



Class Notes

Jonah

Jonah 1-4

Dr. Tim Mackie

The book of Jonah is much more than a children's story—it's a picture of all the beauty, potential, and challenges the Bible presents to its readers. See how this sophisticated literature fits into the larger biblical story and what it means for us today.

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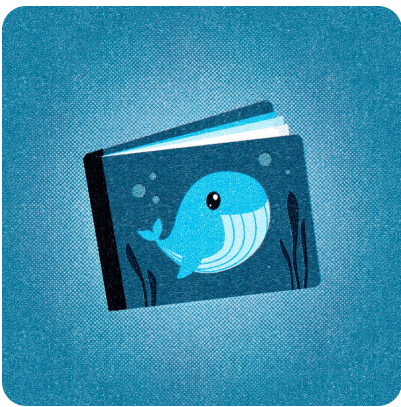
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Module 1: Our Assumptions About the Story of Jonah

SESSIONS 1-5

Address cultural assumptions about the story of Jonah and begin thinking about how this book fits into the larger biblical story.

Session 1: Relearning the Story of Jonah

Key Takeaways

- Reading the Bible well requires unlearning and relearning what the text has to say.
- Jonah is a microcosm of all the beauty, potential, and challenges the Bible represents to its readers.
- Jonah is more than a children's story. It's like a symphony—anyone can sit down and enjoy it, but if you want to learn how it's composed, there are infinite layers of complexity to explore.



This session has no other notes

Reflection Question

What is your experience with the story of Jonah? Are there parts of the story you have typically overlooked or have questions about?

Session 2: How to Read a Text Like the Hebrew Bible

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible, or the Old Testament, defined reality for Jesus.
- The story of the Hebrew Bible is fulfilled in Jesus and brings greater understanding to what Jesus did on Earth.

Exploring Jesus' Bible

The Hebrew Scriptures that Jesus and the apostles would have studied consisted of a three-part collection, called the TaNaK in later Jewish tradition. The arrangement of the books in the TaNaK differs in a few ways from the order of the same collection in modern Christian Bibles.

TaNaK	Christian Old Testament
Torah (The Law) Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy	Pentateuch Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy
Nevi'im (The Prophets) Former Prophets Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings Latter Prophets Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi	History Joshua, Judges, Ruth 1-2 Samuel, 1-2 Kings 1-2 Chronicles Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther
	Poetry Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs
Ketuvim (The Writings) Psalms, Job, Proverbs Ruth, Song of Songs, Ecclesiastes, Lamentations,	Prophets Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations Ezekiel, Daniel
TaNaK Compared with the Christian Old Testament. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

TaNaK	Christian Old Testament
Esther [The <i>Megillot</i>] Daniel, Ezra-Nehemiah, Chronicles	Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi
<i>TaNaK Compared with the Christian Old Testament.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

Reflection Question

Why do you think followers of Jesus should invest time and energy into reading an ancient text like the Hebrew Bible (Old Testament)?

Session 3: Reflecting on How the Hebrew Bible Points to Jesus

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible is meditation literature that asks you to give a lifetime of reflection to its meaning.
- The Hebrew Bible is a diverse collection of literature, but it has been designed into one cohesive story.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

What comes to mind when you consider the Hebrew Bible being connected to Jesus' story?

Session 4: The Main Message of the Hebrew Scriptures

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible is messianic wisdom literature that leads us to understand our need to be rescued by the Messiah, Jesus.
- In 2 Timothy 3:14-17, “good works” refers to seeking the well-being of our neighbors in the name of Jesus.
- We need to build a skill set for reading these texts and examine how we talk about the Hebrew Bible with other people.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

Jesus and Paul teach that the Hebrew Bible is all about a messiah who must pass through death, come out the other side, and create a new humanity (Luke 24:44-47; 2 Tim. 3:14-16). What do you think people in your context think the Hebrew Bible is about? Are there common objections people might have to the Hebrew Bible being about the Messiah and his mission?

Session 5: Reflecting on How To Read the Bible

Key Takeaways

- We're meeting another mind when we read the Bible, so we have to work hard to make sure we're not hearing our own voice reflecting back to us.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

What might it look like for you to embody, reflect, and model the importance of the Hebrew Bible to the people in your context (ministry, church, neighborhood, family, etc.)? How could you invite other people into the story that defined reality for Jesus?



Module 2: The Literary Context of the Book of Jonah

SESSIONS 6-9

Before diving into the book of Jonah, we look at the book's literary context and see how it fits into the overall structure of the Hebrew Bible.

Session 6: Introduction to the Ancient TaNaK Order

Key Takeaways

- TaNaK is an acronym for Torah, Nevi'im, and Ketuvim, the three-part design of the Hebrew Bible. Jesus and other Jewish authors spoke about the Hebrew Bible using this three-part design.
- *Torah* means “teaching” in Hebrew and includes the same first five books as our English Bibles: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy.
- *Nevi'im* means “prophets” in Hebrew and includes Isaiah through Malachi and begins with Joshua through Kings.
- *Ketuvim* means “the writings” in Hebrew and is similar to the poetry section of our English Bibles, but it also includes a few other books such as Ruth and Daniel.

Ancient Evidence for the Shape of the TaNaK

When Jesus alludes to the order of the Hebrew Bible, he assumes a three-part design, which agrees with other contemporary Jewish authors who allude to the ordered sections.

Luke 24:44 NIV*

This is what I told you while I was still with you: Everything must be fulfilled that is written about me in the Torah of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The “blessed one” of [Psalm 1:1-6](#) is portrayed as the ideal Joshua seen in [Joshua 1:7-8](#), “one who meditates on the Torah day and night,” which results in success and a prosperous way.

Luke 11:50-51a NIV

Therefore, this generation will be held responsible for the blood of all the prophets that has been shed since the beginning of the world, from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zechariah, who was killed between the altar and the sanctuary.

Abel was murdered by Cain in [Genesis 4](#), and Zechariah son of Jehoiada was murdered by Joash in [2 Chronicles 24](#), which corresponds to the TaNaK order.

Other published texts in this time period also refer to the three-part design of the TaNaK.

“Many great teachings have been given to us through the Law (*Torah*), and the Prophets (*Nevi'im*), and the others that follow them (*Ketuvim*) ... So my grandfather Yeshua devoted himself especially to the reading of the Law and the Prophets and the other scrolls of our Ancestors.”

Prologue to the Wisdom of Ben Sirach

“The scrolls of Moses, the words of the prophets, and of David.”

Dead Sea Scrolls (4QMMT)

“The laws and the oracles given by inspiration through the prophets and the Psalms, and the other scrolls whereby knowledge and piety are increased and completed.”

Philo of Alexandria (De Vita Contemplativa, 25)

Reflection Question

What are the three parts of the ancient TaNaK order, and what are the main differences when compared to our modern English Bibles?

Session 7: Reflecting on Jonah and the TaNaK Order

Key Takeaways

- The structure of our modern Bibles does not detract from seeing the Hebrew Bible as foreshadowing Jesus' rise, fall, and resurrection.
- Understanding that Jesus read his Bible in the three-part TaNaK structure helps us see what he sees.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

Take a moment to reflect on the structure of the TaNaK and how Jesus describes the message of the Hebrew Bible. What questions come to mind as you ponder the connection between structure and meaning?

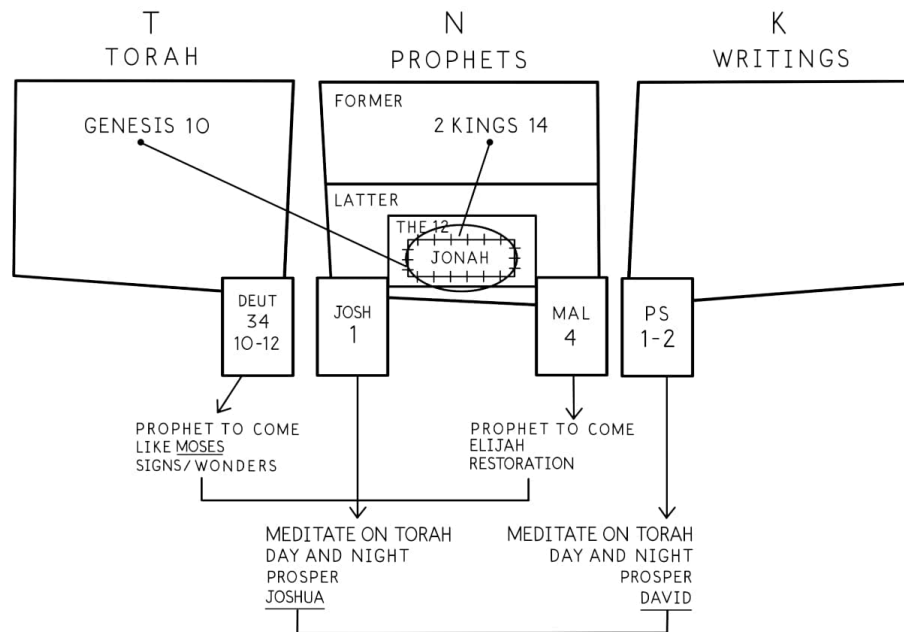
Session 8: The “Seams” of the TaNaK

Key Takeaways

- The seams of the TaNaK, or the beginnings and endings of the major sections, include repeated words and phrases that show the TaNaK is telling one overarching story of Israel’s need for a prophet like Moses and Elijah who will bring life to the nations.
- The Hebrew Bible is meditation literature (Josh. 1; Ps. 1) designed to foster (1) daily reading and pondering about the meaning of these texts, (2) a future hope in the promised prophet who will herald the messianic Kingdom, and (3) a covenantal way of life that is counter-cultural to prevailing world systems.

The Editorial Design of the TaNaK

The three-part shape of the Hebrew Bible isn’t simply a matter of arrangement. Rather, the books themselves have been designed to fit into this particular shape. If you look at the editorial seams of the major sections (remember the technology was papyrus or leather scrolls), you’ll find intentional design clues at the beginning and ending of these sections.



The Shape and Seams of the TaNaK, and Where Jonah Fits In. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Seam 1: The Final Sentences of the Torah and the Opening Sentences of the Nevi'im

- Deuteronomy 34:10-12: Anticipation of a coming Moses-like prophet who was promised but never came.
- Joshua 1:1-9: God's appointed leader, Joshua, who will lead the people into the promised land, must meditate on the Torah day and night to find success.

Seam 2: The Final Sentences of the Nevi'im and the Opening Sentences of the Ketuvim

- Malachi 4:4-6: Anticipation of a coming Elijah-like prophet who will call the people back to the Torah and restore the hearts of Israel before the Day of the Lord.
- Psalms 1-2: The righteous one who will be vindicated in the final judgment is one who meditates on the Torah day and night to find success (Ps. 1). This righteous one is the future messianic king from the line of David, who is appointed by God to rule the nations and overcome evil once and for all (Ps. 2).

Hebrew Meditation Literature

The Hebrew Bible is meditation literature (Josh. 1, Ps. 1) and is designed to foster:

- Daily reading and pondering about the meaning of these texts
- Future hope in the promised prophet who will herald the messianic Kingdom
- A covenantal way of life that is countercultural to the prevailing world systems

Reflection Question

The seams of the TaNaK describe the kind of leader humanity needs. What is this person like?

Session 9: Reflecting on Biblical Patterns

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible trains us, through repeated patterns, to expect humans to fail to live up to their divine calling.
- This repeated pattern shows humanity's need for a divine-human rescuer who will do what only God can do.
- The incarnation of Jesus is not a surprise twist; it's the only possible solution.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

In what ways is it helpful to compare the TaNaK order to the organization of modern Christian Bibles?



Module 3: Hyperlinks and Patterns Between Jonah and the Rest of Scripture

SESSIONS 10-14

Every book in the Hebrew Bible uses coordinated topics and ideas to connect to other books in the Bible—like a hyperlink. Explore some of the hyperlinks between Jonah and the rest of Scripture.

Session 10: Hyperlinks in the Text

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors often use words that are meant to recall other parts of Scripture. In this way, one word or image can be loaded with layers of meaning.
- The scroll of Jonah starts with the Hebrew word for “and.” This signals to readers that Jonah has a bigger context and is connected to what came before.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

The biblical authors often use words or images that are meant to recall other parts of Scripture. How is Jonah hyperlinked to other parts of Scripture, and what effect does that have on the story of Jonah?

Session 11: Reflecting on Nineveh

Key Takeaways

- Nineveh is called "that great city" twice in the Hebrew Bible. The biblical authors use this unique phrase to connect the events in Jonah to the founding of Babylon.
- The Hebrew word *gadol*, translated as "great," means large in size or significance.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

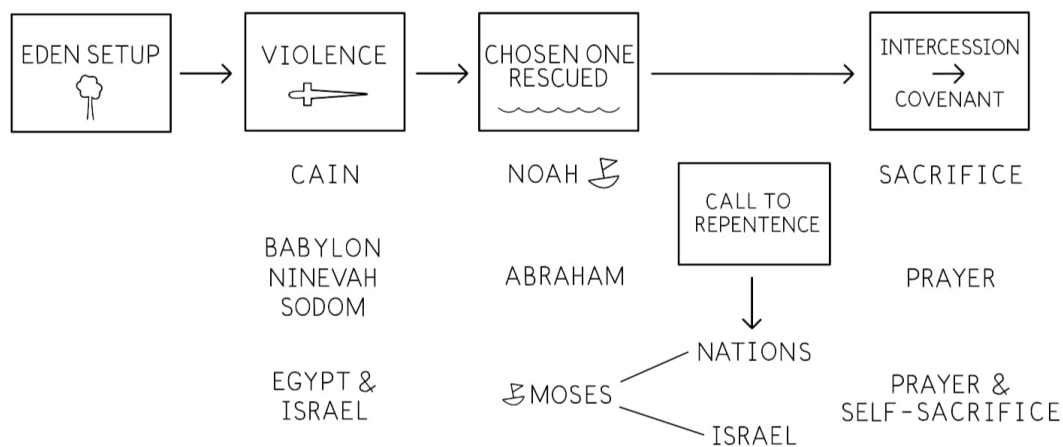
When the Bible calls Nineveh "that great city," does this refer to their glowing track record of representing God's rule?

Session 12: Biblical Patterns the Author Assumes We Know

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible has one storyline that repeats over and over. Knowing this pattern helps us understand the story of Jonah.
- The storyline of the Hebrew Bible is about God choosing a people to bless all the nations and responding to the outcry of violence and evil by rescuing them through the waters. Then, a chosen one intercedes for the wicked so that God's covenant blessing can go out to the nations.

The Main Story of the Hebrew Bible



The Overall Storyline of the Hebrew Bible. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).



This session has no other notes

Reflection Question

Think about the pattern of a chosen one called to intercede for the wicked. Who is the chosen one meant to be in the book of Jonah? How does his story fit or not fit into this pattern?

Session 13: God's Character Summarized

Key Takeaways

- [Exodus 34:6-7](#) is a dense statement of the character of God, and it is the most quoted verse in the Old Testament, including a reference in [Jonah 4](#).
- In this passage, God explains that he offers mercy to sinful people out of his lovingkindness.
- Two important characteristics of God are his justice and his mercy.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

How do you think people in your context view God's character in the Hebrew Bible?

Session 14: Reflecting on God's Character

Key Takeaways

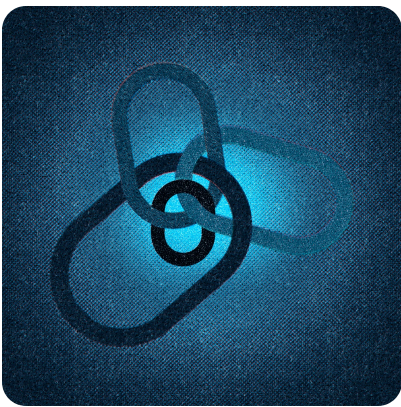
- The book of Jonah helps you build the skills you need to read the rest of the Bible.
- Jonah flees God's call because he doesn't see how God can be merciful and loving and still just.
- A portrait of God being fully just and fully merciful is represented by Jesus on the cross.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

What questions do you have about the aspects of God's character found in Exodus 34:6-7? Do you struggle with the tension between God's justice and mercy? Why or why not?



Module 4: Links Between Literary Units

SESSIONS 15-21

Take a deep dive into the sophisticated literary artistry of the Hebrew Bible before further exploring the book of Jonah.

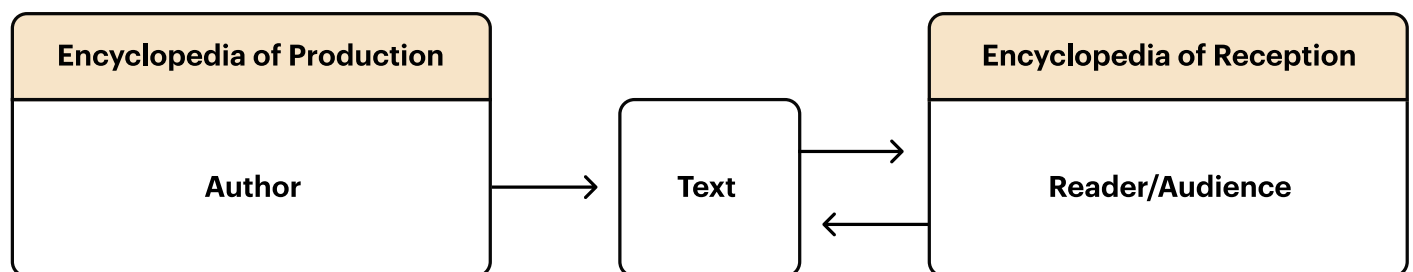
Session 15: Noticing Repeated Words

Key Takeaways

- Although the stories in the Hebrew Bible were written over a long period of time, they are intricately connected to one another.
- The Hebrew Bible is like a quilt where the pieces represent various stories and the thread stitching them together represents repeated words and patterns.
- The point of this quilt of stories replaying and developing the same storyline is for us to see our own lives in these patterns. The stories in the Bible aren't just something we look at—they become what we look through to understand our experiences.

How To Read the Hebrew Scriptures

The Hebrew Bible is an ancient text, and a text is an act of literary communication.



Textual Communication. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

The ideas of our “encyclopedia of production” and “encyclopedia of reception” are from Stefan Alkier’s *Reading the Bible Intertextually*.

Our “encyclopedia” is the mental storehouse of words, ideas, images, and stories that we gather and store in our memories from our first waking moments. Every text we read will be interpreted and understood in light of our current operating encyclopedia. Authors have their encyclopedias from which they produce texts, and readers have encyclopedias through which they process and understand texts.

The model reader who wants to understand an author on their terms will adapt their encyclopedia of reception by learning about the author’s encyclopedia of production.

Where is the meaning located in the text? The text is the literary embodiment of an author’s intended communication.

"[A text-focused approach] sets out to understand not the realities behind the text but the text itself as a pattern of meaning and effect. What does this piece of language ... signify in context? What are the rules governing the transaction between the storyteller or poet and the reader? ... What image of a world does the narrative project? Why does it unfold the action in this particular order and from this particular viewpoint? What is the part played by the omissions, redundancies, ambiguities, alternations between story and summary or elevated and colloquial language? How does the work hang together? In what relationship does each part stand to the whole? To pursue this line of questioning is to make sense of the work as an act of communication, always goal-directed on the writer's part and always requiring interpretive activity on the addressee's. The author wields certain linguistic and literary tools with an eye to certain effects on the reader, while the reader infers a coherent message from the signals, and it is the text itself that mediates between these two, embodying the author's intent and guiding the reader's response."

Sternberg, Meir (1987). [*The Poetics of Biblical Narrative: Ideological Literature and the Drama of Reading*](#). Indiana University Press. 15.

Text vs. Event

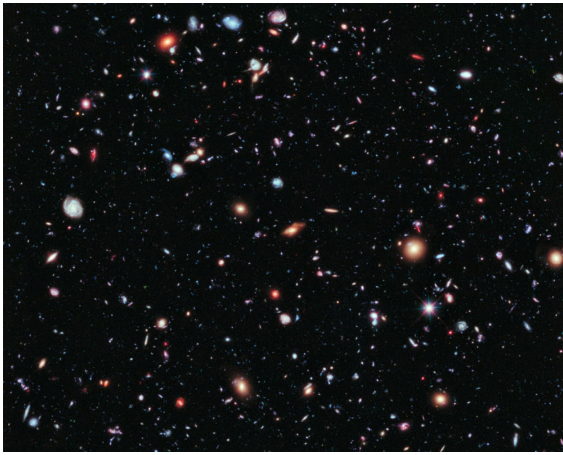
A text provides a literary representation of an object that helps the reader grasp its meaning and significance from a particular perspective.



Magritte, René (1929). *The Treachery of Images*. [Wiki Art](#)

"Ah, the famous pipe. How people reproached me for it! And yet, could you stuff my pipe? No, it's just a representation, is it not? So if I had written on my picture 'This is a pipe,' I'd have been lying!"

Torczyner, Harry (1985). [*Magritte: The True Art of Painting*](#). Abradale/Abrams. 85.



Left: Hubble Telescope (2009). *Hubble Deep Field Image*. ([Wikimedia Commons](#)). Right: van Gogh, Vincent (1889). *The Starry Night*. ([Wikimedia Commons](#)).

Both images are representations of the starry universe portrayed through different media for different purposes, and with different effects on the viewer. Neither one is the starry universe itself ("This is not a pipe."). The Hubble photo represents a maximal realism, while "The Starry Night" employs an impressionistic style. "The Starry Night" conveys the impression and feeling of the night sky as it's relevant to a small human community. It communicates much through minimal detail and uses juxtaposition and contrast (swirling skies vs. geometric human buildings) as well as similarity (blue tones in the sky and on land).

Summary

1. The Hebrew Bible offers a literary representation of Israel's history that claims to be a divinely inspired, prophetic interpretation of Israel's history within the larger context of God's cosmic purposes.
2. The Hebrew Bible is not a history of Israel (or "chronicle of Jonah's exploits"); rather, it is a theological interpretation of Israel's (and Jonah's) story designed to elicit a response from the reader.
3. The Hebrew Bible is a collection of collections, made up of textual materials from all periods of Israel's history, religion, and literature.

Stages in the Process of Making the TaNaK

How does an author make a collection of collections mean something? We must first understand the actual materials used by the biblical authors. The tradition of ancient Israelite literature came into existence through a multi-step process that is still discernible by looking at literary evidence within the texts themselves.

Events



- The life of Abraham, the exodus, the wilderness wanderings, settlement in the land of Canaan, etc.

The Origins of the Bible From a Historical Perspective. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

	Oral Traditions ↘	• The family history of Abraham’s ancestors, the wilderness wanderings • Early songs: Exodus 15, Judges 5, Psalm 29, etc.
	Early Written Traditions ↘	• “This is the scroll of the generations of humanity” (Gen. 5:1) • “The scroll of Jashar” (Josh. 10:13; 2 Sam. 1:18) • “The scroll of the wars of Yahweh” (Num. 21:14)
	Early Collections of Written Traditions ↘	• “The scroll of the deeds of the kings of Israel” (1 Kgs. 14:19, 29, etc.) • “The commentary of the scroll of the kings” (2 Chron. 24:27)
	Proto-Editions of Biblical Books ↘	• “The proverbs of Solomon that the men of Hezekiah compiled” (Prov. 25:1) • “The prayers of David son of Jesse are ended” (Ps. 72:20) • The “Mosaic” Torah (Exod. 21-23 and Deut. 12-26) • First edition of Jeremiah (Jer. 36)
		TaNaK Editions of Biblical Books

The Origins of the Bible From a Historical Perspective. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Each of these stages is worthy of study for historical interest. However, classical orthodox Jewish and Christian theology (i.e., biblical theology) has been based on the final edition of the biblical text, that is, the text of the Hebrew Scriptures in the time of Jesus.

The Family Quilt Metaphor

A quilt made of many preexisting materials can retain the integrity of the earlier materials while giving the new layers meaning when they are set within a larger context and frame of reference.

So now we can ask: What is the matrix of themes and motifs that the author of Jonah assumes we already know?

The Story Behind the Story of Jonah

- Genesis 3-4: Adam, Eve, Cain, and Cain's city of blood
- Genesis 6-11: The generation of the flood and the chosen one (comforter Noah) rescued through the waters to intercede through sacrifice. God relents, but humanity goes on to make another city.
- Genesis 12, 18-19: Abraham brought out of Babylon, intercedes on behalf of Sodom.
- Exodus 2-3, 14-15: God rescues Moses through the waters (in an ark). Moses then meets with God on Sinai (in fire) and is commissioned to confront the king of Egypt. Moses resists but eventually goes. Israel flees and is rescued through the waters on dry land, and they come to fear Yahweh and believe in him.
- Exodus 32-34: God's rescued people make an idol. God threatens to bring a flood of judgment upon them, but Moses steps in to offer intercession, appealing to Abraham and then offering his own life as a sacrifice of atonement. God forgives the people, and Moses sees Yahweh and learns of his character.
- 1 Kings 17-19: In Ahab's sinful generation, God sends Elijah to announce the opposite of a flood (a drought). He leads Israel to meet with God in fire on Mount Carmel, but he is ultimately unsuccessful in turning Israel back to Yahweh. He goes to the wilderness, and instead of interceding and offering himself, he asks God to kill him. Then he goes to Mount Sinai and has a pity party in a dialogue with God. He is an anti-Moses.
- Jeremiah 18, 26: Jeremiah is sent as a prophetic intercessor to Israel to tell them that if they repent, God will relent and not bring disaster. But the Israelites reject him and bring down innocent blood upon themselves.

Core Themes of the TaNaK Found in Jonah

- Humans are violent and destructive and bring the blood guilt of the innocent upon themselves, compelling God to bring judgment.
- God wants to bless humanity instead of destroying them, so he makes and fulfills his promise to rescue humanity by raising up a deliverer/intercessor (Noah, Abraham, Moses, Elijah, Jeremiah) who will appeal to his mercy.
- Human intercessors are problematic, sometimes doing their job (Noah, Abraham, Moses) but other times failing to persuade their audience (Jeremiah) or failing personally (Elijah).
- The portraits of human intercessors point forward to the ultimate prophetic intercessor like Moses.
- The book of Jonah also points forward to this hope (as Jesus understood in Matthew 12:40), but it does so by creating an inverted parody portrait of Jonah as the anti-Moses prophet.

Reflection Question

Although the stories in the Hebrew Bible were written over a long period of time, they are intricately connected to one another. How is this similar or different from how you and those in your context typically view the Bible?

Session 16: How to Read an Ancient Text

Key Takeaways

- We can use three strategies to understand the literary design of a work: Identifying the contextual anchors (what the author assumes we know), identifying the literary units, and identifying repeated words.
- A “lead-word” is a significant repeated word in a text that helps us understand the meaning of the text.

Lessons in Literature

Literature is a form of literary communication through which an author conveys a “what” (the message) through a carefully and intentionally crafted “how” (an artistically formed/shaped literary work).

The poetics of biblical literature are the “how” of Israelite literature.

The unique set of literary techniques, conventions, and strategies employed by the biblical authors (narrative, poetry, and discourse) have a particular stylistic profile that is both similar to and different from other ancient Near Eastern literature.

Recommended Resources

- Robert Alter, [*The Art of Biblical Narrative*](#)
- Adele Berlin, [*Poetics and Interpretation of Biblical Narrative*](#)
- Shimon Bar-Efrat, [*Narrative Art in the Bible*](#)
- Meir Sternberg, [*The Poetics of Biblical Narrative*](#)

The Epic Literary Genre

This genre can be defined as a larger collection of smaller narratives interwoven with poems and genealogies and arranged into movements that exhibit a high degree of repetition and patterning.

Identifying Contextual Anchors

What does the author assume we know before we start reading this work? The opening words of biblical literary works usually give some indicator of the context within which to understand the text.

For example, Jonah 1:1-2 invites the reader into a set of hyperlinks related to the backstory of Jonah and of Nineveh.

Literary Analysis

Study the literary features of a book in order to determine the boundaries of literary units (see David A. Dorsey, [The Literary Structure of the Old Testament: A Commentary on Genesis-Malachi](#), chapter 2).

Defining Literary Units

Read carefully and identify introductions, conclusions, and changes of setting, character, or time to find the words that give clues to the narrative's design on the micro-level.

Identifying Repeated Words

Read, re-read, use multiple translations (especially more literal ones) or an interlinear or a concordance, and then re-read some more!

"A 'lead-word' is a word that repeats significantly in a text or group of texts, and by following these repetitions, one is able to decipher or grasp a meaning of the text ... The repetition may not be of the same exact word, but of the word-root ... which intensifies the dynamic action of the repetition ... if you imagine the entire text stretched out before you, you can sense waves moving back and forth between key words, matching the rhythm of the text ... it is one of the most powerful means of conveying meaning."

Buber, Martin (2012). [Schriften zur Bibelübersetzung](#). Gütersloher Verlagshaus. 1131.

An example of repeated words in Jonah is the use of "fear" and "hurl" in chapter 1 and the use of "call out" in chapters 1-3.

"One of the most imposing barriers that stands between modern readers and the imaginative subtlety of the biblical authors is the prominence of repetition. We are accustomed to stories in which repetition is far less obvious, and so this is probably the feature of biblical narrative that looks most 'primitive' to the modern eye ... In order to appreciate the artfulness of this kind of repetition, a modern reader has to cultivate a new, even opposite, set of expectations than what they bring to literary works. Modern stories usually attempt to mimic reality by giving us large amounts of information that is not crucial to the plot, so that one is expected to detect the repetition of key themes and words among lots of other background noise. Biblical narrative is the opposite. Here we are confronted with an extremely spare narrative with a high degree of repetition and similarity, and what we are expected to notice is the small but revealing differences among the sea of similarities. This is how new meanings emerge in pattern of expectations created by explicit repetition."

Alter, Robert (2011). [The Art Of Biblical Narrative](#). Basic Books. 96-97.

Wordplay and Paronomasia

"Biblical authors often employ wordplays upon a name or a play made with sounds, but they also have significant links between stories offered by names and puns ... there is a wide scope of possibilities: sound effects, alliteration, word play, riddles, concealed meanings, key-word motifs. The biblical writers utilize these potentialities within literary units in different ways ... The biblical authors are creative and very

imaginative with this technique, pushing their word and sound associations far beyond the norms of spoken language. Here ‘poetic license’ is indeed the name of the game.”

Garsiel, Moshe (1991). *Biblical Names: A Literary Study of Midrashic Derivations and Puns*. Bar-Ilan University Press. 19-20.

An example of this type of wordplay in Jonah is the use of “go down/sleep/make vows” in chapter 1.

Techniques of Biblical Composition: Juxtaposition

Placing two narratives side by side so that their proximity encourages the reader to compare and contrast their content (see Zakovitch, *Through the Looking Glass: Reflection/Inversion Stories in Genesis*) is called juxtaposition.

An example of juxtaposition from Jonah can be seen in how the phrases “call out” (sailors vs. Jonah in chapters 1-3) and “go down” (sailors’ vows in chapter 1 vs. Jonah’s vows in chapter 2) are used in the story.

Genesis 2-4 as Mutually Interpreting Temptation Narratives

Narratives	Genesis 2-3: Adam and Eve	Genesis 4: Cain and Abel
Human given a significant choice for an unstated reason	2:16-17: “From any tree of the garden you may eat, but from the tree of knowing good and evil you should not eat, because the day you eat from it you will surely die.”	4:5-7: But Yahweh did not regard Cain’s offering, and Cain was very angry ... Yahweh said, “Why are you angry, and why has your face fallen? Isn’t it the case that if you do good , you will be lifted up?”
Human tempted by an animal	3:1: Now the snake was more crafty than any creature of the field ... And he said to the woman, “Did God really say not to eat from any tree in the garden?”	4:7: “But if you don’t do good, sin is crouching at the door , and it’s desire is for you.”
Human gives into temptation with destructive consequences	3:6: When the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and desirable to the eyes, and desirable for gaining wisdom, she took ...	4:5: And Cain was very angry 4:8: And Cain spoke to Abel his brother, and while they were in the field Cain rose up against Abel his brother and murdered him”
God shows up to ask a question	3:9: And God called out to the human and said, “ Where are you (איכה)?”	4:9: And God said to Cain, “ Where is your (אי) brother Abel?”

Genesis 2-4 Temptation Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Narratives	Genesis 2-3: Adam and Eve	Genesis 4: Cain and Abel
	3:12: And God said to the woman, " What have you done (מה עשית)?"	4:10: And God said, " What have you done (מה עשית)?"
The human dodges the question	3:12: The human said, "The woman who you set with me, she gave to me and I ate."	4:9: "I don't know! Am I my brother's keeper?"
The perpetrator is cursed	3:14: God said to the serpent, "Because you have done this, you are cursed from every beast and from every creature of the field" 3:17 " Cursed is the ground because of you"	4:11: "And now you are cursed from the ground ..."
Working the ground will now be more difficult	3:17b: "in pain you will eat from the ground " 3:23 And God sent him from the garden of Eden to work the ground .	4:12: "For you will work the ground , and it will no longer give its strength to you."
The human is banished from the divine presence	3:24: And [God] banished the human and he camped east of the garden of Eden ...	4:14: "Behold, you have banished me from the face of the ground and from your presence." 4:16: And Cain settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden .
Genesis 2-4 Temptation Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

In his book, *The Art of Biblical Narrative*, Robert Alter quotes a famous Russian film director in his section on biblical poetry and juxtaposition.

"It remains true to this day, that the juxtaposition of two separate shots by splicing them together resembles not so much a simple sum of one shot plus one shot. Rather, it resembles a new creation. The result is qualitatively distinguishable from each of the elements viewed separately ... This is the effect of the montage: each piece exists no longer as something unrelated, but as a given particular representation of a larger common theme that now penetrates all of the shot-pieces. This juxtaposition of these partial details calls to life and forces into light any general qualities that each piece expresses that might bind them together into a single whole, a single image that the spectator experiences."

Alter, Robert (2011). [The Art Of Biblical Narrative](#). Basic Books. 24.

Reflection Question

What kinds of things should we pay attention to in order to understand a text's literary design? Which of these would be most helpful for you or others in your context?

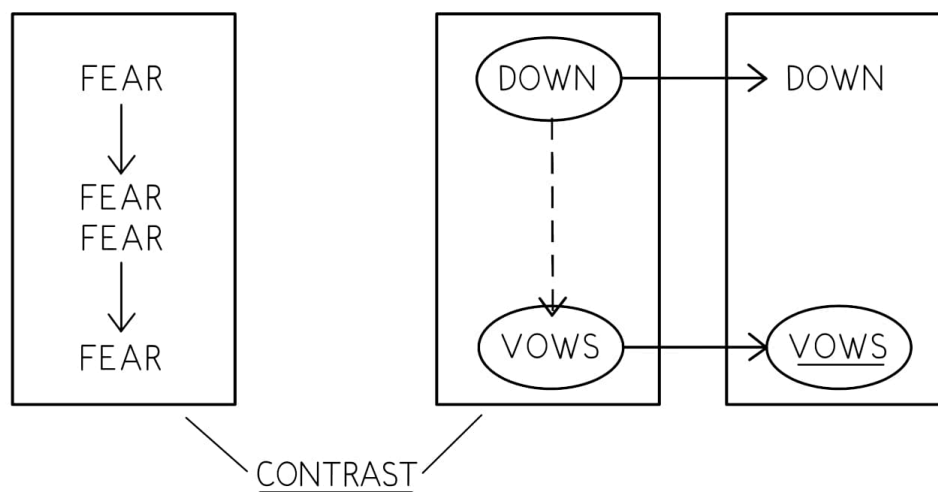
Session 17: Repeated Words and Implications for Literary Design

Key Takeaways

- Biblical narrative achieves maximal characterization through minimal details. The authors do a lot with a little, which is why everything matters.
- Symmetrical design is when repeated words link passages that are not side by side, prompting the reader to compare the passages. All four chapters of Jonah are symmetrically designed.

The Flow of Jonah

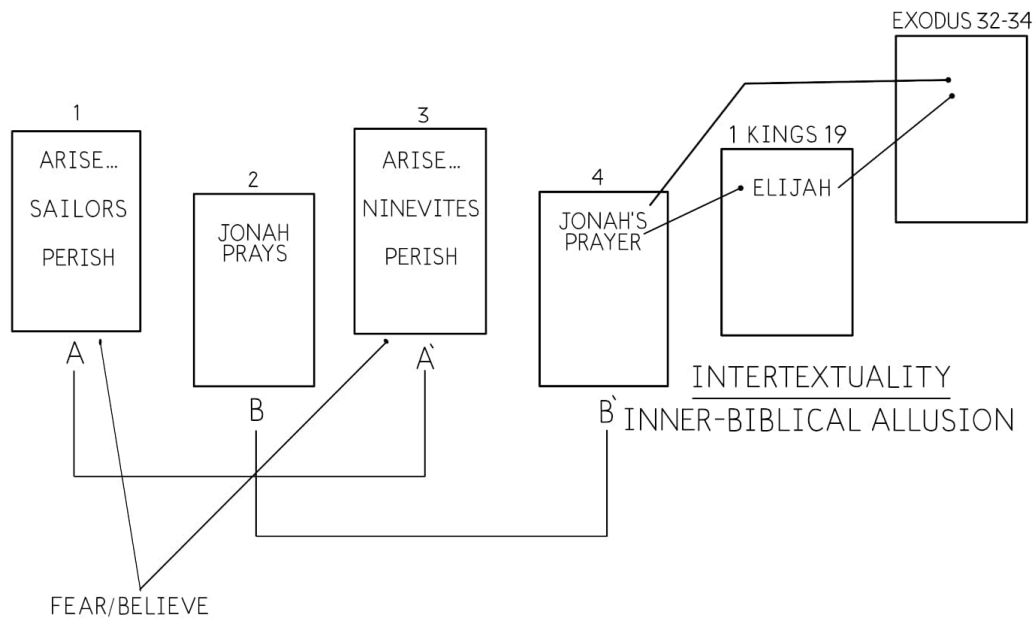
Repeated words in Jonah's literary units develop a thematic flow and lend momentum to the story arc.



Contrasts in the Design of Jonah 1. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Repeated words in distant literary units allow the reader to connect parts of a story that are not immediately adjacent. The biblical authors use this technique to draw together distant literary units within a scroll, or even

connect one scroll to another.



The Macro-Design of Jonah. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Reflection Question

What are some of the words (wordplays or themes) repeated in Jonah 1? Which might be the most significant and helpful to highlight for those in your context?

Session 18: Hyperlinks in the Hebrew Bible

Key Takeaways

- Repeated words can signal a theme and link chapters that are in sequence to each other or in different parts of the Hebrew Bible.
- The portrait of Jonah in [chapter 4](#) is hyperlinked to the portrait of Elijah in [1 Kings 19](#). The Elijah story itself also hyperlinks to the golden calf story in Exodus.
- The Hebrew Bible is meditation literature for a lifetime. Every word, every episode, and every scene is intentional—you'll never stop noticing threads and connections.

Literary Symmetry

This same kind of juxtaposition happens between literary units that are not side by side but connected by literary symmetry and key word links.

An example of this from Jonah can be seen in the use of “arise, go call” in [chapters 1](#) and [3](#), in the use of “pray” in chapters [2](#) and [4](#), and in the use of “perish” in chapters 1 and 3.

“Prose narrative naturally expects linear reading, i.e., progressive reading from one unit to the next (from A to B to C, etc.) as the story unfolds through the text. Symmetrically organized narrative offers additional avenues for interpretive access as well ... because it invites multi-level comparison. We can examine why units are placed next to one another (A and B), but also are invited to mentally juxtaposed symmetrically paired units (A and A'). This pattern also invites comparison between entire matching sequences (ABC and A'B'C'). Different symmetrical patterns can indicate reversal (ABCDC'B'A'), progression (ABC/A'B'C'), or even intensification (ABC/A'B'C'D).”

Walsh, Jerome (2001). [Style and Structure in Biblical Hebrew Narrative](#). Liturgical Press. 12.

Chapter 1

God - Jonah - The Sailors

- 1:1-2 "And the word of Yahweh came to Jonah ... 'Arise, go to Nineveh ...'"
- 1:3 "And Jonah arose to flee to Tarshish."
- 1:5 Sailors: They were afraid and every man cried out to his god.
- 1:6 Captain: "Call out to your God; perhaps God will consider and we will not perish."
- 1:9 Jonah: "I fear Yahweh, the God ... who made the sea and the dry land."

Jonah "went down" 3X

The sailors "sacrifice" and "vow vows"

- 1:13 The sailors rowed to turn back to land.
- 1:15 They picked up Jonah and threw him into the sea, and the sea stopped its raging.
- 1:16 And the men feared Yahweh a great fear ...

Chapter 2

Jonah's Prayer to God

- 2:1 "And Jonah prayed to God ... from the deep abyss."
- 1:17 God "appoints" a fish to swallow Jonah.
- 2:1 Jonah is "delivered" by the fish's belly.

"I went down to the underworld."

"I will sacrifice to you; I will pay my vows."

- 2:2-9 Jonah offers thanks to God for saving his life.
- 2:9 Jonah praises God for offering his salvation.
- 2:10 The fish responds to Jonah's prayer by vomiting.

Chapter 3

God - Jonah - The Ninevites

- 3:1-2 "And the word of Yahweh came to Jonah ... 'Arise, go to Nineveh ...'"
- 3:3 And Jonah arose and went to Nineveh.
- 3:5 Ninevites: The people believed in God and called a fast.
- 3:8-9 King: "Let them call out to God ... he may turn and relent ... and we will not perish!"
- 3:4 Jonah: "Forty days and Nineveh will be turned over!"

Will God repent from his heat-anger?

They turned back from their evil ways.

- 3:8 "Let each one turn back from his wicked way ..."
- 3:10 "And God relented concerning the evil which he said he would do to them, and he did not do it."
- 4:1 "And it was evil to Jonah, a great evil."

Chapter 4

Jonah's Prayer to God

- 4:2, 5 "And Jonah prayed to God ... in the east of the city."
- 4:6-8 God "appoints" the plant, worm, and wind: to shade Jonah, eat a plant, and burn Jonah.
- 4:5 Jonah is "delivered" by his "shelter."

And Jonah had heat-anger.

I knew that you'd repent concerning evil!

- 4:3, 8 Jonah asks God to take his life.
- 4:2 Jonah criticizes God for offering his compassion.
- 4:7 The worm responds to Jonah's prayer by eating.

Literary Techniques for Analyzing Literary Design and Thematic Development

Intertextual Hyperlinks and Dynamic Analogies

The biblical authors regularly invite comparison and analogies between different sections of the Hebrew Scriptures. They do this in a manner similar to hyperlinks on a web page, where a key word or well-known allusive phrase will signal to the reader that the other text is meant to be recalled and connected thematically to the present text.

1 Kings 19: Elijah	Jonah 1-4
Elijah flees from Jezebel after defeating the prophets of Baal on Mt. Carmel	Jonah flees from God's call to go to Nineveh
Elijah walks one day into the wilderness (19:4a)	Jonah walks one day into Nineveh (3:4) Jonah goes east of Nineveh (4:5)
Elijah "asked for his life, to die (וישאל את־נפשו למות)" (19:4b)	"And now, Yahweh, please take my life (נפשי) from me, for good is my death more than my life" (4:3) "And he asked for his life, to die (וישאל את־נפשו למות)" (4:8)
"And he lay down and he slept (וישכב וישן), and look, an angel touching him, and he said, 'Arise (קום), eat!'" (19:5)	"And [Jonah] lay down and he slept (וישכב וירדם) ... And the captain said ... 'Arise (קום) call on your God!'" (1:5-6)
Elijah journeys 40 days to Mt. Horeb (Mount Sinai) (19:8)	Jonah announces 40 days until Nineveh's destruction (3:4)
God asks Elijah two times why he has come to Mt. Horeb (19:9, 13)	God asks two times if it is good that Jonah is angry at his mercy (4:4, 9)
Elijah gives the same exaggerated, self-pitying answer two times (19:10, 14)	Jonah gives the same pathetic and selfish answer two times (4:2, 9)
Narrative Analogy Between Elijah and Jonah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

1 Kings 19: Elijah	Jonah 1-4
God communicates with Elijah through symbolic natural phenomena (wind, earthquake, lightning) (19:11-12)	God communicates with Jonah through symbolic natural phenomena (plant, worm, wind) (4:6-8)
God counters Elijah's self-pity: You are not the only faithful Israelite, I have 7,000 others (19:18)	God counters Jonah's self-pity: You had pity on this plant, shouldn't I have pity on a great city? (4:10-11)
<i>Narrative Analogy Between Elijah and Jonah.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Exodus 14:31	The Sailors and Ninevites
After the Israelites are rescued from the sea	Jonah is rescued from the sea
And the Israelites saw the great hand which Yahweh acted against Egypt and the people feared Yahweh (וִירָאוּ הָעָם אֶת־יְהוָה) and they believed in Yahweh (וַיֵּאֱמִינוּ בַיהוָה) and in Moses his servant.	1:16: And the sailors feared Yahweh (וִירָאוּ ... אֶת־יְהוָה) a great fear ...
	3:5: And the men of Nineveh believed in God (וַיֵּאֱמִינוּ בֵּאלֹהִים).
<i>Dynamic Analogy in Jonah.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Criteria for identifying intertextual hyperlinks (Leonard, 2008)

1. Clusters of shared words or phrases
2. Shared language that consists of distinct vocabulary
3. Shared language within thematically similar contexts
4. Shared language between units that are united by other literary strategies (similar plot, themes, settings)

Inversion/Reflection Stories

This is “a strategy used by biblical narrators to aid the reader in evaluating characters ... It’s one of the many instances of intertextuality so common in biblical literature. The narrators use many overt allusions to other narratives known to them and to their audience ... in order to shape a character as the antithesis of a character in another narrative. The new creation awakens in the reader undeniable associations to the source-story; the relationship between the new narrative and its source is like that between an image and its mirrored reflection: the reflection inverts the storyline of the original narrative ... The discerning reader will consider the implicit relation between the two narratives—the original and its reflection—and observe how the new character behaves contrary to the character upon which he or she is modeled. The reader is being asked to evaluate the new hero in light of the model, both with regard to action and to lack of action.

In addition, the comparison created between the two stories sheds new light on the source story and its protagonist. I call these 'inverted' stories reflection stories.”
Zakovitch, Yair (1993). [Through the Looking Glass: Reflections/Inversions of Genesis Stories in the Bible](#). Brill.

Narrative Analogy and Design Patterns

Robert Alter gives the example of cowboy western films. What if 1,200 years from now, post-apocalyptic archaeologists discover an old Hollywood film vault with dozens of old western films? They'd watch and analyze them and notice patterns.

“In eleven films, the sheriff hero has the same anomalous neurological trait of hyperreflexivity—no matter what the situation in which his adversaries confront him, he is always able to pull his gun out its holster and fire before they can, even if they're already poised with their own weapons ... But, in the twelfth film, the sheriff has an injured arm and instead of a pistol he uses a rifle that he carries, slung over his back ... Contemporary viewers of westerns recognize the convention without even having to name it as such. Much of our pleasure in watching westerns derives from our awareness that the hero, however sinister the dangers looming ahead, leads a charmed life that he will always in the end prove himself more successful than his enemies ... For us, the repetitive pattern across all these cinematic works is not an enigma to be explained, but a necessary condition for telling a story within expected conventions of the film medium. With our easy knowledge of the patterns, we naturally see the point of the twelfth sheriff, and we can spot the pattern of the quick-draw sheriff by its absence.”

Alter, Robert (2011). [The Art Of Biblical Narrative](#). Basic Books.

Symphonic Development of Themes Through Narrative Analogy

“A musical approach to Scripture encompasses a number of aspects, each of which can help us see Scripture in a fresh light ... One aspect of the music metaphor is the relationship between melody and harmony. The Bible has a clear storyline, a melody, but it also has a range of individual and corporate stories that run together, sometimes taking center stage, sometimes fading into the background, providing harmony and counterpoint, treble and bass, height and depth, in such a way that no single writer (or musician) could possibly represent it all. Studying the Bible is about exploring the detail of the harmony — Why is the oboe, or Obadiah, doing that, and how does it contribute to the whole piece?—without losing sight of the melody ... Another (and more subtle) aspect is the interplay between rhythm and meter. Meter is the underlying time structure of a piece—one, two, three, four, one, two, three, four—and although it may vary within the piece, it provides a grounding in time, a sense of orientation, for the listener. Rhythm is the structure of the sound you actually hear— boom, ba-cha, boom, boom, ba-cha— which may involve a number of notes in one beat, or a number of beats without notes. The rhythm rides the meter like a surfer rides a wave, playing, doing its own thing, but always mindful of and constrained by the steady movement underneath. As the Bible commences with its overture, we hear a melody, and a regular rhythm begins. As things develop, various harmonies and disharmonies arise ... leaving us listeners to wonder what the Composer is doing. And a good Composer allows dissonance to create anticipation for the right time to heal it. Then the melody returns, cutting through the cacophony and bringing a temporary sense of resolution. To someone who has never heard the piece before, some moments can even sound like the symphony is fully resolved and is about to finish (a new reader of the Bible could easily think the tension is resolved, for instance, upon the entrance into the Promised Land or David's coronation). Yet these

temporary resolutions produce tensions of their own, which point forward to more complexities, and beyond them, to further resolutions. Throughout the Bible, as time metronomically marches on, the rhythms of Scripture continue to be accented, with particular days and festivals highlighting rest and freedom, law and atonement. But every bar, every cadence, every pause, heightens the sense that the piece is still incomplete. Eventually, after an uncomfortably long silence, the score builds to a massive crescendo in Jesus the Messiah, as the various themes come together and resolve in a fashion that nobody could have quite imagined, but yet seems completely natural ... Only at the finale, when the Christ-crescendo is recapitulated and the instruments are joined by earthly and angelic choirs, do we ultimately see the full scope of the Composer's vision. As such, a musical reading of Scripture does more justice to the way Scripture actually works. Scriptural typology is more like a piece of music: familiar themes like temple, kingdom, exodus, judgment, and sacrifice keep recurring, but always slightly differently. The judgment of Jerusalem is not just a 'picture' or 'shadow' of the last day; nor is it simply a dramatic 'event' that happens once and then is no more. It is somehow a part of the future judgment, a foretaste of it, and yet at the same time historically distinct from it. The final resolution, when it comes, is both familiar and new at the same time. It is, in that sense, musical."

Roberts, Alastair J. and Wilson, Andrew (2018). [*Echoes of Exodus: Tracing Themes of Redemption Through Scripture*](#). Crossway.

A Series of Questions To Ask of Every Literary Unit

1. What is the literary design of the unit?
2. What are the key words and wordplay within each literary unit?
3. What are the relationships and links to the juxtaposed literary units?
4. What are the relationships and links to symmetrically-paired units?
5. What are the intertextual relationships and links within the unit?
6. What are the relationships and links to inner-book patterns?
7. What are the relationships and links to inner-TaNaK patterns?

Reflection Question

How is Jonah like Elijah or Moses? How is he not like them? How do you think these similarities or differences affect our perspective on the character of Jonah?

Session 19: Reflecting on Seeing the Hyperlinks

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible gives us a realistic portrait of the human condition through a litany of stories that build on the Eden narrative. And ultimately, this portrait draws our attention to Jesus.
- To identify hyperlinks between stories, look for clusters of shared words or phrases, shared language that consists of distinct vocabulary, shared language within thematically similar contexts, and shared language between units that are united by other literary strategies (similar plot, themes, settings).



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

What are different ways you can invite the people in your context into an honest recognition of their desperate need for someone to do for them what they cannot do for themselves?

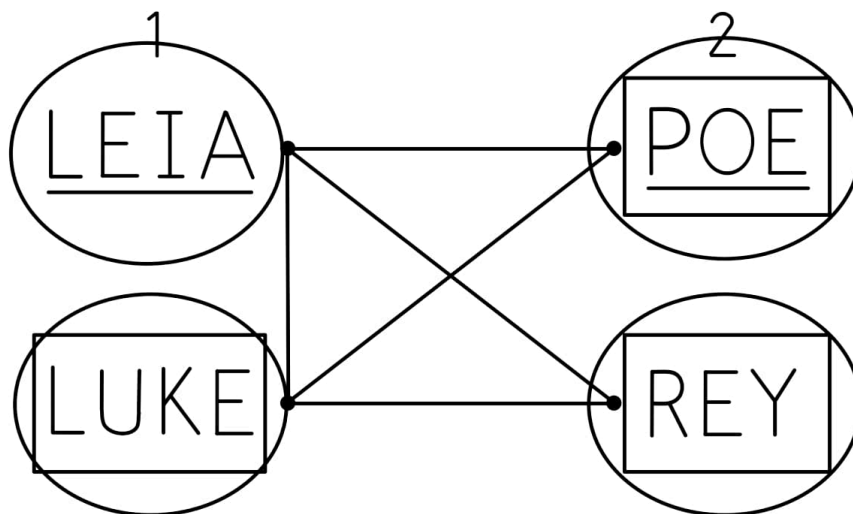
Session 20: Hyperlinks in *Star Wars* and in Jonah

Key Takeaways

- Universal narratives, like the ones in the Bible, help us identify with characters and their stories, connecting them to our own stories.

Relationships Between *Star Wars* Characters

In the *Star Wars* movies, characters are given similar characteristics or narrative moments in order to create plot tension and expectation. The viewer is intended to pick up on these similarities and begin to connect, compare, and contrast these characters so that the viewer is drawn deeper into the story. The Bible's authors utilize similar storytelling techniques in crafting the biblical narrative.



Relationships Between Star Wars Characters. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).



This session has no other notes

Reflection Question

Tim uses examples from *The Lord of the Rings* and *Star Wars* to illustrate how different characters can be hyperlinked to convey meaning, similar to how the sailors and Ninevites are linked in the book of Jonah. Are there other examples that would be helpful for your own context?

Session 21: Reflecting on Expectations Created by Hyperlinks

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors communicate in a way that is multi-layered, sophisticated, and designed to be understood after multiple readings.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

How do we know when the biblical authors are alluding to other stories or themes in the Bible?



Module 5: Exploring Jonah

Chapter 1

SESSIONS 22-28

Wade into the first chapter of Jonah using the literary techniques we explored in previous modules.

Session 22: Why Does Jonah Flee to Tarshish?

Key Takeaways

- Concentric symmetry is when the center of a movement acts as a moment of emphasis or highlight.
- Jonah was the last prophet to prophecy the restoration of Israel's borders to an Eden-like proportion, but that was all reversed by Babylon in the next generation.
- All mentions of "the ships of Tarshish" in the Hebrew Bible are negative. Tarshish is the place people go to build their false Edens.

Jonah's Commission: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 1:1-3

¹ The word of the Lord came to Jonah the son of Amittai saying,

² " **Arise** ,
go to Nineveh the great city
and call out against it,
for their wickedness has come up before me."

a ³ And Jonah **arose** to flee **to Tarshish from before the face of Yahweh** .

b **And he went down** to Joppa,

c and he found a ship

d which was **going** to **Tarshish**

c' and he paid the fare

b' **and he went down** into it

a' to **go** with them **to Tarshish from before the face of Yahweh** .

Jonah 1:1-3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019)

Jonah's Name (1:1)

"Jonah, son of Amittai" = "dove, son of faithfulness"

Faithfulness = אֱמֶתִי / yonah = dove / יוֹנָה

Jonah, Prophet of God's Mercy and Israel's Restoration

Jonah first appears in 2 Kings 14:25-26, where he prophesied that the borders of Israel would be restored to their original borders from the days of Solomon, which happened during the reign of Jeroboam II. However, the narrator also makes clear that Jeroboam II “did evil in the eyes of Yahweh” in perpetuating the sins of Jeroboam I (2 Kgs. 14:24), so there is more than meets the eye here.

Jonah’s Prophecy and God’s Mercy on Sinful Israel

Narrative	2 Kings 13: Reign of Jehoahaz	2 Kings 14: Reign of Jeroboam II
Apostate King of Northern Israel	13:2: [Jehoahaz] did evil in the eyes of Yahweh and he followed the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, which he caused Israel to sin.	14:24: [Jeroboam II] did evil in the eyes of Yahweh, he did not turn away from the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, which he caused Israel to sin.
Yahweh’s Response	Judgment and Oppression 13:3: And the anger of Yahweh was hot against Israel and he gave them into the hand of Hazael king of Aram and into the hand of Ben-Hadad son of Hazael ... 13:22: Now Hazael king of Aram had oppressed Israel all the days of Jehoahaz.	Blessing and Victory?! 14:25: He restored the border of Israel from the entrance of Hamath as far as the Sea of the Arabah, according to the word of the Lord, the God of Israel, which he spoke through his servant Jonah the son of Amittai, the prophet, who was of Gath-hepher.
Repentance of the King	13:4a: Then Jehoahaz appeased the face of Yahweh and Yahweh listened to him.	No repentance!
Divine Mercy	13:4b: Because [Yahweh] saw the oppression of Israel, which the king of Aram oppressed them. 13:23a: But Yahweh was gracious to them and had compassion on them and turned toward them because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob , and he would not destroy them ...	14:26-27a: For the Lord saw the affliction of Israel, which was very bitter; for there was neither bond nor free, nor was there any helper for Israel. The Lord did not say that he would blot out the name of Israel from under heaven ...

Jonah’s Prophecy and God’s Mercy on Sinful Israel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Narrative	2 Kings 13: Reign of Jehoahaz	2 Kings 14: Reign of Jeroboam II
Provision of a Deliverer	13:5: And Yahweh provided for Israel a deliverer and they went out from under the hand of Aram and the sons of Israel sat in their tents as in former times.	14:27b: But he delivered them by the hand of Jeroboam the son of Joash.
Jonah's Prophecy and God's Mercy on Sinful Israel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

In the sequence of 2 Kings 13-14, we have two contrasting generations of Israelite kings. Jehoahaz is wicked, but he appeals to Yahweh's mercy (in the language of Exodus 34:6), so Yahweh delivers Israel in his generation. Contrast this with Jeroboam II, who is also wicked but does not repent, yet Yahweh blesses him with victory and divine mercy with the prophetic support of Jonah ben Amittai.

The author of Jonah assumes a knowledge of this section of 2 Kings and builds his portrait of Jonah in light of this story of undeserved divine mercy to sinful kingdoms.

“If God just goes around forgiving everybody all the time, what’s the point of doing anything? If disobedience goes cavalierly unpunished, then the idea of obedience ceases to have meaning, and this is why Jonah ends up in the grip of a deathwish in Jonah ch. 4 ... [I]n Jonah’s perception, the deity has sovereign power over everything but himself, a situation that allows sin to flourish unchecked and sinners (like Jeroboam or the Ninevites) to reap rewards.”

Muldoon, Catherine (2016). “In Defense of Divine Justice: An Intertextual Approach to the Book of Jonah.” *Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*, vol. 16. 120-121.

Jonah’s Prophecy and the Garden of Eden

The restoration of the borders in 2 Kings 14:24-26 links back to the borders of Israel realized only in the time of Solomon, which themselves go back to the land borders promised to Abraham in Genesis 15, and even further back to the borders of Eden in Genesis 2.

Genesis 2:10-14 NASB

¹⁰ Now a river flowed out of Eden to water the garden; and from there it divided and became four rivers. ¹¹ The name of the first is Pishon; it flows around the whole land of Havilah, where there is gold. ¹² The gold of that land is good; the bdellium and the onyx stone are there. ¹³ The name of the second river is Gihon; it flows around the whole land of Cush. ¹⁴ The name of the third river is Tigris; it flows east of Assyria. And the fourth river is the Euphrates.

1 Kings 4:21 NASB

Now Solomon ruled over all the kingdoms **from the river to the land of the Philistines and to the border of Egypt**; they brought tribute and served Solomon all the days of his life.

Genesis 15:18 NASB

On that day the LORD made a covenant with Abram, saying,
"To your descendants I have given this land,
from the river of Egypt as far as the great river, the river Euphrates:"

1 Kings 8:65 NIV

So Solomon observed the festival at that time, and all Israel with him—a vast assembly, people **from Lebo Hamath to the Wadi of Egypt**.

Joshua 1:4 NIV

Your territory will extend **from the desert to Lebanon, and from the great river, the Euphrates**—all the Hittite country—to the Mediterranean Sea in the west.

2 Kings 14:25 NIV

[Jeroboam ben Joash] was the one who restored the boundaries of Israel **from Lebo Hamath to the Dead Sea**, in accordance with the word of the LORD, the God of Israel, spoken through his servant Jonah son of Amittai, the prophet from Gath Hepher.

These links are all connected to the promise to Abraham, that his seed would inherit a land whose borders resemble the land encompassed by the rivers of Eden in Genesis 2. These borders are what Joshua is told to possess and what Solomon reigns over for a short period until losing the north to Aram ([1 Kgs. 11:23-25](#)). Ironically, it is Jeroboam II who restores the Eden-like borders of Israel, as prophesied by Jonah son of Amittai.

Jonah's Prophecy and Jeroboam's Victory Reversed

It's crucially important to note that Jeroboam's border restoration and Jonah's prophecy are intentionally reversed by an oracle from the prophet Amos. So whatever positive associations we had in [2 Kings 14](#) must be tempered by the eventual reversal of Jonah's prophecy brought on by Israel's apostasy.

2 Kings 14:24-25 NASB

²⁴ Jeroboam did evil in the sight of the LORD; he did not depart from all the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat, which he made Israel sin. ²⁵ He restored the border of Israel from the entrance of Hamath as far as the Sea of the Arabah, according to the word of the LORD, the God of Israel, which he spoke through his servant Jonah the son of Amittai, the prophet, who was of Gath-hepher.

Amos 6:13-14 NASB

¹³ You who rejoice in Lodebar,
and say, "Have we not by our own strength taken Karnaim for ourselves?"
¹⁴ "For behold, I am going to raise up a nation against you,
O house of Israel," declares the LORD God of hosts,
"And they will afflict you from the entrance of Hamath
to the brook of the Arabah."

The nation that God will use to reverse Jonah's prophecy and fulfill Amos' warning is none other than Assyria, who will eventually destroy the entire northern kingdom of Israel.

2 Kings 15:27-29 NASB

²⁷ In the fifty-second year of Azariah king of Judah, Pekah son of Remaliah became king over Israel in Samaria, and reigned twenty years. ²⁸ He did evil in the sight of the LORD; he did not depart from the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, which he made Israel sin.

²⁹ In the days of Pekah king of Israel, Tiglath-pileser king of Assyria came and captured Ijon and Abel-beth-maacah and Janoah and Kedesh and Hazor and Gilead and Galilee, all the land of Naphtali; and he carried them captive to Assyria.

2 Kings 16:9 NASB

[Then] ... the king of Assyria went up against Damascus and captured it, and carried the people of it away into exile to Kir, and put Rezin to death.

Nineveh, the Great City

The phrase "Nineveh, the great city" appears four times in Jonah ([Jon. 1:2](#); [3:2](#), [3](#); [4:11](#)) and only elsewhere in Genesis 10 in a crucially important story about the founding of Babylon and Nineveh.

Genesis 10:10-12 NASB*

¹⁰ The beginning of [Nimrod's] kingdom was Babylon and Erech and Akkad and Calneh, in the land of Shinar.

¹¹ From that land Asshur went out, and he built Nineveh and the wide-ness-of-city and Calah, ¹² and Resen between Nineveh and Calah; that is the great city.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Asshur's kingdom consists of four cities, just as Nimrod's Babylon. From this point on, these two empires will loom in the background until Assyria appears in [2 Kings 15](#) (right after Jonah) as a precursor to the Babylonian threat.

"The deliberate association of Assyria with Babylon (in Gen 10:11-12) is significant; otherwise, in the lists of names which follow, Assyria is associated with the sons of Shem (Gen 10:22). By means of this narrative insertion, then, the author has not only introduced a key city, Babylon, but has also taken Assyria out of its natural associations with Shem and given it a new identification with Babylon. Thus the author has opened the way for an association and identification of other cities with Babylon. These appear to be the initial stirrings of a larger-than life symbolic value for Babylon, one known in a fully developed sense in the book of Isaiah (chs. 13-14 where Assyria is identified with Babylon), and in Micah 5:6, where the prophet could speak of Assyria as the 'land of Nimrod.'"

Sailhamer, John H. (1995). [The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-Theological Commentary](#). Zondervan Academic. 132.

Rising Evil

The phrase “their evil has risen up before me” connects to an important biblical design pattern of the evil human city whose violence forms an outcry that rises up to God.

Genesis 4:10 NASB*

The blood of your brother is crying out to me (צעקים אלי) from the ground.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Cain and Abel and Cain’s city of violence

Genesis 6:13 NASB*

The end of all flesh has come before me (לפני בא).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The generation of the flood

Genesis 18:20-21 NASB*

²⁰ The outcry (זעקה) against Sodom and Gomorrah, it is great and their sin is extremely heavy. ²¹ I will go down now and I will see if its outcry (צעקה) which has come to me (אלי הבאה) they have done, totally.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Sodom and Gomorrah

Exodus 2:23 NASB*

And they cried out (זעק) and their outcry rose up to God (אל אלהים ... ותעל) from their slavery.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Israelites in Egypt

Jonah 1:2 NASB*

For their evil has risen up before me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ninevah

In each of these stories, God raises up a deliverer/intercessor who either:

1. Confronts the evil-doers and calls them to repent (Moses in Egypt), or
2. Pleads with God on behalf of the wicked (Noah’s sacrifice, Abraham’s intercession)

But this is not the case with Jonah.

Jonah’s Flight from God

Jonah 1:3 NASB*

And Jonah arose to flee ... from before the face of Yahweh (יהוה מלפני).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The phrase “from before the face of Yahweh” refers to the divine presence and appears 16 times in the Hebrew Bible. The first time is in the story of Cain’s exile east of Eden after his brother’s blood cries out from the ground. This interpretation is confirmed by the fact that the author returns to a series of clear analogies between Jonah and Cain in Jonah 4.

Genesis 4:16 NASB*

And he went out from before the face of Yahweh (מלפני יהוה).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Cain's exile from Eden

Jonah 1:3 NASB*

And Jonah arose to flee ... from before the face of Yahweh (יהוה מלפני).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah's flight from God

Cain in Genesis 4

Genesis 4:4b-5 Instructor’s Translation

^{4b} And Yahweh regarded Abel and his offering, ⁵ but Cain and his offering he did not regard, and there was heat-anger to Cain (ל ויחר-).

Genesis 4:6-7 Instructor’s Translation

⁶ “Why is there heat-anger to you (לך חרה)? ⁷ Isn’t it the case that if you do good (תיטיב) there is exaltation?”

Genesis 4:16 NASB*

And Cain went out (ויצא) from before the face of Yahweh and he sat (וישב) in the land of Nod, to the east of Eden (עדן קדמת).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 4:17 Instructor’s Translation

And he built a city and called the name of the city according to the name of his son Enoch.

Jonah in Jonah 4

Jonah 4:1 Instructor’s Translation

And [God's showing mercy to Nineveh] was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and there was heat-anger to him (ל ויחר-).

Jonah 4:4 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh said, "Is it doing good that there is heat-anger to you (חרה וזהיטב ולך)?"

Jonah 4:5 Instructor's Translation

And Jonah went out (ויצא) from the city and he sat from the east of the city (מקדם וישב) and made for himself a *sukkah* and he sat (וישב) under it.

The phrase "from before the face of Yahweh" also refers to the divine presence in the tabernacle ([Num. 17:7](#), [20:9](#); [1 Sam. 21:7](#)), divine judgment/fire ([Lev. 9:24](#), [10:2](#)), and incense ([Num. 16:40](#); [Lev. 16:12](#)). This instance in Jonah matches Cain's closely, especially in light of the Cain analogies at work in chapter 4.

Going to Tarshish

Tarshish has two main associations.

1. An exotic, distant nation: The name appears for the first time among the sons of Japeth ([Gen. 10:4](#)) among the distant island nations (with Elisha, Kittim, Dodanim).
2. A place of gold and precious gems: The name also refers to a precious stone that, according to Ezekiel, endowed the garden of Eden with its majestic splendor ([Ezek. 28:13](#)).

When these associations are combined, we can see Tarshish as a source of wealth and resources that people use to create their own versions of Eden, which then subjects them to judgment.

1 Kings 10:22 NASB

For the king [Solomon] had at sea the ships of Tarshish with the ships of Hiram; once every three years the ships of Tarshish came bringing gold and silver, ivory and apes and peacocks.

1 Kings 22:48 NASB

Jehoshaphat made ships of Tarshish to go to Ophir for gold, but they did not go for the ships were broken at Ezion-geber.

Just as in Jonah 1:4

The "ships of Tarshish" are a source of wealth, idolatry, and pagan influence in Israel and, therefore, a target for Yahweh's justice.

Isaiah 2:12, 16 Instructor's Translation

¹² For Yahweh of armies has a day ... ¹⁶ against all the ships of Tarshish, and against all the desirable ships.

Isaiah 23:1 Instructor's Translation

Wail, O ships of Tarshish,
for Tyre is destroyed without house or harbor;

Psalm 48:4-5, 7 Instructor's Translation

⁴ The kings assemble themselves together ...

⁵ They saw and were stunned ...

⁷ With the east wind

you break the ships of Tarshish.

Just as in Jonah 1:4

But Tarshish is eventually redeemed. The new Jerusalem will receive the gold from the ships of Tarshish ([Isa. 60:9](#), [72:10](#)). And in the messianic age, the witnesses will go out to the islands, including Tarshish ([Isa. 66:19](#)).

Tarshish plays the role of a pseudo-Eden, a place for precious stones that is exploited by human scheming (ships and trade routes). The destroyed ships of Tarshish become an image of God defeating humanity's search for Eden life on their own terms.

Jonah flees to Tarshish just as all biblical characters attempt some kind of "return to Eden" by their own power and scheming.

Reflection Question

In the biblical story, what kind of a place is Tarshish? What does it mean that Jonah flees there? Do you think this is a point that would be helpful for those in your context?

Session 23: Reflecting on Jonah's Flight

Key Takeaways

- Jonah is the most extreme example of a prophet who resists God's call on their life.
- God wants humans to experience Eden, but they keep forfeiting it through rebellion and creating their own versions of it. Cain's city, Babylon, and Jerusalem under Israel's kings all represent false Edens.
- [Psalm 139](#) is a good companion text for Jonah because Jonah was clearly on the mind of the psalmist.
- The authors of the Hebrew Bible are mostly anonymous because what matters to the text's authority are the people in whom the tradition is anchored such as Moses, the prophets, or Isaiah.

The Resistant Prophet

Jonah's flight is extreme behavior for a resistant prophet, bringing to mind other resistant prophets in the Hebrew Bible, like Moses, Elijah, and Jeremiah. This action by Jonah opens up large-scale comparisons and contrasts with these three prophets.

Moses the Resistant Prophet

Exodus 3:10 NASB

Therefore, come now, and I will send you to Pharaoh, so that you may bring my people, the sons of Israel, out of Egypt.

The commission

Exodus 3:11 NASB

Who am I?

First objection

Exodus 3:13 NASB

What is [your] name?

Second objection: Moses is asking, "Who are you?"

Exodus 4:1 NASB

What if they [don't] believe me?

Third objection

Exodus 4:10 NASB*

Please, my Lord, I'm not a man of words ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Fourth objection

Exodus 4:13 ESV*

Please, my Lord, send someone else!

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Fifth objection

Exodus 4:12 NASB

Now then go, and I, even I, will be with your mouth, and teach you what you are to say.

God's response

Jeremiah the Slightly Less Resistant Prophet

Jeremiah 1:4-5 NASB

⁴ Now the word of the LORD came to me saying,

⁵ "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you,
and before you were born I consecrated you;
I have appointed you a prophet to the nations."

The commission

Jeremiah 1:6a NIV*

Look, I don't know how to speak!

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

First objection

Jeremiah 1:6b NIV

I am too young!

Second objection

Jeremiah 1:7-9 NASB

⁷ “Do not say, ‘I am too young,’ because everywhere I send you, you shall go.

⁸ And all that I command you, you shall speak ...”

⁹ Then the LORD stretched out his hand and touched my mouth, and the LORD said to me, “Behold, I have put my words in your mouth.”

God’s response

Elijah the Disillusioned Death-Wish Prophet

1 Kings 17:1-2 NASB

¹ Now Elijah the Tishbite, was of the settlers of Gilead ... ² The word of the LORD came to him ...

The commission

1 Kings 19:1-4 NASB

¹ Now Ahab told Jezebel all that Elijah had done, and how he had killed all the prophets with the sword. ² Then Jezebel sent a messenger to Elijah, saying, “So may the gods do to me and even more, if I do not make your life as the life of one of them by tomorrow about this time.” ³ And he was afraid and arose and ran for his life and came to Beersheba, which belongs to Judah, and left his servant there. ⁴ But he himself went a day’s journey into the wilderness, and came and sat down under a juniper tree; and he requested his life, that he might die, and said, “It is enough; now, O LORD, take my life, for I am not better than my fathers.”

After his unsuccessful mission on Mount Carmel

Jonah the Utterly Rebellious Prophet

Jonah 4:3, 8 NASB*

³ “Take my life, for better is my death than my life!” ... ⁸ And he requested his his life to die,

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

After his successful mission in Nineveh

Jonah is an extreme character among the prophets, taking the motif of the resistant prophet to the next level. He is more resistant to his call than Moses or Jeremiah, and he is more comic than Elijah in that he too wants to die, but only after an outstanding success in his prophetic calling.

Reflection Question

How is Jonah like Moses or Jeremiah?

Session 24: The Symmetry of the Ship Scene

Key Takeaways

- Chiasms encourage us to compare and contrast parallel sections of the text.
- Jonah's actions and words are often in contrast, and this is intentional. The author wants us to draw our own conclusions and continue questioning Jonah's motives.

Jonah, the Storm, and the Sailors: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 1:4-16

A

4 Now, Yahweh had **hurled** a great wind **to the sea** and there was a great storm on the sea, and the ship considered breaking apart.

5 And the sailors **feared** and each cried to his god, and they **hurled** the cargo which was in the ship **to the sea** to make it lighter from upon them. Now, Jonah **went down** into the far reaches of the ship, and he laid **down** and **fell asleep**.

B

6 And the chief of the sailors approached him and said, "What is it with you, **sleeping**? Get up, **call to your god**. Perhaps a god will be concerned about us **so that we will not perish**."

7 And each man said to his companion, "Come, let us cast lots, so that we can know **on whose account this evil is to us**." So they cast lots and the lot fell on Jonah.

C

8 **And they said to him**, "Please tell us, **on whose account is this evil to us**? What is your work? And where do you come from? What is your country? From what people are you?"

9 **And he said to them**, "I am a Hebrew, and I fear Yahweh God of heaven who made the sea and the dry land."

10 And the men **feared a great fear** and they said to him, "What is this you have done?!"

D For the men knew that he was fleeing **from before the face of Yahweh** because he had told them.

C' 11 **And they said to him**, "What should we do to you that the sea may become calm for us?" for the sea was going and storming.
12 **And he said to them**, "Pick me up and **hurl me to the sea** .
Then the sea will become calm for you,
for I know that **on account of me this great storm is to you.** "

B' 13 And the men dug in to return to land
but they could not, for the sea was going and storming against them.
14 And **they called to Yahweh** and said,
"Please Yahweh, **do not let us perish** on account of this man's life
and don't set innocent blood against us;
for you, O Lord, have done as you have pleased."

A' 15 And they picked up Jonah, and they **hurled him to the sea** ,
and the sea stopped its raging.
16 Then the men **feared** the Lord a **great fear** ,
and they offered sacrifices to Yahweh and **they vowed vows** .

Jonah 1:4-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Reflection Question

So far in chapter 1, what evidence of Jonah's motives being positive do you see? What evidence of Jonah's motives being negative do you see? Why do you think the author decides not to tell us what Jonah's motives are?

Session 25: Reflecting on Jonah's Motives

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors intentionally leave out information about characters' motives to invite us to think about our own experiences.
- Jonah is depicted as completely unaware, as if his rebellion has put him in a stupor.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

The biblical authors don't often give you all the information that you need to make sense of characters' motives in the story. What thoughts or questions do you have about Jonah's motives?

Session 26: The Upside-Down Character of Jonah

Key Takeaways

- In the book of Jonah, everything is upside-down, and every character reverses their stereotypical behavior, including the pagans and Jonah. The only person who is true to form is God.
- The phrase “the uttermost parts of the ship” is a clever wordplay on a well-known phrase for the cosmic mountain of God that is associated with Eden, “the uttermost reaches of the north” ([Ps. 48](#)).

Jonah’s Flight to a Pseudo-Eden

Jonah’s flight ([Jon. 1:3](#)) introduces a major theme in [chapter 1](#) that comically inverts a standard biblical motif: humans exiled from Eden because of their attempt to recreate their own version of Eden in high places or gardens and with wealth or wisdom.

Jonah, on the other hand, goes down instead of up, and he runs toward death instead of life.

Jonah’s “Descent” Into Death

Jonah 1:3a NASB*

Jonah **went down** (*yarad*) to Joppa (*yapho*).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Went down” = *yarad* = יָרַד

Jonah 1:3b NASB*

Jonah **went down** (*yarad*) into the ship.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Went down” = *yarad* = יָרַד

Jonah 1:5 NASB*

Jonah **went down** (*yarad*) into the **uttermost parts of the ship** (*yarketey-hasephinah*), and he lay down and went into a **deep sleep** (*vayeradam*).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Far reaches” = *yarketey* = יִרְכֵּתִי

“Deep sleep” = *yeradam* = וַיִּרְדָּם

The triple repetition of “went down” (יָרַד) is echoed by Jonah’s “deep sleep” (וִירְדָם) and the location he seeks upon the ship (יִרְכָתִי). All three of these terms connect to Jonah’s inverted Eden.

“Deep sleep” is associated with a lifeless slumber caused by Yahweh when he does something for the sleeper that they could not do for themselves. This prompts one to wonder: Is Jonah’s deep sleep a kind of judgment? Is Yahweh’s providence taking Jonah “all the way to the bottom”?

Adam’s “Deep Sleep” in Eden

Genesis 2:21 NASB

So the LORD God caused a deep sleep to fall upon the man, and he slept. Then he took one of his sides and closed up the flesh at that place.

Abraham’s “Deep Sleep” When Given the Eden Blessing

Genesis 15:12 NASB

Now when the sun was going down, a deep sleep fell upon Abram; and behold, terror and great darkness fell upon him.

The phrase “the uttermost parts of the ship” is a clever wordplay on a well-known name for the cosmic mountain of God that is associated with Eden, “the uttermost reaches of the north.”

- Uttermost parts of the ship = *yarketey hasephinah* / הספינה ירכתי
- Uttermost reaches of the north = *yarketey hatsaphon* / הצפון ירכתי

“Zaphon, a mountain to the north of Israel, represented a divine abode in the ancient period. Accordingly, Zaphon in the Bible signifies either a heavenly divine location (“I will rise up into the heavens ... I will sit on the mountain of divine assembly, in the upper reaches of Zaphon,” [Isa. 14:13](#)) or to the sacred mountain in Jerusalem (“Mount Zion, the upper reaches of Zaphon,” [Ps. 48:3](#)). The divine mountain, for its part, constitutes a secure, paradisiacal location, one that Ezekiel ... likens to “the garden of God” ([Ezek. 28:13-14](#)). Based on the biblical and comparative evidence, scholars characterize the garden of Eden as an archetypal sanctuary, a place where God dwells and where humans worship him.” Correspondingly, the Israelite temple on Mount Zion is identified with the primeval hill, paradise, the cosmic mountain.”

Berger, Yitzhak (2016). [Jonah in the Shadows of Eden](#). Indiana University Press. 3-4.

“The uttermost reaches of the north” is a biblical phrase with rich overtones of the cosmic mountain range in the far north (Mount Hermon and beyond). This was the mythological realm of the Canaanite deities (see Clifford, 2010). It was an exotic, snowy, high place of the divine realm, where Heaven and Earth overlapped. The biblical authors adopted this phrase and image to describe the temple in Jerusalem, which was an image of Eden, the true cosmic mountain ([Ps. 46](#)).

Psalms 48:1-2 NASB

¹ Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised,
in the city of our God, his holy mountain.

² Beautiful in elevation, the joy of the whole earth,
is Mount Zion, the uttermost reaches of the north,
the city of the great King.

Psalm 46:4-5 NASB

⁴ There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God,
the holy dwelling places of the Most High.

⁵ God is in the midst of her, she will not be moved;
God will help her when morning dawns.

Isaiah depicts the spiritual power behind Babylon as a divine rebel who attempted to ascend God's throne in Eden, which is called "the uttermost reaches of the north." Isaiah inverts the phrase to describe the "uttermost parts of the grave."

Isaiah 14:13-15 NASB*

¹³ "But you said in your heart,
'I will ascend to the heavens;
I will raise my throne above the stars of God,
And I will sit on the mount of assembly
In the uttermost parts of the north (*yarketey tsaphon*).

¹⁴ I will ascend above the heights of the clouds;
I will make myself like the Most High.'

¹⁵ Nevertheless you will be thrust down to Sheol,
To the uttermost parts of the pit (*yarketey bor*)."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This phrase "uttermost parts of the pit" taps into a widespread motif of descent into the grave as an anti-Eden.

Ezekiel 32:18, 21-23 NASB*

¹⁸ Son of man, wail for the hordes of Egypt and bring it down, her and the daughters of the powerful nations, to the underworld, with those who go down to the pit ...

²¹ The strong among the mighty ones shall speak of him and his helpers from the midst of Sheol, "They have gone down, they lie still, the uncircumcised, slain by the sword."

²² Assyria is there and all her company; her graves are round about her. All of them are slain, fallen down by the sword, ²³ whose graves are set in the uttermost parts of the pit and her company is round about her grave.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The author is portraying the prophet as fleeing the call of Yahweh to the nations only to seek his own self-made version of Eden by turning to the nations. In boarding a ship bound for Tarshish, Jonah is actually beginning his descent into death, and the author cleverly calls Jonah's bed "the uttermost parts of the ship" (that is, north).

This phrase also prepares us to expect a storm, which will humble and threaten to break apart the ships of Tarshish.

God’s Judgment on the Ships of Tarshish

In [Isaiah 2](#) and [Ezekiel 26-27](#), God brings judgment on the nations for building false Edens with the wealth of Tarshish.

Isaiah 2:12, 16 Instructor’s Translation

¹² For Yahweh of armies has a day ... ¹⁶ against all the ships of Tarshish, and against all the desirable ships.

Isaiah 23:1 NASB

Wail, O ships of Tarshish,
for Tyre is destroyed without house or harbor;

Psalms 48:4-5,7 NASB*

⁴ The kings assemble themselves together ...
⁵ They saw and were stunned ...
⁷ With the east wind
you break the ships of Tarshish.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Just as in [Jonah 1:4](#)

Jonah 1 and 3 have been designed to echo the divine judgment on Tyre and the ships of Tarshish in Ezekiel 26-27.

Ezekiel 26-27: The Sailors for Tyre	Jonah 1: The Sailors to Tarshish	Jonah 3: The Ninevites
26:16: And the princes of the sea will go down from upon their thrones (בסאותם מעל) and they will remove their robes (והסירו מעליהם) and their garments of embroidery they will strip off; with trembling they will clothe themselves; they will sit upon the ground (ישבו הארץ על) and shudder		The king rises from his throne (מכסאו), removes his robe (אדרתו ויעבר), and sits in the dust (וישב על האפר).
The Sailors in Ezekiel Going to Tyre and in Jonah Going to Tarshish. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

Ezekiel 26-27: The Sailors for Tyre	Jonah 1: The Sailors to Tarshish	Jonah 3: The Ninevites
nonstop, and they will be appalled at you.		
27:3-4: Tyre, perfect in beauty (יָפִי) ... they perfected your beauty. 27:11: They perfected your beauty (יָפִיד). 28:7: Foreigners will ... defile your beauty (יַפְעֵתְךָ), while the king of Tyre was perfect in beauty (28:12 יָפִי), which gave rise to arrogance in your beauty (28:17 יָפִיד).	1:1-3: Jonah flees to Joppa (יָפוֹ)	
27:8b: Your wise ones, O Tyre, were among you, they were your sailors. 27:9b: All the ships of the sea and their sailors (אֲנִיּוֹת וּמַלְחֵיהֶם הֵם) were among you.	1:5-6: The chief of sailors (הַחֹבֵל רֹב) and sailors (מַלְחִים), these words appear only in Ezekiel 27 and Jonah 1.	
27:12: Tarshish was your trader (סַחֲרֶתְךָ) due to the greatness of your wealth (See סַחַר, "trade" in 27:15, 16, 18, 21, 36).	1:3: Jonah paid the fare (שָׂכַר).	
27:23: Haran, Canah, and Eden, traders of Sheba, Assyria, Kilmad, were your traders. 27:25: Ships of Tarshish were carriers of your merchandise, and they were filled and very heavy in the heart of the seas.	Jonah found a ship (אֲנִיָּה) going to Tarshish (תַּרְשִׁישׁ). 2:3: You cast me into the heart of the seas (יָמִים בִּלְבָב).	
<i>The Sailors in Ezekiel Going to Tyre and in Jonah Going to Tarshish.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

Ezekiel 26-27: The Sailors for Tyre	Jonah 1: The Sailors to Tarshish	Jonah 3: The Ninevites
27:26: An east wind broke you in the heart of the seas (רוח הקדים שברך בלב ימים).	1:4: God hurled a great wind (רוח גדולה) upon the sea ... so that the ship considered breaking up (והאניה חשבה להשבר).	4:8: And God appointed an east wind (הקדים רוח), a burning one.
27:27: Your wealth, your wares, your merchandise, your sailors and your pilots, your repairers of seams, your dealers in merchandise and all your men of war who are in you, with all your company that is in your midst, will fall into the heart of the seas on the day of your downfall.	1:5: And the sailors ... hurled the cargo in the ship into the sea to lighten from upon them.	
27:28-30: At the sound of the cry of your sailors (זעקת חבליך) the pasture lands will shake. All who handle the oar, the sailors and all the pilots of the sea will come down from their ships. They will stand on the land, and they will make their voice heard over you, and will cry (ויזעקו) bitterly. They will cast dust on their heads. They will wallow in ashes (באפר).	1:5: And the sailors cried out (ויזעקו) each to his god.	3:6: The king of Nineveh sat upon the ashes (האפר) and he cried (ויעזק) out.
27:31: Also they will make themselves bald for you and gird themselves with sackcloth (שקים). And they will weep for you in bitterness of soul with bitter mourning.		3:7-8: Let human and animal ... clothe themselves with sackcloth (שקים).
The Sailors in Ezekiel Going to Tyre and in Jonah Going to Tarshish. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).		

These hyperlinks bring perspective to Jonah's flight and the portrayal of the sailors and Ninevites.

Tyre and Its Sailors

In Ezekiel 26-27, Tyre was using the sailors and ships of Tarshish (among other places) to bring Eden-like wealth, security, and abundance to their "rock" (רֹכֶס = Tyre) in the "heart of the seas" (Ezek. 27:4). But God will reverse all of their wealth, sending storms to break their ships so that all the sailors cry out in grief, sit in the dust, and mourn over Tyre's lost wealth.

Jonah and the Sailors

Jonah is fleeing to his own pseudo-Eden by heading to Tarshish (on Tyre's fleet) and paying its fare, but God sends a storm to humble his wayward prophet so that the sailors cry out in fear.

The Sailors and the Ninevites

Because the design of Jonah sets the response of the sailors in parallel with the response of the Ninevites, and both of these groups are contrasted with Jonah, it makes perfect sense that the grief and crying out of Tyre's sailors would be applied to the sailors of Tarshish and the Ninevites. Both imitate the crying and grief of the sailors in Ezekiel 26-27.

"In this sequence of prophecies [Ezekiel 26-28], the prophet compares the glamorous Tyre, a kingdom supplied and signified by ships of Tarshish, to the divine mountain and the garden of Eden. If, accordingly, Jonah occupies a Tarshish-bound vessel that stands in parallel to those ships, this yields ... evidence that our protagonist seeks an Eden-like realm of the kind that Ezekiel describes."

Berger, Yitzhak (2016). [*Jonah in the Shadows of Eden*](#). Indiana University Press. 5.

"As for Jonah having provided the *sakar* of the vessel ('its fare') ... consider the familiar motif of treasure-laden ships of Tarshish ... Every biblical reference to the ships of Tarshish signal this luxuriant motif, none more emphatically than Ezekiel 27. [With these associations] the clause in Jonah 'he provided its fare,' much like the place name 'Joppa' (יָפוֹ // יָפִי 'beauty'), gives rise to a highly consequential secondary meaning: In stocking/providing the vessel's fare, a fleeing Jonah, pursuing the idyllic realm that ships of Tarshish supply and signify, hastily provided the ship with the fortune it is destined to carry. The text suggests that the prophet, seeking to escape toward that paradisiacal domain of Tarshish, started out in pursuit of that 'beautiful' (יָפִי) location."

Berger, Yitzhak (2016). [*Jonah in the Shadows of Eden*](#). Indiana University Press. 6-7.

Jonah's Prophetic Failure vs. the Sailors' Spiritual Intuition

Jonah is portrayed as selfish and slow to understand the reality of his situation, while the sailors are depicted as spiritually aware and more in tune with Jonah's God than Jonah is.

Jonah's hypocritical confession in 1:9 shows that he is totally unaware of the contradiction between his actions and his words.

Jonah 1:9 NASB*

I fear Yahweh, the God of the heavens, who made the sea and the dry land.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 95:3, 5 NIV*

³ Yahweh is a great God ...

⁵ The sea is his, for he made it,
and the dry land, his hands formed it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The irony is that Jonah's confession of his "beliefs" is likely based on the formulation of [Psalm 95](#), but this psalm is a call for Israel not to rebel against their God precisely because he is the creator and ruler of all—the very thing Jonah is doing as he quotes these words.

Interpretive Ambiguity

Is Jonah's confession in 1:9 an indirect admission of guilt?

"This is not an empty declaration that Jonah worships the Lord ('fear' or 'awe' in the conventional meaning of fealty and obedience) ... It is rather implicit acknowledgment of his personal responsibility for their predicament because he falls under the direct jurisdiction of the God of sky and sea, therefore the punitive action—the storm—is clearly directed against him."

Simon, Uriel (1999). [JPS Bible Commentary: Jonah](#). Jewish Publication Society. 12.

"The implication of the confession of faith is that the source of the storm is none other than Yahweh who made the sea. The wonder is that Jonah can recite such a creed and yet show disrespect to the commands of the God whose sovereignty it celebrates."

Allen, Leslie C. (1976). [The Books of Joel, Obadiah, Jonah, and Micah](#). Eerdmans. 210.

In contrast, the sailors' prayer to God in 1:14 quotes from the psalms and has the opposite effect.

Jonah 1:14 Instructor's Translation

Please Yahweh, don't let us perish on account of this man's life ... for just as you have purposed, you have done.

Psalms 115:2-3 NASB*

² Why should the nations say,

"Where now is your God?"

³ Our God is in the heavens,
And everything which he purposes, he does.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 135:5-6 NIV*

⁵ I know that Yahweh is great,
and our Lord is greater than all gods.

⁶ Everything which he purposes, Yahweh does
in the heavens, on the land,
in the seas and all the depths.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The irony is that Jonah confessed to believe in the “God of the heavens,” yet it is the sailors who actually understand the implications of such a belief. They recognize the storm as God’s purpose and a result of his power over the sea.

“In both psalms, the confession of faith contrasts Yahweh with other, impotent gods ([135:5](#)) and idols ([115:4-7](#)) ... In this way—through the prayer in general and through its individual phrases—the narrator depicts the heathen sailors as people who turn to Yahweh like model Israelites, at least where Jonah’s affairs are concerned, and when they are in danger of shipwreck.”

Wolff, Hans Walter (1986). [Obadiah and Jonah: A Commentary](#). Augsburg Fortress Pub. 120.

Reflection Question

Recall the page from the children’s magazine *Highlights* called “What’s Wrong?” where readers are challenged to find everything that’s not quite right in the picture. What do you find helpful about this example? Is there a different example or illustration that would help those in your context understand how the author of Jonah is subverting or playing with reader expectations?

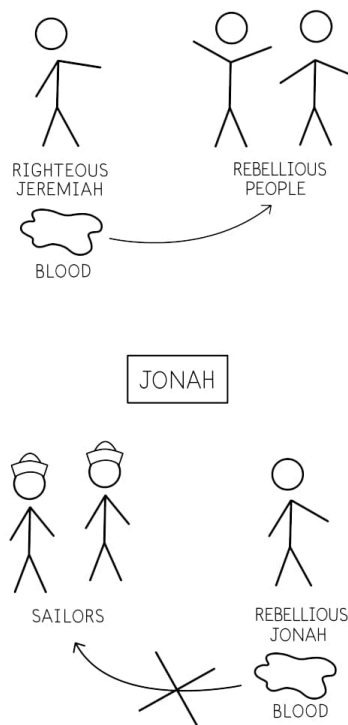
Session 27: Relationships Between Jonah and the Story of the Bible

Key Takeaways

- Jonah's deathly descent into the waters becomes an instrument of Yahweh's purpose to bring salvation to the nations.

The Contrast Between Jeremiah and Jonah

In this scene, the sailors cry out to Yahweh, asking that he not hold them guilty for killing an innocent man. The language of this scene hyperlinks Jeremiah 26, but the roles are reversed. Instead of a righteous prophet and rebellious people, Jonah is a rebellious prophet and the sailors are acting righteously.



Contrasts in the Design of Jonah 1. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Reflection Question

The story of the Bible paints a portrait of a prophetic figure who dies for the sins of others to bring salvation to the nations. What are some of the ways Jonah interacts with the overarching story of the Bible? How important do you think it is to help those in your context understand how the story of Jonah interacts with this broader biblical portrait?

Session 28: Reflecting on Jonah 1

Key Takeaways

- God is dealing with horrific human evil, but he doesn't wave it away. He lets people sit in the mess they create, but not forever.
- Even our evil can become an instrument of God's purposes.

Deceptive Prophet, Fearful Pagans

Jonah's deception of the sailors—not telling them he was running from Yahweh—is discovered. And the irony of this is made clear by two hyperlinked design patterns that compare Jonah to Pharaoh in [Exodus 14](#) and then to Achan in [Joshua 7](#).

Jonah as Pharaoh

Pharaoh's Deception and the Israelites' Fear

Exodus 14:5 NASB*

When the king of Egypt was **told** (ויגד) that the people had **fled** (ברח), Pharaoh and his servants had a change of heart toward the people, and they said, **"What is this we have done"** (עשינו זאת מה), that we have let Israel go from serving us?"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 14:10 NASB*

As Pharaoh drew near, the sons of Israel looked, and behold, the Egyptians were marching after them, and they became **very afraid** (מאד ויראו) and the sons of **Israel cried out** (ויצעקו) to the LORD.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah's Deception and the Sailor's Fear

Jonah 1:5 NASB*

And the sailors **were afraid** (וייראו) and they **cried out** (ויצעקו) each to his god ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 1:9 NASB*

I am a Hebrew, and I fear (ירא) Yahweh, the God of the heavens who made the sea and dry land.

Jonah 1:10 Instructor's Translation

And the men were **afraid, a very great fear** (וייראו...יראה גדולה) and they said, **"What is this you have done to us?!"** (מה זאת עשית), for the men knew that he had **fled** (ברח) from Yahweh, for he **told** (הגיד) them.

Note that in this analogy, Jonah has been paired with Pharaoh as the deceiver, while the sailors have been paired with the helpless Israelites who are at the mercy of the deceiver. The main difference is that Jonah has not premeditated his deception, whereas for Pharaoh, his actions are the culmination of a long series of deceptions.

Jonah as Achan

The Eden Deception in Genesis

Genesis 3:6 Instructor's Translation

And the woman saw that the tree was good (כי טוב העץ) ... and desirable (נחמד) for becoming wise, and she took from its fruit and she ate and she gave to her husband.

Genesis 3:11 Instructor's Translation

God to Adam: "Who told you (מי הגיד לך) that you were naked?"

Genesis 3:13 Instructor's Translation

God to Eve: "What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית)?"

Jonah's Deception

Jonah 1:7 NASB

And each man said to his mate, "Come, let's cast lots so that we may find out on whose account this catastrophe has struck us." So they cast lots, and the lot fell on Jonah.

Jonah is selected by lot for his sin.

Jonah 1:8 Instructor's Translation

Sailors to Jonah: "Please tell us now (הגידה נא לנו)."

Sailors to Jonah: "What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית)?"

Achan's Deception in Joshua

Joshua 7:14-18 NASB

¹⁴ So in the morning you shall come forward by your tribes. And it shall be that the tribe which the LORD selects by lot shall come forward by families, and the family which the LORD selects shall come forward by

households, and the household which the LORD selects shall come forward man by man. ¹⁵ And it shall be that the one who is selected with the things designated for destruction shall be burned with fire, he and all that belongs to him, because he has violated the covenant of the LORD, and because he has committed a disgraceful thing in Israel.”

¹⁶ So Joshua got up early in the morning and brought Israel forward by tribes, and the tribe of Judah was selected. ¹⁷ So he brought the family of Judah forward, and he selected the family of the Zerahites; then he brought the family of the Zerahites forward man by man, and Zabdi was selected. ¹⁸ And he brought his household forward man by man; and Achan, son of Carmi, son of Zabdi, son of Zerah, from the tribe of Judah, was selected.

Achan is selected by lot for his sin.

Joshua 7:19 Instructor's Translation

Joshua to Achan: “Please tell me now (הגד נא לי) what have you done (מה עשית)?”

Joshua 7:21 NASB*

Achan: “I saw among the spoil a cloak of Shinar, a good one (טובה) and two hundred shekels ... and I desired them (ואחמדם) and I took them (ואקחם).”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah as the Scapegoat

There is only one other figure in the Hebrew Bible that has lots cast over them and is then “cast out” so that others may experience Yahweh’s blessing, and that is the scapegoat on the Day of Atonement in Leviticus 16.

Jonah 1	Leviticus 16
1:7: And they cast lots, and the lot fell concerning Jonah.	16:8: And Aaron will give lots concerning the two goats, one lot for Yahweh, and one lot for going away (<i>azazel</i>). 16:10: And the goat which the lot went up concerning it for going away (<i>azazel</i>), it will stand alive before Yahweh for making atonement for it, by sending it for going away (<i>azazel</i>) into the wilderness.
1:14: “Please Yahweh, don’t let us perish for the life of this man, and don’t place innocent blood upon us!”	16:21a: And Aaron will rest his two hands upon the head of the living goat and will confess over it all of the iniquities of the sons of Israel.

Jonah as the Scapegoat. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Jonah 1

1:12: “Take me up (נשא) and hurl me into the sea ...”

1:15: And they took up (נשא) Jonah, and they hurled him into the sea. And the sea stopped its wrath.

Leviticus 16

16:21b: And all their transgressions and all their sins, and he will place them on the head of the goat ... and the goat will take up (נשא) all their iniquities to a land of isolation, and he will send the goat into the wilderness.

Jonah as the Scapegoat. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Notice the personification of the sea as “wrathful” (Heb. *za’aph* / זעף), which is elsewhere used to describe Yahweh’s anger at humanity’s evil ([Mic. 7:9](#)) and likened to a storm.

Isaiah 30:30 Instructor's Translation

Yahweh will cause people to hear his voice of majesty, and he will display the descent of his arm, with wrathful (זעף) anger, and flame of devouring fire, and hail and storm clouds and rain and hail.

The Sailors as Ideal Israelites

In contrast to Jonah, who replays the deceptions of Eve and Achan, the sailors are portrayed as the humble and repentant Israelites from the structurally significant [Psalm 107](#).

Psalm 107 begins with an opening call for those who have returned from the exile to praise Yahweh for his covenant loyalty (Ps. [107:1-3](#)). This is followed by four mini-narratives that portray various acts of divine deliverance from chaos environments that are set in analogy to the Babylonian exile. They are arranged symmetrically.

A v. 4-9: Wanderers in the **desert** without food or water

B v. 10-16: **Prisoners** in the dark **because of their sins**

B’ v. 17-22: People with **illness** unto **death because of their sins**

A’ v. 23-32: Sailors on the **sea** threatened by a storm

In each episode, people cry out to Yahweh with the identical line: “And they cried out to Yahweh in their distress, and from their afflictions he delivered them” (v. 6, 13, 19, 28).

The fourth episode is the longest, and it portrays an iconic sea storm that threatens human wisdom and power that is represented by ships and their navigation.

Psalm 107:23-31	The Sailors in Jonah 1 and 2
Those who go down to the sea in ships who do business on great waters; they have seen the works of Yahweh, and his wonders in the deep.	1:3: And he went down to Joppa and found a ship going to Tarshish ... and he went down into it to go with them to Tarshish.
And he spoke and raised up a stormy wind , which lifted up the waves of the sea.	1:4: And Yahweh hurled a great wind onto the sea and it became a great storm .
They rose up to the heavens, they went down to the depths ; their soul melted away in calamity.	2:5: "Waters surrounded up to my neck , the deep encircled me ... I went down to the underworld."
They reeled and staggered like a drunken man, and all their wisdom was swallowed up .	1:17: And Yahweh appointed a great fish to swallow up Jonah.
Then they cried to Yahweh in their trouble, and he brought them out of their distress .	1:5: And they cried out each to his god. 1:14: And they called out to Yahweh. 2:2: "I called out to Yahweh from my distress ."
He caused the storm to be still, so that the waves of the sea were hushed.	1:15: And the sea stood from its raging.
Then they were glad because they were quiet , so he guided them to their desired haven.	1:11-12: "What may we do for you, so that the sea will become quiet ?"
Let them thank Yahweh for his covenant love, and for his wonders to the sons of men!	1:16: And they offered sacrifices to Yahweh and they fulfilled their vows. 2:9: "And I will with a voice of thanks , I will sacrifice to you, what I have vowed I will repay."
The Iconic Threatening Sea Storm. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Both Jonah and the sailors are set in analogy with those rescued in Psalm 107, though Jonah undergoes an additional descent unto death from which he needs to be rescued.

Most significantly, the storm rescue in Psalm 107 is set in analogy with being lost in the wilderness, imprisoned, and sick unto death. Together these are metaphorical analogies to the Babylonian exile. This makes Jonah's story resonate with meta-themes of the Hebrew Bible: sin and rebellion among God's covenant people, a self-imposed exile away from the true temple in a search for a pseudo-Eden that draws one near to

chaos and death only to cry out and be rescued from the domain of death. All of these are brought into the orbit of exile and restoration themes, and Jonah's story now resonates with those larger biblical themes.

Jonah's Death Wish and Innocent Blood

Why does Jonah's solution to the problem involve placing blood-guilt on the sailors? Why doesn't Jonah cry out to Yahweh like the sailors did to their gods? Why is he making them "repent" on his behalf?

Is this a moment of noble self-sacrifice? Or is this another moment of Jonah's selfish lack of awareness? Would he rather die than try to save the lives of others, much less his own? The answers to these questions seems to lie in understanding the design patterns being activated by the hyperlinks in this scene.

The Suffering Prophetic Intercessor

Noble Moses

When Moses is at his best, he intercedes for idolatrous Israel when they least deserve it, even offering his own life in place of theirs.

Exodus 32:30-32 NASB

³⁰ On the next day Moses said to the people, "You yourselves have committed a great sin; and now I am going up to the LORD, perhaps I can make atonement for your sin." ³¹ Then Moses returned to the LORD, and said, "Alas, this people has committed a great sin, and they have made a god of gold for themselves. ³² But now, if you will, forgive their sin—and if not, please blot me out from your book which you have written!"

Not-So-Noble Moses

When Moses finally loses his patience, he inverts his self-sacrifice by asking God to kill him instead of having to lead these people.

Numbers 11:14-15 NASB

¹⁴ I alone am not able to carry all this people, because it is too burdensome for me. ¹⁵ So if you are going to deal thus with me, please kill me at once, if I have found favor in your sight, and do not let me see my evil.

Elijah's Death Wish

Once Elijah realized that he couldn't bring lasting change to Israel, he fled into pity-party mode and ran back to Mount Sinai where Israel's covenant with Yahweh began. However, instead of interceding for Israel and offering his own life in their place, he acts like not-so-noble Moses and asks God to take his life.

1 Kings 19:4 NASB

But he himself went a day's journey into the wilderness, and came and sat down under a juniper tree; and he requested his life, that he might die, and said, "It is enough; now, O LORD, take my life, for I am not

better than my fathers.”

The City of Bloodshed

Cain’s Murder, Sodom, Egypt, and Nineveh

Recall the design pattern activated in Jonah 1:2, where the city’s violence and oppression activates a network of biblical portraits of the city of blood.

Genesis 4:10 NASB*

The blood of your brother is crying out to me (אלי צעקים) from the ground.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Cain and Abel and Cain’s city of violence

Genesis 6:13 NASB*

The end of all flesh has come before me (לפני בא).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The generation of the flood

Genesis 18:20-21 NASB*

²⁰ The outcry (זעקה) against Sodom and Gomorrah, it is great and their sin is extremely heavy. ²¹ I will go down now and I will see if its outcry (צעקה) which has come to me (אלי הבאה) they have done, totally.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Sodom and Gomorrah

Exodus 2:23 NASB*

And they cried out (זעק) and their outcry rose up to God (ותעל...אל אלהים) from their slavery.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Israelites in Egypt

Jonah 1:2 NASB*

For their evil has risen up before me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Nineveh

Israel’s City of Bloodshed

In Deuteronomy 21:1-9, Israel is given guidelines to prevent any of their towns from becoming like these cities of bloodshed. If a murdered corpse is found, there is a ritual for those who found it to be purified before God.

Deuteronomy 21:6-9 NASB*

⁶ All the elders of that city which is nearest to the slain body ... ⁷ and they shall answer and say, "Our hands did not shed this blood, nor did our eyes see it." ⁸ Provide atonement for people Israel whom you have redeemed, O LORD, and do not place innocent blood (אל תתן דם נקי) in the midst of your people Israel. And the bloodshed shall be atoned for them. ⁹ So you shall remove innocent blood from your midst, when you do what is right in the eyes of the LORD.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jeremiah and Jerusalem's Bloodshed

Jeremiah warns the leaders of Jerusalem that because they have shed the blood of the innocent, their city will come under God's judgment just as the cities of Cain, Sodom, Egypt, and Nineveh.

Jeremiah 26:12-15 NASB*

¹² Then Jeremiah spoke to all the officials and to all the people, saying, "The LORD sent me to prophesy against this temple and against this city all the words that you have heard. ¹³ Now therefore make good your ways and your deeds and listen to the voice of the LORD your God; and the LORD will relent concerning the evil he has spoken concerning you. ¹⁴ But as for me, behold, I am in your hands; do with me as is good and right in your sight. ¹⁵ Only know for certain that if you put me to death, you will place innocent blood (נקי דם נתנים אתם) on yourselves, and on this city and on its inhabitants; for truly the LORD has sent me to you to speak all these words in your hearing."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"Whereas Jeremiah in chapter 26 pleads for his life on the grounds that with his death, 'innocent blood' will be on the heads of the people of Jerusalem, it is not Jonah who tells this to the sailors, but the sailors themselves who pray to God, and thus remind Jonah of this danger. The two-way effect of this inversion is to diminish Jonah in comparison with Jeremiah and to elevate the moral sensitivities of the sailors. It also brings a fourth party into the picture, the citizens of Jerusalem in Jeremiah's day, their reaction to Jeremiah being contrasted to the Ninevites and their king ... Thus, Jeremiah is compared with Jonah in an inverted way."

Adapted from Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [*Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah*](#). Almond Press. 102-103.

The Sailors Fear Responsibility for Jonah's Blood

The sailors cry out to Yahweh in fear that they might incur the blood-guilt of the prophet that rejected his mission to the city of blood-guilt.

Jonah 1:14 Instructor's Translation

“Please Yahweh, don’t let us perish on account of this man’s life, and don’t place innocent blood upon us (אל תתן ... דם נקיא), for you, Yahweh, have done just as you have purposed.”

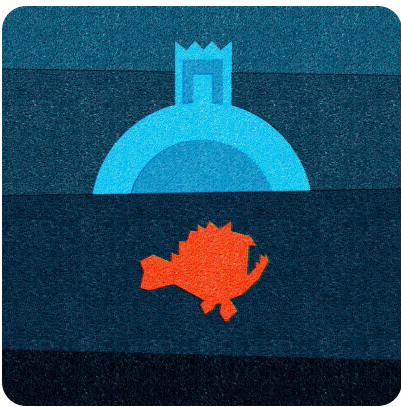
These are the only three texts in the Hebrew Bible where the phrase “place innocent blood” (נתן + דם נקי) is used.

“The significant fact [in [Deuteronomy 21](#)] is that someone’s blood has been shed, and atonement must be made for the death by the symbolic killing of a calf ... the elders of the nearest town are not literally responsible for the murder, but they are in a sense ritually responsible, hence the rite of atonement. [This indirectly connects] with the situation of the sailors, who are concerned with the murder they are about to commit, to a man who is actually the guilty one (at least before God) ... In Jeremiah the ‘bad’ people wish to kill the ‘good’ prophet, and he pleads for his own life, not for his own sake, but because his death will bring the stain of ‘innocent blood’ upon Jerusalem. In contrast to both of these scenarios, Jonah, the ‘bad’ prophet, faced with the ‘good’ sailors asks that he be thrown overboard, and it is the sailors who try to prevent this act. Ironically, it is they, not the prophet, who are aware of the significance of shedding innocent blood and pray that God not hold this against them. The author of Jonah has synthesized the two texts, taking the context of Jeremiah while using the language of Deuteronomy.”

Adapted from Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah](#). Almond Press. 72-73.

Reflection Question

Are many people selected by casting lots in the Bible?



Module 6: Exploring Jonah

Chapter 2

SESSIONS 29-35

Explore Jonah chapter 2 and the meaning of the great fish.

Session 29: The Meaning of the Great Fish

Key Takeaways

- In the Bible, giant sea creatures like the one that swallowed Jonah are dangerous, but they are totally within God's control.
- Jonah's time in the fish is portrayed as a kind of death. But will this passage through death into new life change him? That's the big question explored in the last chapter of Jonah.

Narrative Structure of Jonah's Prayer

A 1:17a And **Yahweh** appointed a great **fish** to **swallow Jonah**,

B 1:17b and Jonah was in the inner-parts of the fish for three days and three nights.

B' 2:1 And Jonah prayed to Yahweh from the inner-parts of the fish.

2:2-9 **[Jonah's Prayer]**

A' 2:10 And **Yahweh** spoke to the **fish**, and it **vomited Jonah** to the dry land.

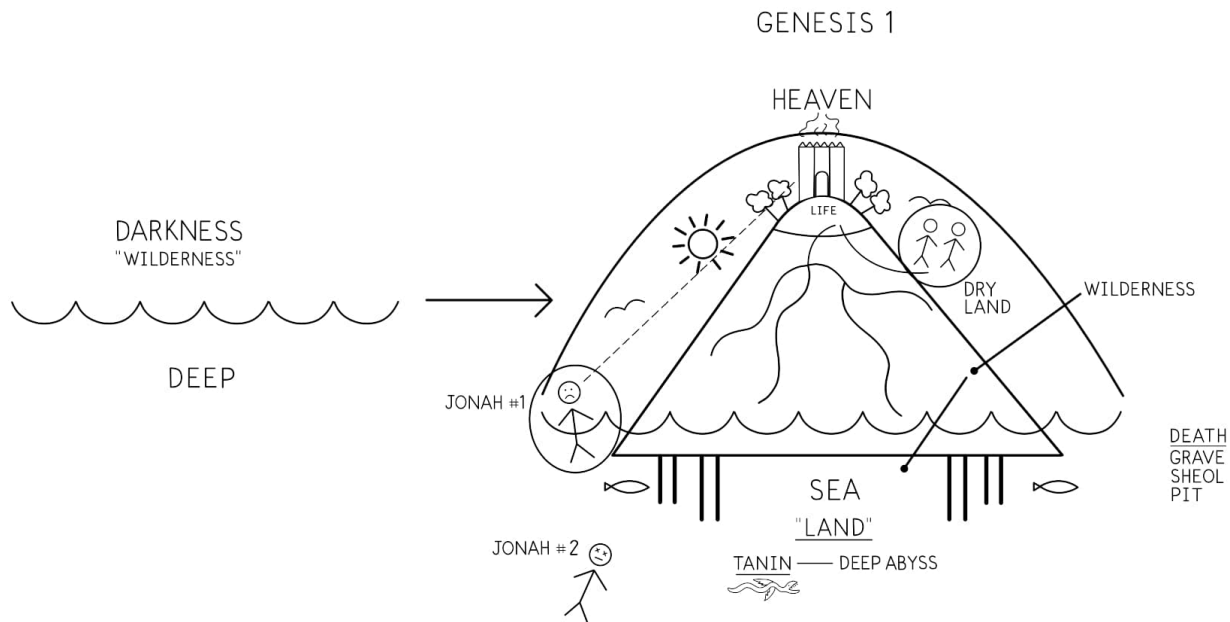
Jonah 1:17-2:10. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

The Great Fish

The biblical authors were well aware of great, monstrous creatures in the deep sea. They were considered deities among Israel's neighbors, but for the biblical authors, they were extremely powerful creatures who were under the rule of their Creator.

Great Sea Creatures in the Hebrew Bible

Genesis 1 provides the foundation for understanding the ancient cosmology of the biblical authors. Here we are introduced to the important creature of the sea monster/sea dragon (Heb. *tannin* / תנין) and Leviathan as



A Hebrew Understanding of the Cosmos in Genesis 1. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Genesis 1:20-21 NASB

²⁰ Then God said, “Let the waters teem with swarms of living creatures, and let birds fly above the earth in the open expanse of the heavens.” ²¹ God created the great sea monsters and every living creature that moves, with which the waters swarmed after their kind ...

Later in [Genesis 1:26](#), God commissions his human images to “rule over the fish (Heb. *dag* / גֹּדֶל) of the sea.” So in the narrative sequence of Genesis 1, the sea monsters are associated with the “fish of the sea.” This explains why the author of Jonah has him swallowed by a “great fish” instead of a “great sea monster.”

In the Old Greek translation, “sea monster” in [Genesis 1:21](#) was translated as *κῆτος* (sea monster), precisely the same way the Greek translators of [Jonah 1:17](#) translated the phrase “the great fish” (Heb. גֹּדֶל הַדָּג) “the great sea monster” (*κῆτος μέγας*).

Psalms 104:24-27 NASB*

²⁴ O LORD, how many are your works! ...

²⁵ There is the sea, great and broad,
in which are swarms without number,
animals both small and great.

²⁶ There the ships move along,
and Leviathan, which you have formed to play in it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 148:7-8 NASB*

⁷ Praise the LORD from the earth,
Sea monsters [Hebrew: *tannin* / Old Greek: δράκον] and all the depths,
⁸ fire and hail, snow and clouds;
stormy wind, fulfilling his word;

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The terms leviathan (Heb. לִיָּתָן) and *tannin* were adopted from the mythological imagery of Israel's neighbors to refer to human and spiritual forces of evil and chaos. The biblical authors adopted this imagery and applied it to their conviction that Yahweh alone is the one who defeats the powers of evil and chaos.

Isaiah 51:9-10 NASB*

⁹ Awake, awake, put on strength, O arm of the LORD;
awake as in the days of old, the generations of long ago.
Was it not you who cut Rahab in pieces,
who pierced the sea monster?
¹⁰ Was it not you who dried up the sea,
the waters of the great deep;
who made the depths of the sea a pathway
for the redeemed to cross over?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 74:12-14 NASB

¹² Yet God is my king from of old,
who works deeds of deliverance in the midst of the earth.
¹³ You divided the sea by your strength;
you broke the heads of the sea monsters in the waters.
¹⁴ you crushed the heads of Leviathan ...

"The great fish is a comic version of an ancient nightmare, the great monster of the deep that represents chaos and destruction, the flooding and undoing of the world ... In bearing witness to the power of the God of Israel, Scripture often reckons with the nightmares of ancient near eastern mythology and puts the images to its own uses ... In Jonah the nightmare is turned into comedy. The creature that swallows Jonah up is not one of the terrible monsters of the deep ... but just a great big fish ... Call it a monster if you wish, it's no big deal. Wherever you go in the world, the LORD who created it is there before you and can prepare a way for you, even if the way is a great big fish."

Cary, Phillip (2008), [*Jonah*](#). Brazos Press. 76.

There are two other biblical texts that depict Israel's ancient enemies as the sea monster, and one of them is the only other passage where a great sea creature swallows someone alive.

Ezekiel 29:3 NASB*

"Thus says the Lord God,
'Behold, I am against you, Pharaoh king of Egypt,
the great sea monster that lies in the midst of his rivers ...'"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Egypt

Jeremiah 51:34 NASB*

Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon has devoured me, crushed me,
he has set me down as an empty vessel;
he has swallowed me like a sea monster;
he has filled his stomach with my delicacies;
he has washed me away.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Babylon

This fits with other instances in biblical poetry of Israel being "swallowed up," which is consistently an image of being overcome by enemy nations.

Psalms 124:2-5 NIV*

² If the LORD had not been on our side
when humans attacked us,
³ they would have swallowed us alive
when their anger flared against us;
⁴ the flood would have engulfed us,
the torrent would have swept over us,
⁵ the arrogant waters
would have swept us away.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

See [Exodus 18:11](#)

Lamentations 2:16 NASB

All your enemies
have opened their mouths wide against you;
they hiss and gnash their teeth;
they say, "We have swallowed her up!"

Hosea 8:8 NASB

Israel is swallowed up;
they are now among the nations
like a vessel in which no one delights.

See also [Psalm 35:25](#) and [Isaiah 49:19](#)

The story of Jonah has drawn together all of these images of Egypt and Babylon as great sea monsters swallowing God's people into exile and slavery. But God's power can protect his people despite their "submarine death" so that a re-created people can emerge out the other side (as in [Ezek. 37](#)).

"The original readers of Jonah would have seen these connections right away: long ago Israel passed safely through the sea in their exodus from Egypt, and more recently Israel was swallowed up by the greatest beast of them all, Babylon the great, which the prophet Jeremiah calls "the great monster that has swallowed me up" ([Jer 51:34](#)) ... And yet, after being swallowed up by Babylon, the remnant of Israel was kept safe in the belly of Babylon (see the stories of Daniel or [Jeremiah 29](#)). Jonah swallowed up by a sea monster is a parallel image to the Jewish people going into exile, yet still alive and still having a future as they sings songs in the belly of the beast ..."

Adapted from Cary, Phillip (2008), [Jonah](#). Brazos Press. 76-77.

Early Artwork of Jonah's Great Fish

Mosaics from fourth century C.E., Basilica Patriarchale in Aquileia, Italy



Agricola, Peter (2009). Jonah and the sea-monster (Ketos). [Flickr](#).



HEN-Magonza (2021). Aquileia, Basilica, floor mosaic, Jonah thrown on the beach. [Flickr](#).

Sixth century stone-carved door lintel and fourth century Coptic tapestry from Monastery of Bawit in Upper Egypt (Louvre, Paris)



Korshi (2019). Unknown. [CopticMagicalPapyri](#).



Korshi (2019). Unknown. [CopticMagicalPapyri](#).

From the catacomb of St. Priscilla, Rome (2nd-4th century C.E.)



Leinad, Creative Commons (2006). Jonah thrown into the Sea. [Wikimedia](#).

Reflection Question

What kinds of things does the author want us to understand when we read that Jonah is swallowed by a fish?
What are the biblical ideas related to large sea creatures that the author is assuming we know?

Session 30: Reflecting on the Sea Monster

Key Takeaways

- The point of Jonah isn't to relay security camera footage of what happened to him. The point of the book is the meaning of what happened to him.
- God chose to reveal himself through the ancient Israelites and their framework of the world. So if we want to understand the Bible, we have to understand their framework.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

Some might say that because the Bible is the word of God, the biblical authors can't be wrong in their descriptions of the world. What are some of your thoughts, questions, or reflections on this?

Session 31: The Meaning of Three Days and Three Nights

Key Takeaways

- “Three days,” the time Jonah was in the belly of the fish, was a common phrase that conveyed the idea of a dangerous, ominous journey that brought someone near to death.

A Fishy Womb?

In [Jonah 2:1](#), the word “fish” is a masculine noun, *dag* (דג), but in [2:2](#), “from the belly of the fish,” unexpectedly uses a feminine noun, *dagah* (דגה).

“Interpreters have noted that the Hebrew term for ‘the fish’ changes from the masculine form *haddāg* in verse 1 to the feminine form *haddāgā* in verse 2 [nrsv: 1]. Although this shift remains problematic, Jonah’s presence in the belly of the fish suggests the imagery of pregnancy for the fish and new birth or new creation for Jonah.”

Sweeney, Marvin A. (2000). [Berit Olam: Studies in Hebrew Narrative and Poetry: The Twelve Prophets](#). Liturgical Press. 317.

“[T]he male fish (*dag*) that devoured Jonah in 2:1 becomes a female (*dagah*) for Jonah once he enters her entrails. The point is forced upon us further as we hear Jonah, from the belly of a female fish, sing a misguided song from the womb of Sheol.”

Ackerman, James (1981). “Satire and Symbolism in the Song of Jonah.” [Traditions in Transformation: Turning Points in Biblical Faith](#). Eisenbrauns. 235-256.

Three Days and Three Nights

The landmark study on this phrase was made by George Landes in “The Three Days and Three Nights Motif in Jonah 2:1” from the *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 86 (1967), pages 446-450.

Within the Hebrew Bible, the time span of “three days and nights” or arriving somewhere “on the third day” appears in two main connections.

A Time of Testing, Danger, or Near-Death

This phrase is often used to signify a period of testing or danger that brings someone near death.

1 Samuel 30:12b NASB

For he had not eaten bread or drunk water for three days and three nights.

2 Kings 20:5, 8 NASB

⁵ Return and say to Hezekiah the leader of my people, "This is what the LORD, the God of your father David says: 'I have heard your prayer, I have seen your tears; behold, I am going to heal you. On the third day you shall go up to the house of the LORD.'" ... ⁸ Now Hezekiah said to Isaiah, "What will be the sign that the LORD will heal me, and that I will go up to the house of the LORD on the third day?"

Hosea 6:1-2 NASB

¹ Come, let's return to the LORD.
For he has torn us, but he will heal us;
he has wounded us, but he will bandage us.
² He will revive us after two days;
he will raise us up on the third day,
that we may live before him.

"In each case, the time period is specified not to imply the still present possibility of a deliverance but to emphasize the comparative duration of the affliction under the circumstances."

Landes, George (1967). ["The 'Three Days and Three Nights' Motif in Jonah 2:1."](#) *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 86. 448.

An Ominous Journey

"Three days" is also used in the Bible to signal an ominous or challenging journey.

- The Israelites' journey from Egypt through the waters to Mount Sinai was to take three days ([Exod. 3:18, 5:3, 8:27, 15:22](#)).
- The first three-day journey in the Bible is Abraham's journey to Jerusalem to sacrifice Isaac ([Gen. 22:4](#)).
- See also [Joshua 2:16, 9:17](#); [1 Samuel 30:1](#); [2 Samuel 20:4](#); [2 Kings 2:17](#).

The most ancient appearance of the phrase "three days and three nights" is in a Sumerian (ca. 1800 B.C.E.) mythological text, where the goddess descends into the underworld of death to visit her recently dead sister Ereshkigal. The time of her "virtual death" is described as three days and three nights.

"The three days and three nights are intended to cover the time of Inanna's travel to the depths of the underworld ... This appears to be a most promising clue for understanding the full import of this phrase to ancient near eastern scribes and readers, including the author of Jonah. In Jonah 2:1 the phrase indicates the period of time it took the fish to bring Jonah back from the Deep, understood more explicitly in the following poem as the netherworld ([2:2](#) 'from the belly of Sheol') ... Jonah's residence in the fish is therefore not the same thing as being in the Deep or in Sheol, and the fish is not employed as a personification of the chaotic waters or the realm of the dead. It is clearly before Jonah is swallowed by the fish that he is threatened by the sea and in danger of permanent residence in the nether world."

Landes, George (1967). "The 'Three Days and Three Nights' Motif in Jonah 2:1." *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 86. 448.

Hosea chapters 5 and 6 are also relevant to our understanding of "three days" in the Hebrew Bible.

Hosea 5:13-15 NASB*

¹³ When Ephraim saw his sickness,
and Judah his wound,
then Ephraim went to Assyria
and sent to the great king.
But he is unable to heal you,
or to cure you of your wound.

¹⁴ For I am like a lion to Ephraim
and like a young lion to the house of Judah.
I, even I, will tear to pieces and go away,
I will carry away, and there will be none to deliver.

¹⁵ I will go away and return to my place
until they acknowledge their guilt and seek my face;
in their distress (לו בצר) they will earnestly seek me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Hosea 6:1-3 NASB

¹ Come, let us return to the LORD.
For he has torn us, but he will heal us;
he has wounded us, but he will bandage us.

² He will bring us life after two days;
he will raise us up on the third day,
that we may have life in his presence.

³ So let us know, let us press on to know the LORD.
His going forth is as certain as the dawn;
and he will come to us like the rain,
like the spring rain watering the earth.

Notice that in Hosea 5-6 and in Jonah 2, Yahweh is the one controlling a terrifying animal (lion/great fish). And while being devoured by this animal would be certain death in normal circumstances, with the creator of life, apparent death can become a strange vehicle for humbling leading to new life.

Jesus draws on this network of "three day" passages when he uses the phrase "three days" or "on the third day" to describe his liberation from death into resurrection life (Matt. 12:40, 16:21; Luke 24:21, 46).

Reflection Question

What's the significance of Jonah being in the fish for three days and three nights? What are we supposed to understand?

Session 32: Reflecting on Three Days and Three Nights

Key Takeaways

- Passage and rebirth through the waters is a key theme in the Hebrew Bible.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

What questions or thoughts do you have about the theme of the three days and three nights?

Session 33: Metaphors for Death in Hebrew Poetry

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors place poems at key moments in the story when God gives an Eden moment to his people.
- These inset poems take individual narratives about the Israelites and apply them to the cosmic story line of the whole biblical narrative.

Jonah's Song Compared With Other Songs of Deliverance

Jonah's prayer has much in common with the other inset prayers in the Hebrew Bible that take place either right after or right before deliverance. The key study here was done by James Watts in [Psalm and Story: Inset Hymns in Hebrew Narrative](#).

Notably, all of these examples contain images of either rescue from dangerous waters or ascent from the grave into the land of the living.

Poems of Thanksgiving After Deliverance

Exodus 15:1-13 NASB

¹ Then Moses and the sons of Israel sang this song to the LORD, and said,
"I will sing to the LORD, for he is highly exalted;
the horse and its rider he has hurled into the sea.

² The LORD is my strength and song,
and he has become my salvation ...

⁴ Pharaoh's chariots and his army he has cast into the sea;
and the choicest of his officers are drowned in the Sea of Reed.

⁵ The deeps cover them;
they went down into the depths like a stone. ...

⁸ At the blast of your nostrils the waters were piled up,
the flowing waters stood up like a heap;
the deeps were congealed in the heart of the sea. ...

¹⁰ You blew with your wind, the sea covered them;
they sank like lead in the mighty waters. ...

¹² You stretched out your right hand,
the underworld swallowed them.

¹³ In your lovingkindness you have led the people whom you have redeemed;
in your strength you have guided to your holy habitation."

2 Samuel 22:4-7, 16-18 NASB

⁴ I call upon the LORD, who is worthy to be praised,
and I am saved from my enemies.

⁵ For the waves of death encompassed me;
the torrents of destruction overwhelmed me;

⁶ the cords of Sheol surrounded me;
the snares of death confronted me.

⁷ In my distress I called upon the LORD,
yes, I cried to my God;
and from his temple he heard my voice,
and my cry for help came into his ears. ...

¹⁶ Then the channels of the sea appeared,
the foundations of the world were laid bare
by the rebuke of the LORD,
at the blast of the breath of his nostrils.

¹⁷ He sent from on high, he took me;
he drew me out of many waters.

¹⁸ He delivered me from my strong enemy,
from those who hated me, for they were too strong for me.

Judges 5:19-21 NASB*

¹⁹ The kings came and fought;
then fought the kings of Canaan
at Taanach near the waters of Megiddo;
they took no plunder in silver.

²⁰ The stars fought from heaven,
from their courses they fought against Sisera.

²¹ The river of Kishon swept them away,
the ancient river, the torrent Kishon.
O my soul, march on with strength.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Poems of Thanksgiving Right Before Deliverance

1 Samuel 2:5-8 NASB

⁵ Those who were full hire themselves out for bread,
but those who were hungry cease to hunger.
Even the barren gives birth to seven,
but she who has many children languishes.

⁶ The LORD kills and makes alive;
he brings down to Sheol and raises up.

⁷ The LORD makes poor and rich;
he brings low, he also exalts.

⁸ He raises the poor from the dust,
he lifts the needy from the ash heap
to make them sit with nobles,
and inherit a seat of honor;
for the pillars of the earth are the LORD's,
and he set the world on them.

Isaiah 38:10-11, 18-20 NASB

¹⁰ I said, "In the middle of my life
I am to enter the gates of Sheol;
I am to be deprived of the rest of my years."

¹¹ I said, "I will not see the LORD,
the LORD in the land of the living;
I will look on man no more among the inhabitants of the world. ...

¹⁸ For Sheol cannot thank you,
death cannot praise you;
those who go down to the pit cannot hope for your faithfulness.

¹⁹ It is the living who give thanks to you, as I do today;
a father tells his sons about your faithfulness.

²⁰ The LORD will surely save me;
so we will play my songs on stringed instruments
all the days of our life at the house of the LORD."

The Cosmology of Biblical Poetry

These inset poems all occur in stories of Yahweh providing some kind of deliverance and rescue for his people. But notice that each poem magnifies the scope of the rescue to cosmic proportions. In this way, the biblical authors show their interest in telling us the story of God's wider purposes to rescue all humanity and all creation.

Notice also that each poem assumes the cosmology of Genesis 1-2, namely the three-tiered world of sky-land-sea, and each realm is associated with unique theological themes.

Sky

The sky is the divine realm of life and is poetically linked to mountains, high rocks, the temple, and God's heavenly temple.

Psalms 11:4 NIV*

The LORD is in his holy temple;
the LORD is on his heavenly throne.
He observes everyone on the land;
his eyes examine them.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 66:1 NIV*

“The heavens are my throne
and the land is my footstool.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Land

The land is the human and animal realm, floating by God’s power above the sea and bordered by the sea.

Proverbs 8:27-29 NIV

²⁷ I was there when he set the heavens in place,
when he marked out the horizon on the face of the deep,
²⁸ when he established the clouds above
and fixed securely the fountains of the deep,
²⁹ when he gave the sea its boundary,
so the waters would not overstep his command,
and when he marked out the foundations of the earth.

Psalms 24:1-2 NASB*

¹ The land is the LORD’s, and all it contains,
the world, and those who dwell in it.
² For he has founded it upon the seas
and established it upon the rivers.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 75:3 NASB*

The land ...
it is I who have set it upon its pillars

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Wilderness

The wilderness is the uncultivated land and the realm of death. It is hostile to human flourishing.

Sea

Like the wilderness, the sea is a realm of death and disorder. It is poetically depicted as the deep, the waters under the land, the grave/sheol, and even the giant sea monster.

Psalms 69:1-2, 15 NASB

¹ Save me, O God,
for the waters have threatened my life.
² I have sunk in deep mire, and there is no foothold;

I have come into deep waters, and a flood overflows me. ...

¹⁵ May the flood of water not overflow me
nor the deep swallow me up,
nor the pit shut its mouth on me.

Psalm 88:3-7 NASB

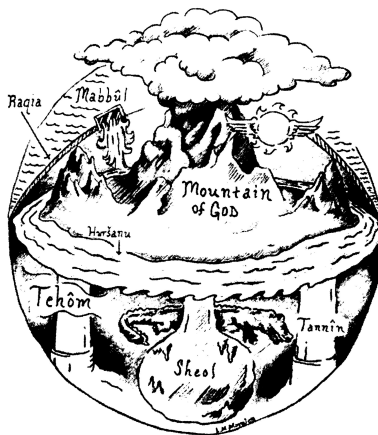
³ For my soul has had enough troubles,
and my life has drawn near to Sheol.

⁴ I am reckoned among those who go down to the pit;
I have become like a man without strength,

⁵ forsaken among the dead,
like the slain who lie in the grave,
whom you remember no more,
and they are cut off from your hand.

⁶ You have put me in the lowest pit,
in dark places, in the depth. ...

⁷ And you have afflicted me with all your waves.



Morales, L. Michael (2015). *Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?: A Biblical Theology of the Book of Leviticus*. IVP Academic.

Reflection Question

What are some of the images or metaphors used for coming near to death in Hebrew poetry? Which of these occur in Jonah's poem?

Session 34: Jonah's Prayer: Oddities and Observations

Key Takeaways

- The image of a prophet composing a poem in the belly of a beast is odd, but so is the prayer's content. Why is it a thanksgiving for deliverance instead of a confession of guilt or a plea to be released from the fish?
- When the text doesn't give clear answers, it's an invitation for us to meditate on the story and author's message.

Jonah's Prayer: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 2:2-9

A

² I called out from my distress **to Yahweh** ,
and he answered me.

From the belly of the grave I shouted for help,
and you heard my voice.

B

³ **And you cast me to the deep, to the heart of the seas** .
And **a river surrounded me** .
All your waves and breakers passed over me.

C

⁴ And I said: "I am banished from before your eyes.
However, I will continue to gaze **to your holy temple** ."

B'

⁵ The waters encircled me up to the neck.
The deep surrounded me,
kelp wrapped to my head.

⁶ To the bases of the mountains I went down.
The underworld, its bars around me forever,
but you raised up my life from the pit, Yahweh my God .

C'

⁷ When my being was fainting within me,
I remembered Yahweh,

and my prayer came to you
to your holy temple.

A'

⁸ Those who keep idols of worthlessness
forsake the covenant love shown them

⁹ but I, with a voice of thanksgiving, I will sacrifice **to you**.
What I have vowed I will pay in full.

Rescue belongs **to Yahweh** !

Jonah 2:2-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

The prayer begins and ends (A and A') with Jonah's orientation "to Yahweh," first crying out from his distress, and then vowing allegiance after his deliverance. Inside of this is Yahweh's action of first casting him into the seas (B), which is reversed in B' as God draws him up from the pit. Matched with the descent is his final hopeful glance up to Yahweh's temple (C), which is matched by his prayer ascending to Yahweh's temple (C'), which leads to his deliverance.

Jonah's descent is marked in two stages. In B, Jonah is sinking into the deep waters, while in B', he has hit bottom and reached the underworld. It is precisely at this moment that his descent converts into an ascent from the pit.

Notice how B begins with Yahweh's initiative in casting him down into the deep, but then the conclusion of B' makes Yahweh's action central in raising him up from the pit. Jonah's double descent is matched by a twin upward orientation. In C, all he can manage is to look to God's temple. But after he is assured of deliverance in C', he can know that his prayer has actually ascended to God's temple.

"The stages of descent in the poem are described with almost geographical exactitude: at first the 'flood,' the breakers and waves pass over him; he descends further to the base of the mountains till the very earth closes over him. Every other description of 'danger from the waters' in the book of Psalms consists of a series of synonymous phrases which are interchangeable, but no other examples of such a prolonged, consecutive descent are described ... It displays essentially a narrative technique that has organized the symbolic terminology of the 'underworld' into a coherent pattern of the continuing descent."

Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [*Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah*](#). Almond Press. 40-41.

Metaphorical Imagery of the Poem

Notice how all of the various metaphors for death in biblical poetry have been associated.

Images of Death in 2:3

- “From the belly of Sheol”: the grave in the underworld
- “The deep” (Heb. *metsulah*): the depths of the open oceans
- “The heart of the seas”: the depths of the open oceans
- “A river”: the ocean currents

Images of Death in 2:5

- “The waters”: general term for rivers, oceans, or underworld waters
- “The deep”: the waters under the earth
- “Kelp”: the vegetation at the bottom of the sea
- “The bases of the mountains” + “the underworld”: the base/bottom of the cosmic dome

Reflection Question

What strikes you as odd in Jonah’s poem?

Session 35: Reflecting on Jonah's Prayer

Key Takeaways

- Jonah is so self-consumed that he doesn't realize he's self-consumed.
- Jonah perceives the sailors as the idolators, but Jonah's actions recall the rebellious Israelites who made the golden calf. He's trying to make his own paradise, and he's greedy for a life without God.
- Jonah's prayer deepens the mystery of his character and motives, and that's okay.
- Every line of the prayer poem comes from the Psalms with subtle tweaks.

Oddities and Observations About Jonah's Poem

The image of a prophet composing a poem in the belly of a beast is odd, but so is the prayer's content. Why is it a thanksgiving for deliverance instead of a confession of guilt or a plea to be released from the fish?

The prayer is a thanksgiving for a rescue that has already happened, though it seems that Jonah is still in danger of death by a monster. But notice that the great fish is actually the vehicle of salvation from death and the underworld. Jonah describes his peril as death by drowning, not by fish digestion.

The tone of Jonah's words (praise, gratefulness, humility) contrasts his oblivious hypocrisy ([Jon. 1:9](#)) and self-consumed anger ([Jon. 4](#)) elsewhere in the book.

"These two Jonah figures [the rebel of chs. 1, 3, and 4; and the grateful of ch. 2] ... do not simply separate into two. It is quite possible that the righteous one enters into the disobedient one and lends him his voice. And when such thanksgiving, strange though it be, comes from lips that are otherwise impious—even when that praise is seriously contradicted by the life of the person in question who does not, perhaps, really understand at all what he is saying—there the sun of divine comfort does shine, even though behind clouds."

von Rad, Gerhard (1980). [God at Work in Israel](#). Abingdon. 70.

"[I]n the context of chapter 1 and the remainder of the book it can only be seen as another inappropriate, hypocritical, pious-sounding affirmation like 1:9 before it and 4:2 after it. By it, Jonah shows the reader more clearly his true colors. His phrases sound good and right, but in the event they turn out to be empty. The negative character portrayal of Jonah in chapter 1 is sharpened in 2, as he is further and further separated from those around him by his appalling behavior. This separation is not complete until the book's end, where Jonah is in fact physically separated from everyone."

Holbert, John (1981). "Deliverance Belongs to Yahweh!: Satire in the Book of Jonah." *Journal for the Study of the Old Testament*, vol. 6 (21). 74-75.

“The psalm does present Jonah as an orthodox and pious Yahwist who responds to salvation with appropriate thanksgiving. Through its vivid description of the experience and emotions of drowning, it provides readers intimate insight into Jonah’s thoughts and feelings, thereby casting him in a more sympathetic light. Simultaneously the context highlights Jonah’s lack of reflection on his conflict with Yahweh. The tension between the sympathetic portrait in the psalm and the judgment implied by the book as a whole is acute, but not inherently contradictory. The psalm simply elicits reader identification with Jonah to such a degree that the confrontation with Jonah’s true motivations in ch. 4 forces them to share his discomfort.”

Watts, James W. (1992). [Psalm and Story: Inset Hymns in Hebrew Narrative](#). A&C Black. 139.

Key Hyperlinked Psalms in Jonah’s Prayer

Nearly every line in Jonah’s prayer has been adapted from poems throughout the book of Psalms. In each case, an image of danger, death, or exile has been associated with Jonah sinking into the sea.

Jonah	Psalms
I called out from my distress to Yahweh and he answered me. From the belly of the fish I shouted for help and you heard my voice.	120:1: To Yahweh in my distress I called, and he answered me. 31:22b: You heard the voice of plea when I shouted to you for help.
And you cast me to the deep, to the heart of the seas. And a river surrounded me. All your waves and breakers passed over me.	102:10: You lifted me up and cast me away. Exodus 15:8: At the wind of your nostrils, waters congealed ... deep in the heart of the sea. 42:7: All your waves and breakers passed over me.
And I said: I am banished from before your eyes. However, I will continue to gaze to your holy temple.	31:22a: And as for me, I said, I am cut off from before your eyes. 138:2: I will bow toward your holy temple.
The waters encircled me up to the neck. The deep surrounded me. Kelp wrapped to my head, to the base of the mountains I went down. The underworld, its bars around me, forever.	18:4, 116:3: Cords of death encircled me. 69:2: The waters ... up to my neck. 103:4: He redeems my life from the pit.

Hyperlinked Psalms in Jonah’s Prayer. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Jonah	Psalms
But you raise up my life from the pit, Yahweh my God.	
When my being was fainting within me, I remembered Yahweh. And my prayer came to you, to your holy temple.	143:4-5: When my spirit was fainting within me ... I remember. 88:2: May my prayer come before you.
Those who keep idols of worthlessness forsake the covenant love shown them. But I, with a voice of thanksgiving, I will sacrifice to you. What I have vowed I will pay in full. Rescue belongs to Yahweh!	31:6: I hate those who keep idols of worthlessness, but I ... rejoice in your covenant love. 116:17-18: To you I will offer a sacrifice of thanksgiving ... I will pay my vows. 3:8: Rescue belongs to Yahweh!
<i>Hyperlinked Psalms in Jonah's Prayer. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).</i>	

Because we can trace the source texts, Jonah's prayer provides a fascinating window into the methods of biblical composition.

The poem's opening line is adapted from Psalm 120:1

Psalm 120:1 Instructor's Translation

To Yahweh **in** my distress I called
and he answered me

Jonah 2:2 Instructor's Translation

I called **from** my distress Yahweh
and he answered me

The word order has been changed so that in Jonah 2, the speaker's call to Yahweh is now emphasized by being placed at the beginning.

The prepositional phrase has been adapted from "**in** my distress" (לי בצרתה) to "**from** my distress" (הדגה ממעי) and aligned with the context as Jonah prays "from the innards of the fish" (לי מצרה) and cries out "from the belly of the grave" (שואל מבטן). (Magonet, *Form and Meaning*, 47).

Jonah 2:3	Source Texts
And you cast me into the deep (מצולה),	Exodus 15:4 Pharaoh's chariots and his army he has cast into the sea; and the choicest of his officers are drowned in the Sea of Reeds. Psalms 102:10 Because of your indignation and your wrath, for you have lifted me up and you cast me away (מפני־זעמך וקצפך כי נשאתני ותשליכני). Psalms 69:15 Don't let the flood of water overflow me and don't let the deep (מצולה) swallow me up nor the pit shut its mouth on me.
Into the heart of the seas ,	Exodus 15:8 At the blast of your nostrils the waters piled up ... the deeps congealed in the heart of the seas. Ezekiel 27:4, 25-27; 28:2, 8 All applied to Tyre
And the river surrounded me.	Genesis 2:10-14 The river of Eden surrounds Havilah and Cush
All your breakers and billows passed over me .	Psalms 42:6-7 O my God, my soul is in despair within me; therefore I remember you from the land of the Jordan and the peaks of Hermon, from Mount Mizar. Deep calls to deep at the sound of your waterfalls; all your breakers and your waves have rolled over me.
Source Texts in Scripture for Jonah 2:3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Notice how images of the defeat of Pharaoh in the seas ([Exod. 15](#)) have been adapted into imagery to describe a personal crisis ([Ps. 102, 69](#)), the downfall of a city (Tyre in [Ezek. 27](#)), and the exile from the Jerusalem temple ([Ps. 42](#)).

Jonah 2:4

Jonah 2:4 NASB*

As for me, I said: I am **banished**
from before Yahweh.
Nevertheless ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 31:22 NASB*

And as for me I said **in my alarm**
I am **cut off** from before Yahweh.
Nevertheless ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Note that this line adapts Psalm 31:22 verbatim, except for the phrase “in my alarm.” The absence of “in my alarm” (בַּחֲפוּזִי) from Psalm 31:22 can be explained as unnecessary to the author’s portrayal of Jonah. In Psalm 31:22, the poet portrays his distress as one in a city under siege, which causes alarm until he calls out for deliverance. In Jonah 2, Jonah’s inner-shift of orientation only happens after his total “descent” into death, which has not yet happened in the sequence of the poem.

The replacement of “I am cut off” with “I am banished” (נִגְרָשְׁתִּי) ties Jonah’s descent into the exile pattern based on [Genesis 3-4](#).

Jonah 2:5

Jonah 2:5 NASB*

Waters have encompassed me unto my neck.
The deep has surrounded me,
reeds bound to my head.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The author has brought together phrases from multiple texts.

“They have encompassed me” (אֶפְסוּנִי) comes from either Psalm 18:4 or [116:3](#).

Psalm 18:4-5 NASB*

⁴ The cords of death encompassed me;
the torrents of destruction overwhelmed me.
⁵ The cords of the grave surrounded me;
the snares of death confronted me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Waters ... unto my neck” comes from Psalm 69:2.

Psalm 69:1-2 NASB*

¹ Save me, O God,
for the waters have come up to my neck.
² I have sunk in mire of the deep, and there is no foothold.
I have come into deep waters, and a flood overflows me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The composition of Jonah 2:5 is a combination of two distinct texts, Psalms 18 and 69.

Psalms 18:4 NASB

The cords of death **have encompassed me**;

Psalms 69:1 NIV

For **the waters** have come **up to my neck**,

Jonah 2:5 NASB*

... have encompassed me
waters ... up to my neck

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

But why the avoidance of the phrase “cords of death” in Psalm 18:4? Though the word “death” may seem appropriate to this poem, this word would be out of place as it seems to be a key word restricted to the final chapter of Jonah. Although Jonah has approached symbolic death and implied that he wished to die by being cast overboard, it is still too soon in the writer’s purpose to spell out the prophet’s wish, for it would destroy the tension in his argument with God in chapter 4.

Jonah 2:8 Instructor's Translation

Those who keep empty idols abandon the covenant love of them.

What does “empty idols” (שוא הבל) mean? Both words are associated with derogatory vocabulary for idols, asserting their inability to help because they are only statues and not deities.

Zechariah 10:2 Instructor's Translation

For idols speak deceit,
and diviners conjure lies,
and dreams speak falsehood (שוא);
they offer empty (הבל) comfort.

Deuteronomy 32:21 Instructor's Translation

They ignited my passion with what is not-god,
they provoked me with their nothings (הבל).

Covenant Loyalty

What about “their covenant loyalty” (חסדם)? The third-person masculine plural suffix on “their covenant love” could be subjective or objective.

Subjective

Their covenant love toward God: Maintaining allegiance to idols is a violation of one’s covenant obligations toward God.

“[I]dols represent not only ineffectiveness; worshiping them also shows a lack of faith in Yahweh. For any Israelite to trust in idol worship was a violation of the covenant. Covenant loyalty (חסד) was a mutual obligation both of God, the initiator of the covenant (Exod 20:6, etc.), and of the Israelites to whom the covenant was given. Accordingly, one who broke the covenant’s first commandment by having other gods had ‘abandoned’ (עזב) his or her loyalty to Yahweh.”

Stuart, Douglas (1987). *Word Biblical Commentary Vol. 31, Hosea-Jonah*. Thomas Nelson Inc. 478.

Objective

God’s covenant love toward them: Giving allegiance to idols forfeits the divine covenant commitment that God shows to his faithful people.

“Here (חסד), ‘steadfast love,’ does not mean human faithfulness. It means the divine attitude which in the Psalter is continually extolled as God’s faithfulness, goodness, and graciousness, which is the one true help for human beings. The third person plural suffix does not refer to the subject of the faithfulness; it means its object (cf. Ps. 59:17*; 144:2*), i.e., those to whom the dependable help is given. In 4:2* חסד, as almost always, is one of the divine attributes.”

Wolff, Hans Walter (1986). [*Obadiah and Jonah: A Commentary*](#). Augsburg Fortress Pub. 138.

The source of the quotation in Psalm 31:7 clarifies that “God’s covenant loyalty” is likely in view (the “objective” view).

Psalm 31:6-7 NIV*

⁶ **I hate those who keep worthless idols;**
and as for me I trust in Yahweh.
⁷ I rejoice and am glad in **your covenant loyalty**,
for you have seen my affliction
you have known my distress.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 2:8-9 NASB*

⁸ **Those who keep hold of worthless idols**
abandon their **covenant loyalty**,
⁹ **and as for me**, I will sacrifice to you
with a voice of thanksgiving.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"This statement by the poet at this point ... must be a summation of his experience and the lesson he has learned from it ... Yet the sentence by itself, a generalized impersonal statement about the fate of those who 'regard lying vanities' tells us nothing ... The sentence surprises us by its appearance, and puzzles us by having no obvious relationship to the experience described in the poem. So we are forced to go to the only other place where an answer might lie, namely the original source of the phrase in Psalm 31. And here we have a clue in the form of a first person statement: 'I hate,' which is significantly absent in our poem. We are thus led to conclude that the speaker in our poem no longer hates the worshippers of idols but accepts instead that if they continue to regard their idols (the Piel form suggesting a repeated action or a more intense form of attachment), then they will ultimately exhaust the mercy which is bestowed upon them by God, they will forsake their $\tau\omicron\eta\eta$. Thus, the speaker has come to accept a more tolerant, though still rather grudging, view of idolators."

Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [*Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah*](#). Almond Press. 46.

"To ally oneself with idols is folly, for they can give no help. Other gods are contemptuously dismissed as useless idols, worthless nonentities. The contrast in ch. 1 between the ineffectual prayer each to his own god and the answered prayer to Yahweh, sovereign over the sea, is echoed in the declaration and denial of vv. 7, 8. In its original setting this section of the psalm envisaged Israelites who betrayed the covenant by resorting to the worship of other gods, and recorded the speaker's dissociation from them in a profession of complete loyalty and so accessibility to Yahweh's favor. Cutting themselves off from Yahweh's aid, they only 'multiply their sorrows' (Ps. 16:4). His grace, the loyal love that rushes to the aid of his own at their first cry, in the psalm's present context not only glances back to Jonah's deliverance but hints at that of the sailors who abandoned their own gods and relied upon Yahweh. This hint is to be taken up in ch. 4."

Allen, Leslie C. (1976). [*The Books of Joel, Obadiah, Jonah, and Micah*](#). Eerdmans. 218-219.

Reflection Question

What do you make of Jonah's prayer? Is he sincere or hypocritical? Is this even the point the author is trying to make?



Module 7: Exploring Jonah

Chapter 3

SESSIONS 36-39

Does God change his mind? Examine chapter 3 and Jonah's one-day walk into Nineveh and five-word sermon.

Session 36: Jonah’s One-Day Walk Into Nineveh

Key Takeaways

- “A walking of three days” echoes Jonah’s three days inside the fish. The city of Nineveh is named after a goddess whose name means “fish.”
- Jonah’s disobedience lands him in a fish for three days, and his obedience lands him in the fish city for three days. But he actually only spends one day in the city.
- Jonah is a complex and often ambiguous story. It’s helpful to keep the interpretive possibilities open as we read as biblical narratives often use intentional gaps and ambiguities to compel us to participate in the discovery of meaning.

Jonah’s Sermon and Nineveh’s Response: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 3:1-10

A	3:1-4 God’s Actions Toward Nineveh through Jonah The word of Yahweh came to Jonah ... "call out the message that I speak to you.”		
B	a	3:5 The Ninevites Respond And the Ninevites believed in God and called a fast, and clothed with sackcloth .	
	b	3:6 The King of Nineveh Responds He arose from his throne ... covered with sackcloth ... and sat in the dust.	
	a	3:7-9 The King’s Edict to the Ninevites “Don’t eat anything ... or drink water ... cover with sackcloth ... turn from his evil way.”	
A	3:10 God Responds to the Ninevites Actions And God saw their actions ... and he repented of the evil which he spoke to do to them.		
Jonah’s Sermon and Nineveh’s Response. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).			

Observations About This Design

The outer frame (A and A’) focuses on God’s action in confronting Nineveh and then responding to their response. The inner section (B) consist of three scenes of repenting, each intensifying the drastic response from (I) all the people to (II) the king, (III) and the king’s edict to all of the people.

A ¹ And the **word of Yahweh** was to Jonah a second time, saying:
 B ² "Arise, go to **Nineveh the great city** ,
 C and **call out** to it the calling-out which **I am speaking** to you."
 B' ³ And Jonah arose and he went to **Nineveh** ,
 A' according to the **word of Yahweh** .

I Now, Nineveh was a great city to God,
 II **a walking of** three **days** .
 I' ⁴ And Jonah began to go into the **city**
 II' **a walking** of one **day** ,
 III and **he called out** , and he said,
 IV "Forty days, and Nineveh is overturned."

Jonah 3:1-4. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

3:1-3a is symmetrically designed with a focus on Yahweh's word and speech. All forms of the Hebrew word דבר punctuate the opening, middle, and concluding lines (A, C, A').

3:3b-4 is designed as a stair-step series.

- I and II introduce Nineveh's metaphorical greatness to God, followed by its physical greatness in size.
- I' shows Jonah going by God's commission to the great city.
- II' shows his entrance into the city.

But notice the difference between II and II'. We're told that the city was "three day's walking," but then we learn that Jonah only walked "one day's walking" into the city. This disconnect between God's command and Jonah's response should alert our suspicions that all is not well in Jonah's response.

"Nineveh Was a City Great to God"

Jonathan Magonet (*Form and Meaning*, 32-33) discusses this as one of many "growing phrases" in the book. This is a technique of thematic repetition that adds words to phrases as they appear throughout the book, each addition giving further clarification to the theme's significance in the book.

Jonah 1:2 NASB

Go to Nineveh, the great city

Jonah 3:2 NASB

Go to Nineveh, the great city

Jonah 3:3 NASB*

And Nineveh was a great city to God

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 4:11 ESV*

Shouldn't I have pity on Nineveh, the great city, which has in it more than 120,000 people ... ?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"At first we know only of Nineveh's size and its wickedness that has arisen to God ... But when in chapter 3 Jonah comes to the city, then it is revealed as being a great city "to God." As yet we don't know whether this only concerns its great evil (as in 1:2) and its imminent punishment, or if the phrase implies some other relationship to God. It's only in chapter 4, which ends with God's question, that the fullness of the implications of the city's relationship to God and even its size is spelled out: the myriads who don't know their right from left hand and all their cattle."

Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [*Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah*](#). Almond Press. 32-33.

"Three Days Walking"

"About Nineveh's size, Bewer (1912: 50–52) gives ample citations from classical sources, most of which accentuate its inordinate size. R. D. Barnett (1968) and L. C. Allen (1976: 221–22) refer to archaeological and cuneiform sources showing that at its zenith Nineveh was about three miles on its widest axis, almost eight miles in circumference, and occupied about 1,850 acres. Because in a three-day march individuals normally cover thirty to forty miles, some scholars imagine that the narrator is referring to 'greater' Nineveh, that is, the city and its outlying territories and cities (as in [Genesis 10:11-12](#)). Be that as it may, we are not likely to gain much by testing the validity of Jonah's 'three-day walk/journey' against Nineveh's actual dimensions. 'Three-day' merely establishes that a large space separates two positions (see especially [Gen 30:36](#) and [Exod 3:18](#)). Strikingly similar in vocabulary and spirit is the way the Greeks remembered Babylon's size. Herodotus tells us (1.191) that it took a long time before news reached the town's center that the Persians had captured Babylon's fortifications. Aristotle apparently embellishes the same tradition by specifying that the city 'had been taken for three days before some part of the inhabitants became aware of the fact.' In Jonah, the phrase also prepares us to learn about Nineveh's immense population (4:11). More immediately, however, 'three-day walk' sets up an obvious contrast with the 'one-day walk' of the next."

Sasson, Jack M. (1995). [Jonah](#). Yale University Press. 230-231.

The mention of "three days" also recalls Jonah's three days and three nights in the belly of the fish. In fact, in popular Akkadian (the Semitic dialect used in ancient Assyria), the name "Nineveh" sounds like "Nina," a river goddess symbolized by a fish.

"If the thesis of a link between the name of the city and the fish is correct, the story incorporates an ironic play on words that enhances readers' enjoyment: Jonah tries to flee in the opposite direction, to get as far as possible from 'Fish City' and avoid performing his mission. But the Lord intervenes and sees to it that he winds up in a fish all the same—first a marine creature and then the metropolis."

Shemesh, Yael (2010). "'And Many Beasts' (Jonah 4:11): The Function and Status of Animals in the Book of Jonah." *Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*, vol 10. 12.

Reflection Question

In the beginning of Jonah 3, we read that “Nineveh was a going of three days.” But we also read that Jonah goes into the city “one day.” The biblical authors are intentional and selective about what they include in their stories. What are some possible reasons for the author’s inclusion of this detail? What might the author want us to understand?

Session 37: Jonah's Five-Word Sermon to the Ninevites

Key Takeaways

- Jonah's sermon is not typical of a prophet. It is only five words, and he doesn't warn the people or urge them to turn back to Yahweh like other Hebrew prophets.
- Jonah's sermon presents us with a comic contrast. Despite Jonah doing little to warn the people, they still turn back to Yahweh. This creates a strong contrast between the character of Jonah and the Ninevites.
- In the story, everyone is awake to God except Jonah.

Jonah's Five-Word Sermon

Jonah 3:4 NASB*

Yet forty days, and Nineveh is overturned (*nehpaket* / נהפכת).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The root *hapak* (הפך) is overwhelmingly connected to the story of Sodom and Gomorrah's destruction throughout the Hebrew Bible.

Genesis 19:24-25, 29 NASB

²⁴ Then the LORD rained on Sodom and Gomorrah brimstone and fire from the LORD out of heaven, ²⁵ and he overthrew those cities, and all the valley, and all the inhabitants of the cities, and what grew on the ground. ... ²⁹ Thus it came about, when God destroyed the cities of the valley, that God remembered Abraham, and sent Lot out of the midst of the overthrow, when he overthrew the cities in which Lot lived.

Deuteronomy 29:23 NASB

All its land is brimstone and salt, a burning waste, unsown and unproductive, and no grass grows in it, like the overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboiim, which the LORD overthrew in his anger and in his wrath.

Isaiah 13:19 NASB

And Babylon, the beauty of kingdoms, the glory of the Chaldeans' pride, will be as when God overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah.

Jeremiah 49:17-18 NASB

¹⁷ "Edom will become an object of horror; everyone who passes by it will be horrified and will hiss at all its wounds. ¹⁸ Like the overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah with its neighbors," says the LORD, "no one will live there, nor will a son of man reside in it."

Amos 4:10-11 NASB*

¹⁰ "I sent a plague among you after the manner of Egypt ... yet you have not repented to me," declares the LORD.

¹¹ "I overthrew you, as God overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah ... yet you have not repented to me," declares the LORD.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

However, the verb *hapak* can also be used in a more general sense of "turned over," and mean to transform or change.

Deuteronomy 23:5 NIV*

The LORD your God would not listen to Balaam but changed the curse into a blessing for you

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Amos 5:8 NASB

He who made the Pleiades and Orion,
and changes deep darkness into morning,
who also darkens day into night

Psalms 30:11 NIV

You changed my wailing into dancing;
you removed my sackcloth and clothed me with joy

1 Samuel 10:6 NASB

Then the Spirit of the LORD will come upon you mightily, and you shall prophesy with them and be changed into another man.

Interpretive Challenges with Jonah's Short Sermon

Jonah obeys the second divine commission to go to Nineveh, but does he announce the message God gave to him?

Jonah predicts the "overturning" of Nineveh within forty days, which he clearly intends as an announcement of destruction. If this was in fact Yahweh's message given to Jonah, it was either inaccurate or it failed to be fulfilled. If Yahweh's truthfulness is to be upheld, then there are a few logical options for interpretation (see Ray Lubeck, "[Prophetic Sabotage: A Look at Jonah 3:2-4](#)," 37-38).

A Conditional Threat

Jonah did deliver Yahweh's message exactly as he received it, but he, Yahweh, the Ninevites, and we as readers are meant to understand it as something else—a conditional threat that will not be carried out if Nineveh repents.

“That this was [Yahweh's] message ... is self-evident since it was the message which Jonah actually delivered.”

Zlotowitz, Meir (1980). [*Yonah: A New Translation With a Commentary Anthologized from Talmudic, Midrashic and Rabbinic Sources*](#). Messorah Publications. 119.

“[T]hese words are not what Jonah composed, but are exactly what Yahweh told him to say.”

Stuart, Douglas (1987). [*Word Biblical Commentary Vol. 31, Hosea-Jonah*](#). Thomas Nelson. 489.

Problem

The king clearly understands the oracle as an irreversible prediction of judgment ([3:8-9](#): “Let each man turn from his wicked way! Who knows, God might turn and relent!”). While prophets recognize that oracles of judgment might be averted by repentance ([Jer. 18:7-10](#)), those oracles are almost always accompanied by a call to repent.

A Justifiable Threat

Jonah delivered the message as given to him by God, but he knew beforehand that it was false (so he fled as he says in [4:2](#)). Yahweh never intended to execute this overturning, but his threat is justifiable on the grounds that it achieved a higher good, the repentance of the Ninevites.

“[T]he biblical story is not about a prophet but about an unfulfilled prophecy. God's wonderful graciousness here explains the failure of Jonah's prediction.”

Bickerman, Elias (1985). [*Four Strange Books of the Bible: Jonah, Daniel, Koheleth, Esther*](#). Schocken. 32.

“This is the mysterious paradox of Hebrew faith: The All-wise and Almighty may change a word that He proclaims.”

Heschel, Abraham J. (2001). [*The Prophets*](#). Harper Perennial Modern Classics. 28.

Problem

This interpretation technically makes Jonah a false prophet (a big deal in [Deuteronomy 18](#)), intentionally proclaiming a word he knows is not true. It also portrays God as bearing false witness.

An Abbreviated Sermon

Jonah did not utter the message Yahweh gave him but altered or abbreviated it to suit his own purposes. Instead of delivering an original, conditional message of judgment and repentance, Jonah stated the oracle so

that the Ninevites would understand it as a pronouncement of irrevocable judgment.

Problems

- This portrays Jonah as being in a state of continued rebellion and disobedience to God, which is entirely possible.
- “This portrays Jonah as distorting God’s word.” Exactly! Jonah is consistently portrayed as an unreliable character whose words evade every person who speaks with him (the sailors in [1:8-9](#) and God in [4:3-4](#) and [4:8-9](#)).

God Teaching Jonah

Jonah faithfully uttered the message, but God is continuing to “teach a lesson” to Jonah. The message is worded ambiguously so that Jonah will think “overturned” means “destroyed,” whereas God knows that it means “changed,” anticipating Nineveh’s response.

Problems (and Solutions)

- This view depicts God as a trickster who knows Jonah will be motivated by a message of destruction. But by capitalizing on the potential double meaning, God can be faithful to the word of the prophet while also overcoming Jonah’s hatred.
- This “divine trick” prepares us for the next lesson for Jonah in chapter 4: the vine, the worm, and the wind.

“The ambiguity of ‘overturned’ amounts to a kind of pun. The word can mean to overthrow and destroy, but also to turn over, around, so that one thing becomes another ... Some such transformation or conversion ... seems to be what the Lord had in mind, if indeed these are the exact words given to Jonah to speak. So it may be that the Lord has fooled Jonah, giving him a message containing more good news than Jonah realizes. We need not suppose that the God of the Bible is above such fooling. Think of how he plays Pharaoh in the story of the Exodus, by at first proposing just a brief trip of three days for the Israelites (like Jonah’s time in the fish!) to worship their God ... God outwits and out maneuvers him, luring him into a trap to overcome his evil ... So too with Jonah, and we can imagine ancient Israelites telling this story aloud and chuckling. It’s not as if Pharaoh, or Jonah, didn’t deserve it.”

Cary, Phillip (2008), [Jonah](#). Brazos Press. 109.

“By the end of the third chapter (in fact, as soon as v 5 tells us that the Ninevites ‘believed in God’), God becomes more playful with Jonah, more tolerant of his caustic responses, more willing to indulge his stubbornness. As we shall also see, the narrative itself becomes more whimsical; more indulgent, I may say, in that it veers from attacking issues frontally. As we observe this shift in character, mood, and temper, we begin to wonder whether God’s great deeds at sea, below waters, and within Nineveh are but mere exhibits for a prophet’s education. All these modifications will be necessary because, to the last, the narrator needs to keep Jonah oblivious of the little games that Hebrew words can play.”

Sasson, Jack M. (1995). [Jonah](#). Yale University Press. 268.

Reflection Question

What do you make of Jonah's short sermon to the Ninevites? What does Jonah not say to the Ninevites that we might expect him to say?

Session 38: Does God Change His Mind?

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew word *nikham* invites us into the deep mystery of God's purpose to partner with humans in the course of history.
- No matter what the people do, God never goes back on his covenant purpose to use this family to bless the nations.

The Repentance of Nineveh: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 3:5-10

The Ninevites Respond

A 5 And the men of Nineveh believed in God,
and **they called a fast** ,
and they were **clothed with sackcloth** ,
from the **great** of them and to the small of them.

The King Responds

B a 6 And the word reached to the king of Nineveh
b **and he arose from his throne**
c and he removed his robe from upon him
c' and he **covered with sackcloth**
b' **and he sat in the dust** .
a' 7 And he cried out, and he said:

The King's Edict

"In Nineveh, from order of the king and his great ones, saying:

a **The human and the beast** ,
the cattle and the flock,
don't let them **taste anything** ;

don't let them graze;

A' ^b and **don't let them** **drink** water,
⁸ and **let them** **cover themselves with sackcloth**,

^{a'} **the human and the beast**,
 and **let them** call to god with force,

^{b'} and **let each** **man** **turn** **from his** **evil** **way**
 and from the violence that is in his hands.

⁹ Who knows?
 The god **may** turn **and** **repent**
and **turn** **from the** **heat of his anger**,
 so that we will not perish.

God's Response to the Ninevites' Repentance

C ¹⁰ And God saw their doings,
 that **they** **turned** **from their** **evil** **way**,
 and **God** **repented** **concerning the** **evil**
 which he spoke to do to them,
 and he did not do it.

Jonah 3:5-10. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

The Symmetry of the Ninevite Response

The actions of the Ninevites (A) anticipate the edict of the king (A'). They fast before they're told to, and their belief is a forward fulfillment of the king's call to "turn and repent." This characterizes the people as so eager to repent that the king's edict only states explicitly what they are already inclined to do without being commanded.

In B, notice how the king's actions are a symmetrical mirror. A word comes to the king (a) and then goes out from him (a'). He rises from his throne (b) and then sits down in ashes (b'). And at the center, he takes off his royal robe (c) only to put on sackcloth (c'). It's a complete reversal of his words, his role in society, and his symbols of high status.

In A', there is a forward symmetry so that in a and a', the king's edict addresses human and beast, while in b and b', we have an increasing series of deprivations ("don't let them ..."), leading up to the ultimate prohibition: "let each turn from his evil way ..."

In C, there is a climactic ending as God responds to the Ninevites' response. His actions match the actions of the Ninevites. They repent, so he relents.

Faithful Ninevites

The depiction of the Ninevites' faith in God activates an analogy with the Israelites immediately after their rescue from the sea. Recall that the first half of this analogy was applied to the sailors in Jonah 1:16, and now the second half is applied to the Ninevites in Jonah 3:5.

Israelites at the Sea

Exodus 14:31 NIV*

And the Israelites saw the great hand which Yahweh acted against Egypt **and the people feared Yahweh** (ויראו את יהוה) and **they believed in Yahweh** (ב ויאמינו) and in Moses his servant.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Sailors and the Ninevites

Jonah 1:16 Instructor's Translation

And the sailors **feared Yahweh** (ויראו יהוה את) a great fear ...

Jonah 3:5 ESV*

And the men of Nineveh **believed in God** (ויאמינו באלהים).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This analogy creates an ironic contrast, as Jonah is the one being rescued from the sea. But unlike the Exodus story, it is the pagan sailors and Ninevites who fear and believe in God.

Repenting Ninevites and a Relenting God

The king's edict to the Ninevites activates analogies with both Moses and Jeremiah.

Moses

Exodus 32:12, 14 Instructor's Translation

¹² [Moses to Yahweh] Turn from the heat of your anger (שוב מחרון אפך) and relent concerning the evil toward your people (הנחם ... על הרעה). ... ¹⁴ And Yahweh relented concerning the evil which he spoke to his people. (לעשות לעמו יהוה על הרעה אשר דבר וינחם).

The Ninevites

Jonah 3:8-10 NASB*

⁸ Let each man turn from his evil way (הרעה וישבו איש מדרכו) ... ⁹ Who knows, God may relent and turn from the heat of his anger (פיושב ונחם ... מחרון) and we will not perish! ¹⁰ And God saw ... that they turned from their evil way (מדרכם הרעהשבו), and God relented concerning the evil which he spoke to do to them (דבר לעשות להם הרעה אשר וינחם האלהים על).

Jeremiah

Jeremiah 18:7-8 Instructor's Translation

⁷ I may speak concerning a nation ... to destroy it, ⁸ but if that nation turns from its evil (מרע תושב), then I will relent concerning the evil I planned to do to it (חשבתי לעשות לוונחמתי על הרעה אשר).

Jeremiah 26:3 NASB*

Perhaps they will listen and each will turn from his evil way (וישב איש מדרכו הרעה), and I will relent concerning the evil which I am planning to do to them (חשב לעשות להם אל הרעה אשר אנכי נחמתי).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In both the stories of Moses and Jeremiah, the prophet plays the role of mediator. Moses appeals to God to “turn” from his just anger and not do “evil” to the people. Jeremiah appeals to the people to “turn” from their “evil” so God will relent from the “evil” he plans to do.

The irony is that Jonah, unlike Moses and Jeremiah, has abdicated his role as prophetic mediator, yet unlike the Jerusalemites, the Ninevites do repent!

God's Repentance

In Jonah 3:10, God sees the repentance of the Ninevites, so he relents of the disaster he had spoken to do to them. This vocabulary of human and divine repentance permeates the Hebrew Scriptures and gives us important insight into the purposes and ways of God in his dealings with humans.

The Vocabulary

When humans repent from evil, they *shuv* (pronounced "shooove"). It literally means to “turn around.”

When God repents from bringing evil on evil people, he can *shuv*, but there is an additional word used, *nikham*, which means “to relent, be satisfied.”

The root *nikham* is capable of different nuances based on context. In the active/causative form (*piel*), it can mean to comfort or change someone's emotional or mental state.

Genesis 24:67 NIV

And [Isaac] married Rebekah ... and [he] was **comforted** after his mother's death.

Genesis 37:35 NIV

[Jacob's] sons and daughters came **to comfort him**, but he refused to be **comforted**.

In the reflexive form (*niphal*), it can mean to regret a past action or to change one's mind about a future action.

Genesis 6:6 NIV*

And Yahweh **regretted** that he had made humanity on the land, and his heart was deeply pained.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Samuel 24:16 NIV*

And the angel stretched out his hand to destroy Jerusalem, and Yahweh **relented** concerning the evil and said ... “Stop your hand.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In each example of Yahweh’s relenting, the focus is on his purpose to bring judgment or blessing on violent people.

Jeremiah 18:7-10 NASB*

⁷ At one moment I might speak concerning a nation or concerning a kingdom to uproot, to pull down, or to destroy it; ⁸ if that nation against which I have spoken turns from its evil, **I will relent** concerning the evil I planned to bring on it. ⁹ Or at another moment I might speak concerning a nation or concerning a kingdom to build up or to plant it; ¹⁰ if it does evil in my sight by not obeying my voice, then **I will relent** concerning the good with which I had promised to bless it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The God of the Bible has partnered with humans ([Gen. 1:26-28](#)), and he experiences emotional pain over their evil (Gen. 6:6). God is portrayed as carrying out his ultimate purposes for history and all creation regardless of what humans do. This is the core idea in stories that portray God as not changing his mind even while clearly responding to human decisions.

1 Samuel 15:10-11 NASB*

¹⁰ Then the word of the LORD came to Samuel: ¹¹ “I **nikham** that I have made Saul king, because he has turned away from following me and has not carried out my commands.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Samuel 15:28-29 NIV*

²⁸ Samuel said to him, “The LORD has torn the kingdom of Israel from you today and has given it to one of your neighbors—to one better than you. ²⁹ He who is the Glory of Israel does not lie or **nikham**; for he is not a human being, that he should **nikham**.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The statement in 15:29 is matched by [Numbers 23:19](#).

1 Samuel 15:35 NIV*

Until the day Samuel died, he did not go to see Saul again, though Samuel mourned for him. And the LORD **nikham** that he had made Saul king over Israel.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The relenting of God due to the Ninevites' repentance is a hyperlinked inversion of the golden calf story in Exodus 32. There, Moses stepped into his role as mediator (unlike Jonah), and his intercession is what compels God to relent.

Exodus 32:9-11 NASB*

⁹ Then Yahweh said to Moses ... ¹⁰ "Now then let me alone (הניחה lit. "give me rest"), that my anger may burn against them and that I may destroy them; and I will make of you a great nation." ¹¹ But Moses entreated the LORD his God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"This story explores the mystery about prayer in general and intercession in particular, and raises questions: Was God really serious in this declared threat? If Moses had not interceded, would God have carried out the destruction of Israel? If God was not really planning to destroy the people, did God only 'pretend' to listen to Moses' prayer? Did Moses actually change God's mind?

It seems important first of all to say that there is not much point in wrestling with these alternative hypothetical scenarios posed by such questions. Both God and Moses appear to be behaving straightforwardly. There is nothing in the text to suggest that God's anger was overdone for mere effect. The threat of destruction was real, and Moses recognized that this was a sincere threat that could be countered only with appeal to prior words and actions of the same God.

The real paradox is that in appealing to God to change, Moses was actually appealing to God to be consistent, which may be a significant clue to the dynamic of all genuine intercessory prayer. Yet perhaps there is a hint of the divine intention in God's fascinating words, 'Leave me alone ...' The discussion of this line in Jewish scholarship has sensed deep meaning here. After all, God need not have spoken such words, or indeed any words at all, to Moses. In wrath God could have acted 'immediately' without informing or consulting Moses in any way. God pauses and makes the divine will 'vulnerable' to human challenge.

The fact is that, far from human intercession being an irritating but occasionally successful intrusion upon divinely prefabricated blueprints for history, Moses' prayer becomes an integral part of the way God's sovereignty in history is exercised. That does not totally solve the mystery, but it puts it in its proper biblical perspective. God not only allows human intercession, God invites it and builds it into the decision-making processes of the heavenly council in ways we can never fathom. Intercessory prayer, then, flows primarily not from human anxiety about God but from God's commitment to covenant relationship with human beings. Moses was not so much arguing against God, as participating in an argument within God. Such prayer, therefore, not only participates in the pain of God in history, but is actually invited to do so for God's sake as well as ours. This is a measure of the infinite value to God of commitment to persons in covenant relationship."

Adapted from Wright, Christopher (1994). [*Deuteronomy*](#). Baker Books. 78-79.

Reflection Question

How do you understand the idea of God changing his mind or relenting (Hebrew: *nikham*)? How does this understanding affect how you and others in your context view God and interact with him?

Session 39: Reflecting on God's Response to the Ninevites

Key Takeaways

- God *nikham's* (repents or relents) about evil that he threatens based on human response. He never *nikham's* about the ultimate good that he intends for his creation.



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

Is there any contradiction between the message God told Jonah to preach against Nineveh and the fact that God relented from Nineveh's destruction?



Module 8: Exploring Jonah

Chapter 4

SESSIONS 40-45

You made it to the final module! Examine the last chapter of Jonah, which includes Jonah's response to God's mercy and the book's powerful ending.

Session 40: Jonah as Similar to the Disbelieving Israelites

Key Takeaways

- Jonah is angry because God is merciful to the sinful people of Nineveh. The irony is that Israel exists because God was merciful to sinful people.
- Jonah's hot anger is hyperlinked to Cain's hot anger in [Genesis 4](#).

Jonah Criticizes God's Mercy: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 4:1-11

Speech of Jonah: 39 Words in Hebrew

A

¹ And it was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and there was heat-anger to him. ² And he prayed to Yahweh and he said, "Please, Yahweh! Was not this my word while I was upon my land? Therefore I acted beforehand to flee to Tarshish, because **I knew that you are a God, gracious and compassionate, long of anger**, and great of covenant love, and **who repents concerning evil**."

Jonah and God Dialogue

B

- a ³ And now, Yahweh, please **take my life from** me,
b for **good is my dying more than my living**.
c ⁴ **And Yahweh said, "Is it good that there is heat-anger to you?"**

Jonah's Shelter From the Sun

C

⁵ And Jonah went out from the city, and he sat from the east of the city, and he made for himself there a tent, and he dwelt under it in the shade, until he might see what would happen to the city.

God Provides Shelter

⁶ **And Yahweh Elohim appointed a qiqayon**

D

and it arose from over Jonah,
to be a shade upon his head,
to deliver him from his evil,
and Jonah rejoiced over the qiqayon, a great rejoicing.

God Ruins Shelter

D'

7 **And God appointed a worm**
at the rising of the dawn on the next day,
and it struck the **qiqayon**
and it withered.

No Shelter From the Sun

C'

8 And it came about as the sun shone
and **God appointed an east wind**, a hot one,
and the sun struck the upon the head of Jonah.

Jonah and God Dialogue

B'

- a And he fainted, and he **requested his life**, to **die** ,
b and he said, "**Good is my dying more than my living** ."
c 9 And God said to Jonah, "Is it good that there is heat-anger to you over this qiqayon?"
b' And he said, "**It is good that there is heat-anger to me , unto death !**"

Speech of God: 39 Words in Hebrew

A'

10 And Yahweh said,
"**You had pity** over this **qiqayon** , which you did not labor for it, nor did you make it great, which a
son of the night it was, and a son of the night it perished. 11 And I, **should I not have pity** over
Nineveh, the great city, which there is in it more than twelve ten-thousand humans, who don't know
between their right and their left, and many animals?"

Jonah 4:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Jonah's Anger at His Success: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 4:1-4

Genesis 4 Hyperlinks

A

1 And it was evil to Jonah, a great **evil** , and **there was heat-anger to him** .

Exodus 14 Hyperlinks

B ² And he prayed to Yahweh and he said, “ **Please, Yahweh (יהוה אנה)** , was not this my word while I was upon my land?

Exodus 34:6 Hyperlink

C Therefore I acted beforehand to flee to Tarshish, because I knew that you are a God, gracious and compassionate, long of anger, and great of covenant love, and who repents concerning evil.

Exodus 14 Hyperlinks

B' ³ **And now, Yahweh (יהוה ועתה)** take please my life from me, for good is my dying more than my living.

Genesis 4 Hyperlinks

A' ⁴ And Yahweh said, “Is it **good** that **there is heat-anger to you** ?”

Jonah 4:1-4. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

This section begins and ends with Jonah’s hot-anger, which was caused by God showing mercy to the Ninevites (A and A’). The shift from narrative statement (A) to God’s question (A’) generates a new plot conflict now that Jonah’s mission to Nineveh has been fulfilled. Jonah’s own stubbornness must be dealt with.

The center sections contain Jonah’s three-part response to Yahweh. It includes an appeal (B), the basis of the appeal (C), and a request (B’).

Hyperlinked Portraits of the Angry Jonah

Jonah and Cain in Genesis 4

Jonah 4:1 Instructor’s Translation

And [God’s showing mercy to Nineveh] was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and there was heat-anger to him (ויחר לו).

Genesis 4:4b-5 NASB*

⁴ And Yahweh regarded Abel and his offering, ⁵ but Cain and his offering he did not regard, and there was heat-anger to Cain (ויחר לו).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 4:4 Instructor’s Translation

And Yahweh said, “Is it doing good that there is heat-anger to you (ההיטב לך חרה)?”

Genesis 4:6-7 Instructor's Translation

⁶ "Why is there heat-anger to you (לך חרה)? ⁷ Isn't it the case that if you do good (תיטיב), there is exaltation?"

Jonah and the Exodus Generation

From Joseph Ryan Kelly's article, "Jonah, Joel, and the Yhwh Creed" (*Journal of Biblical Literature*, 2013)

Exodus 14:12-13	Jonah 4:2-3, 5
Is this not the word which we spoke to you in Egypt , saying, " Leave us alone, and let us serve the Egyptians!"	And Jonah prayed to Yahweh and said: "Please, Yahweh. Was this not my word while I was still on my own land? "
For it is good (טוב) for us to serve Egypt rather than we die (מותנו מן) in the wilderness .	Therefore I initially fled to Tarshish , for I knew that you are a God, gracious and compassionate, long of anger, and abundant in covenant love, and relenting concerning evil.
And Moses said to the people: "Do not fear, stand by and see the salvation of Yahweh which he will accomplish for you today, for Egypt which you see today, you will not see again, ever. "	And now, Yahweh, please take my life from me, for good (טוב) is my death more than (מן מותי) my life .
And Moses said to the people: "Do not fear, stand by and see the salvation of Yahweh which he will accomplish for you today, for Egypt which you see today, you will not see again, ever. "	And Jonah went outside of the city, and he sat east of the city, and made himself a shelter and sat under its shade, until he could see what might happen in the city .
Comparing Jonah and the Exodus Generation. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

In Exodus 14:11-13, the people have escaped into the wilderness and see Pharaoh's army drawing near. They accuse Moses of leading them out to the desert to die ("What is this thing you've done to us?"). And absurdly, they wish for their death in the wilderness. Moses assures them that despite their complaining, Yahweh will save them and overcome their enemies as they go through the waters of the sea.

In Jonah 4:2-5, Jonah, who was saved through the waters of the sea, has just left the city of Nineveh, and he also absurdly wishes for death. In contrast to Exodus 14, Yahweh is changing and saving his enemies instead of destroying them.

Jonah and Yahweh in Exodus 34:6

Exodus 34:6 NASB*

Then Yahweh passed by in front of him and proclaimed, "Yahweh, Yahweh, compassionate and gracious, long of anger, and great of covenant love and faithfulness ..."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This verse is connected to [Exodus 32:14](#) where God relented of the evil he intended to do to the Israelites.

Jonah 4:2 NASB*

Therefore I acted beforehand to flee to Tarshish because I knew that you are a God gracious and compassionate, long of anger, and great of covenant love, and who relents concerning evil.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joel 2:12-14 NASB*

¹² “Yet even now,” declares Yahweh,
“Return to me with all your heart,
and with fasting, weeping and mourning;
¹³ and rend your heart and not your garments.”
Now return to Yahweh your God,
for he is gracious and compassionate,
long of anger, abounding in covenant love
and relents concerning evil.
¹⁴ Who knows if he might turn and relent
and leave a blessing behind him.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In [Exodus 32-34](#), Israel was spared from divine judgment because of Moses’ intercession. God’s forgiveness of Israel and his renewal of the covenant is summarized in this dense list of God’s attributes. These are precisely the character traits of God displayed in the story of the golden calf, and they set a pattern of behavior that we will see from God throughout Israel’s history. Notice how both Jonah and Joel have merged the list from Exodus 34:6 with the narrative statement about Yahweh “relenting concerning evil.” God’s relenting is precisely due to Moses’ intercession.

In Jonah 4, the prophet ironically criticizes God for the very attributes that have sustained his existence in the family of Israel. He is angered that God would show the same mercy to his enemies. What’s also ironic is that the Ninevites repented as Israel did in the golden calf story but without any intercessor because Jonah is an anti-Moses!

Reflection Question

What clues does the text give us about Jonah’s anger? How might we be guilty of similar attitudes in our modern-day context?

Session 41: Reflecting on Jonah's Anger

Key Takeaways

- The author challenges us to think about whether there are people who have done such evil that we want God to destroy them rather than heal them and show them compassion.

"We must be clear where Jonah gets it wrong. It's not as if we should never desire justice ... It is good news when an oppressor is toppled, the terrorist caught, and the torturer brought to justice. The Lord does indeed 'take vengeance on his enemies' (as Nahum says of Nineveh in [Nah 1:2](#)), for he is the enemy of all who destroy his world. But the great danger is that instead of simply rejoicing at the vindication of the oppressed, we self-righteously identify ourselves as the oppressed, taking pity on ourselves and not on others. In our imaginations, the Lord becomes a weapon in our campaign to destroy our enemies, an instrument of our own revenge rather than the righteous judge of all the earth ... But the biblical theme of God's 'repentance concerning evil' means that the God of Israel is more inclined to save his enemies than destroy them ... This has particular consequences for God's covenant people ... It creates a two-sidedness to their calling ... to be the vehicle of God's blessing to all the nations ([Genesis 12:1-3](#)) ... so that their enemies are not necessarily God's enemies ... The repentance of God is not about God changing his mind, but is the fulfillment of his intention to save the wicked, which brings about a new and surprising relation between him and his enemies—surprising to us, but not to him."

Cary, Phillip (2008), [Jonah](#). Brazos Press. 160-161.



This session has no other notes

Reflection Question

God asks Jonah, "Is it right for you to be angry?" What does the text tell us about the reason for Jonah's anger?

Session 42: A Tale of Two Shelters

Key Takeaways

- During the feast of Sukkot, the Israelites built tents called *sukkahs*, Eden shelters made out of fruit branches. They didn't build them to provide their own Eden but to remind themselves of God's provision of Eden blessings.
- Jonah builds his own *sukkah*, a miniature city of protection, and refuses God's invitation to join Eden. God responds by sending a plant to shelter him.
- Jonah's actions are hyperlinked to Cain's building of the first city of protection because he didn't accept God's protection. When humans don't trust God's protection, they become violent and elevate their own protection at the expense of others, creating cities of blood.

Jonah's Shelter and God's Worm: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 4:5-8

Jonah's Shelter From the Sun

- A
- a 5 And Jonah went out from **the city** ,
a' and he sat from the east of **the city** ,
b and he made for himself there **a tent** ,
b'' and he sat under it in **the shade** ,
a'' until he might see what would happen to **the city** .

God Provides Plant Shelter

- B
- a 6 **And Yahweh Elohim appointed a** **qiqayon** and it arose from over Jonah,
b to be a **shade** upon his head,
b' to deliver him from his evil,
a' and Jonah rejoiced over the **qiqayon** , a great rejoicing.

God Ruins Plant Shelter

- B'
- 7 **And God appointed a worm**
at the rising of the dawn on the next day,
and it **struck** the **qiqayon**
and it withered.

No Shelter From the Sun

A'⁸ And it came about as the sun shone
and **God appointed an east wind**, a hot one,
and the sun **struck** the upon the head of Jonah.

Jonah 4:5-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

A and A' provide the outer frame that contrasts Jonah's provision of his own shelter with his lack of shelter that exposes him to the burning sun.

B and B' provide a two-step sequence for the provision of a divine shelter and God's destruction of that shelter. Jonah's experience of building and losing his shelter frames the inner scenes where God provides and then ruins the plant.

Jonah's Journey East and His Self-Made Shelter

The opening line in 4:5 recalls the analogies with Cain in Genesis 4:1 and 4:4 and develops them further. Jonah's departure from Nineveh is depicted as a self-inflicted exile like Cain's.

Jonah in Jonah 4

Jonah 4:1 Instructor's Translation

And [God's showing mercy to Nineveh] was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and there was heat-anger to him (ל ויחר-).

Jonah 4:4 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh said, "Is it doing good that there is heat-anger to you (לך חרה ההיטב לך)?"

Jonah 4:5 Instructor's Translation

And Jonah went out (ויצא) from the city, and he sat from the east of the city (מקדם וישב) and made for himself a sukkah, and he sat (וישב) under it.

Cain in Genesis 4

Genesis 4:4b-5 NASB*

⁴ And Yahweh regarded Abel and his offering, ⁵ but Cain and his offering he did not regard, and there was heat-anger to Cain (ל ויחר).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 4:6-7 Instructor's Translation

⁶ "Why is there heat-anger to you (לך חרה)? ⁷ Isn't it the case that if you do good (תיטיב), there is exaltation?"

Genesis 4:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ And Cain went out (וַיֵּצֵא) from before the face of Yahweh, and he sat (וַיֵּשֶׁב) in the land of Nod, to the east of Eden (עֵדֶן קְדֵמַת) ... ¹⁷ And he built a city, and called the name of the city according to the name of his son "Enoch."

Jonah is being likened to Cain, who rejected Yahweh's offer of forgiveness and protection and journeyed east of Eden to build his own protection in the form of a city (this is itself a wordplay hyperlink contrast to God "building help" for the man in Gen. 2:18: "city" עִיר / "help" עֵזֶר).

Jonah's *sukkah* (סֻכָּה) activates a whole network of associations with God's provision of Eden protection for his people in the wilderness.

The Feast of Sukkot

From the 15th to the 21st of the seventh month, the Israelites were to celebrate an extended seven-day Sabbath. The ritual practice is about a self-imposed, symbolic "exile" from their homes to dwell in a *sukkah*. The description is packed with Eden imagery and symbolizes how God provided Israel with glimpses of Eden during their sojourn in the desert.

Leviticus 23:40, 42 Instructor's Translation

⁴⁰ And you will take for yourself ... from the fruit of the tree (פְּרִי עֵץ), a majestic one, branches of palm leaves, and a bough of a tree of leaf and poplars by a river, and you will rejoice before Yahweh your God for seven days. ... ⁴² In Sukkot you will sit (יֵשֵׁב) for seven days.

Eden imagery

- Genesis 3:6: Taking from the fruit of the tree
- Genesis 1:11/2:9: Fruit trees
- Genesis 2:9-10: The tree of life is next to the river of life
- Genesis 2:1-3: Creation is completed within seven days
- Genesis 2:15: God placed humanity in the garden

In Deuteronomy 16, the feast of Sukkot was a time for extreme hospitality for outsiders to Israel. This explains why in Zechariah 14, the in-gathering of the nations to worship Yahweh in the new Jerusalem takes place during the feast of Sukkot.

Deuteronomy 16:13-15 NASB*

¹³ You shall celebrate the feast of Sukkot seven days after you have gathered in from your threshing floor and your wine vat; ¹⁴ and you shall have joy (שִׂמְחָה) in your feast, you and your son and your daughter and your male and female servants and the Levite and **the immigrant and the orphan and the widow** who are in your towns. ¹⁵ Seven days you shall celebrate a feast to the LORD your God in the place which the LORD chooses, because the LORD your God will bless you in all your produce and in all the work of your hands, so that **you will be altogether joyful** (שִׂמְחָה).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Zechariah 14:16 NASB

Then it will come about that any who are left of all the nations that went against Jerusalem will go up from year to year to worship the King, the LORD of hosts, and to celebrate the feast of Sukkot.

Moses directed Israel to gather during every seventh feast of Sukkot and read aloud from the Torah. This practice was carried out by those returning from exile in Babylon in the time of Ezra and Nehemiah.

Nehemiah 8:14-18 NASB*

¹⁴ They found written in the law how the LORD had commanded through Moses that the sons of Israel should live in booths during the feast of the seventh month. ¹⁵ So they proclaimed and circulated a proclamation in all their cities and in Jerusalem, saying, "Go out to the hills, and bring olive branches and wild olive branches, myrtle branches, palm branches and branches of other leafy trees, to make sukkot, as it is written." ¹⁶ So the people went out and brought them and made sukkot for themselves, each on his roof, and in their courts and in the courts of the house of God, and in the square at the Water Gate and in the square at the Gate of Ephraim. ¹⁷ The entire assembly of those who had returned from the captivity made sukkot and lived in them. The sons of Israel had indeed not done so from the days of Joshua the son of Nun to that day. And there was great rejoicing (מאד גדולה שמחה). ¹⁸ He read from the book of the law of God daily, from the first day to the last day.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Recall Jonah's "great rejoicing" (גדולה שמחה) over the plant that God provides in [Jonah 4:6](#).

Deuteronomy 31:10-11 NASB*

¹⁰ Then Moses commanded them, saying, "At the end of seven years, at the time of the year of remission of debts, at the feast of Sukkot, ¹¹ when all Israel comes to appear before the LORD your God at the place which he will choose, you shall read this law in front of all Israel in their hearing."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Sukkot, the Temple, and God's Presence

The ark of the covenant dwelt in a "tent" (אהל), also called a "shelter" (*sukkah* סכה).

2 Samuel 7:2 NIV*

"Here I am, living in a house of cedar, while the ark of God sits (ישב) in the midst of a (אהל) **tent**."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Samuel 11:11 NIV*

Uriah said to David, "The ark and Israel and Judah are sitting (ישב) in **shelters** (*sukkot* סככות), and my lord Joab and the servants of my lord are camping in the open field."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In the Psalms, God's provision of protection is called a shelter.

Psalm 31:19-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁹ How great is your goodness ...
for those who take refuge in you.

²⁰ You conceal them in the secret place of your face-presence ...
you hide them in a **shelter** (סכה).

Sukkot as Jerusalem and the Messianic Jerusalem

Jerusalem as the seat of David's kingdom is likened to a shelter in the Prophets. Thus, the new Jerusalem of the messianic age is called a shelter, which God will build after the full restoration from exile.

Isaiah 1:8 NASB*

The daughter of Zion is left like a **shelter** (*sukkah* סכה) in a vineyard.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Amos 9:11-12 NASB*

¹¹ "In that day I will raise up the fallen **shelter** (סכה) of David,
and wall up its breaches;

I will also raise up its ruins
and rebuild it as in the days of old;

¹² that they may possess the remnant of Edom
and all the nations who are called by my name,"
declares the LORD who does this.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 4:2-6 NASB*

² In that day, the branch of the LORD will be beautiful and glorious, and the fruit of the earth will be the pride and the adornment of the survivors of Israel. ³ It will come about that he who is left in Zion and remains in Jerusalem will be called holy—everyone who is recorded for life in Jerusalem. ⁴ When the Lord has washed away the filth of the daughters of Zion and purged the bloodshed of Jerusalem from her midst, **by a wind of judgment and a wind of burning,** ⁵ **then the LORD will create** over the whole area of Mount Zion and over her assemblies a cloud by day, even smoke, and the brightness of a flaming fire by night; for over all the glory will be a canopy (חפה). ⁶ **There will be a shelter** (סכה) for **shade** (לצל) **from the heat by day**, and refuge and protection from the storm and the rain.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These texts make clear that the renewal of Jerusalem in the messianic age will be an act of God. He will create the ultimate *sukkah* for his people to protect them from the heat of the sun, which is likened to threats from Israel's enemies (see [Isa. 25:4-5](#) for a development of the metaphor of "enemies as heat from the sun").

Conclusions on the Sukkot Theme

These key themes surrounding Sukkot (celebrating a new Eden, in-gathering of the nations, restoration of God's presence in the temple, the renewal of the Davidic kingship) are all brought together in Jonah 4.

Consider Jonah's appearance in 2 Kings 14:25-26, where he prophesied the restoration of Israel's borders to their Eden-like proportions. Assyria was the nation that reduced those very boundaries (as Amos prophesied in Amos 6:14), so it makes perfect sense that Jonah would leave Nineveh to create a "pseudo-Eden" that rekindles the hopes for a new David and a new Jerusalem. But this messianic age is for himself only, a last resort to thwart or counter Yahweh's plans.

God Provides Jonah with a Plant

God Provides Plant Shelter

B

- a 6 And Yahweh Elohim appointed a **qiqayon** and it arose from over Jonah,
b to be a **shade** upon his head,
b' to deliver him from his evil,
a' and Jonah rejoiced over the **qiqayon**, a great rejoicing.

Jonah 4:5-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

4:6a

In all of ancient Hebrew, the *qiqayon* plant name appears only here (קִיקְיֹון). Certainty about the species of plant has eluded scholars for the entire history of interpretation, and one suspects that the real point of its mention is not to discover its botanical identity!

Attempts to Identify the Plant (see Robinson, "Jonah's Qiqayon Plant")

The oldest translations render the Hebrew term with "gourd."

- Old Greek: *κολόκυνθα*
- Old Latin: *cucurbita*
- Syriac Peshitta: *qar'a'*

This was adopted in older English translations (eventually KJV, RV). Some ancient translations rendered it as some kind of ivy.

- Symmachus: *κισσος* There is evidence that Jerome's Vulgate, *hedera*, refers to a castor oil plant. Tyndale, the first English translation, rendered the term "as it were a wild vine."
- Coverdale Bible: "wylde vyne."

The Akkadian term *kukkanitu* was used in Assyrian texts (Assyria!) to refer to plants in the royal garden. It is more than likely that Jonah's author chose a real botanical term, one that sounds like the language of the Assyrians. But there may be more to it.

The plant's name sounds exactly like words in two related texts from earlier in Jonah.

Jonah 1:14 NASB

[Sailors who throw Jonah into the sea] "Don't put innocent blood upon us."

Naqi' (נָקִיא): "we will vomit"

Jonah 1:17, 2:10 NASB

1:17 And Yahweh appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah ... 2:10 And Yahweh spoke to the fish and he vomited Jonah.

Yonah' + qa - יונה + קא

Jonah 4:6 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh Elohim appointed a **qiqayon**.

Qi-qa-yon = "vomiting, he vomited Jonah"

"*Qiqayon* may be a extremely rare word used here to give an exotic flavor to the story. In Jonah 2:11 the author had described how the great fish that God had deployed ... had spewed Jonah out (*qa'*). The plant in Jonah chapter 4 has a similar function to the fish, and this fact may have suggested to the author the rare plant name that is visually similar to the word 'spew.'"

Robinson, Bernard P. (1985). "Jonah's Qiqayon Plant." *Giessen*, vol. 97, 3. 402.

4:6b

"And it went up from over Jonah, to be shade over his head, and to deliver him from his evil."

What is Jonah's "evil?" This is most likely a reference back to Jonah 4:1: "And it [God's mercy toward the repentant Ninevites] was evil to Jonah, a great evil." This plant is God's strategy for relieving Jonah of God forgiving his enemies. But how exactly? We have to keep reading.

The two phrases, "to be shade over his head" and "to deliver him from evil," are two parallel lines in the central symmetry of the entire verse (A B B' A). This prompts the reader to ponder a conceptual analogy between shade and deliverance.

4:6c

"And Jonah rejoiced a great joy over the *qiqayon*."

This is the only time Jonah is happy in the entire story, and it concerns a plant that benefits only him as he sulks in his pitiful anger.

Jonah's "great joy" (גְּדוּלָה שִׂמְחָה) echoes a phrase commonly associated with the feast of Sukkot, which is to be accompanied by "great joy" (Ezra 8:17; also Deut. 16:15).

"Jonah ... crawl[s] under the *sukkâ* that he builds in order to benefit from its shade. Soon, however, God directs the *qîqâyôn* to shade him from above his head. The pun is directional, depending on a contrasting

location for this 'shade' (ṣēl), but it is also versatile: through this divine act meant 'to deliver him from his distress,' Jonah acquires a satisfying response to his complaint. This plant, marvelously rising above his head, is a sign of a new equilibrium between him and God, of a renewed understanding between the two ... From Jonah's perspective, the story can end now on this happy note: Nineveh and its fate are no longer central to Jonah; his difference with God is now resolved. From God's standpoint, however, there is still the matter of educating a prophet on divine mercy. Now that Jonah has turned the issue into a personal, if not physical, problem; now that he has come out from his deep funk, God will readily turn to pedagogic instruments that are too obvious to be misunderstood by Jonah, and by us as well."

Adapted from Sasson, Jack M. (1995). [Jonah](#). Yale University Press. 298.

Reflection Question

In [chapter 4](#), we are presented with an object lesson where Jonah builds a shelter, God provides shelter, Jonah's shelter is taken away, and then God removes his shelter. What is the point of this lesson? Why are these object lessons so helpful for teaching?

Session 43: The Meaning of Key Terms in Jonah

Key Takeaways

- God wants to deliver Jonah from his distorted mindset where his enemies finding mercy is evil to him.
- The imagery of Jonah with two shelters, one made by him and one provided by God, tells us he has a choice to make. Will Jonah stay in his own version of reality, or will he accept the version of reality that God wants to give him as a gift?



This session has no notes

Reflection Question

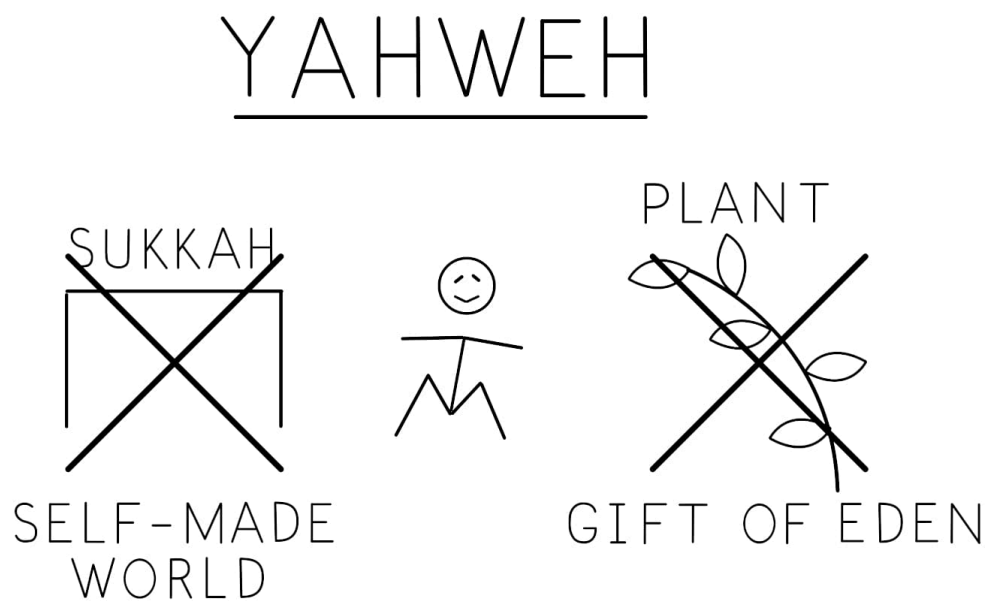
How do the biblical authors link Jonah's story to Cain's?

Session 44: God's Pity vs. Jonah's Pity

Key Takeaways

- Jonah is a symbolic image of Israel's story. God gives them the Eden gift (vines), but when the gift is no longer appreciated, God takes it away in the form of exile.
- God's question to Jonah at the end of the book confronts the reader as well. Will we allow God's merciful and just character to grow compassion in our own hearts?

Jonah's Provision vs. God's



Jonah's Versus God's Provision. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

God Appoints a Worm to Eat the Plant

7 **And God appointed a worm**

at the rising of the dawn on the next day,
and it **struck** the **qiqayon**
and it withered.

Jonah 4:5-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

4:7a: The “Worm” (תולעת)

There are only two other texts in the Hebrew Bible about worms eating and causing ruin, and both are relevant hyperlinks in Jonah 4.

This phrase appears in the manna story ([Exod. 16:20](#)), where the Israelites are instructed to not gather extra manna for the next day.

Exodus 16:17, 19-20 NASB*

¹⁷ The sons of Israel gathered, some very much, and some very little ... ¹⁹ And Moses said to them, "Let no one leave any of it unto morning." ²⁰ But they did not listen to Moses, and they left from it unto morning, and it was infested with worms (תולעה).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This phrase also appears in a section of “inverted-Eden” curses that will come upon the land because of Israel’s obedience ([Deut. 28:39](#)).

Deuteronomy 28:38-39 NASB*

³⁸ “You will bring much seed out to the field, but you will gather little, for the locust will eat it away. ³⁹ You will plant vineyards, and work them, but you will drink no wine and you will not gather, for the worm (תולעת) will eat it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In both of these texts, the worms are sent by God to reverse an Eden blessing. In [Exodus 16](#), the manna is called “the bread from the heavens” ([Exod. 16:4](#)), and in [Deuteronomy 28](#), the blessings are all Eden-like and abundant. And the worms are the result of being exiled out of Eden, where animals become hostile instead of peaceable with humans. Worms are also associated with death and decomposing corpses ([Isa. 14:11](#), [66:24](#)), so they are the ultimate icon of post-Eden mortality and loss. In this way, the worm is a much more clear instrument of divine judgment than the fish, which plays a more positive role both in [Genesis 1](#) (day 5 of creation) and here in this story.

The Withered Vine

The image of a healthy growing vine that quickly withers as a sign of God’s judgment is a common motif in the Prophets for rulers and their kingdoms that grow and quickly pass away.

Isaiah 40:6-7, 23-24 Instructor’s Translation

⁶ All flesh is grass, and all its covenant loyalty like a flower of the field.

⁷ The grass withers and the flower fades,
for the wind of Yahweh blows upon it ...

²³ He makes rulers into nothing,
and makes the judges of the land like nothingness.

²⁴ Scarcely are they planted,
scarcely do they take root, their stock in the ground,
and then he blows on them and they wither,
and a storm lifts them away like chaff.

Israel's monarchy is likened to a flourishing vine that is blown by the east wind so that it withers.

Ezekiel 17:2-10 NASB

² Son of man, propound a riddle and speak a parable to the house of Israel ... ⁵ [an eagle] took some of the seed of the land and planted it in fertile soil. He placed it beside abundant waters; he set it as a willow. ⁶ Then it sprouted and became a low, spreading vine with its branches turned toward him, but its roots remained under it. So it became a vine and yielded shoots and sent out branches. ... ¹⁰ Behold, though it is planted, will it thrive? Will it not completely wither as soon as the east wind reaches it—wither on the beds where it grew?

Ezekiel 19:10-12 NASB

¹⁰ Your mother was like a vine in your vineyard,
planted by the waters;
it was fruitful and full of branches
because of abundant waters.
¹¹ And it had strong branches fit for scepters of rulers,
and its height was raised above the clouds
so that it was seen in its height with the mass of its branches.
¹² But it was plucked up in fury;
it was cast down to the ground;
and the east wind dried up its fruit.
Its strong branch was torn off,
so that it withered

See also [Psalm 80](#); [Isaiah 5:1-7](#); [Hosea 10](#); [Joel 1:12-20](#)

If Jonah's joy over his vine and his subsequent loss of it is a parable to teach him about God's mercy, the royal associations with a ruined vine point toward Israel's history. Just as God provided the line of David for Israel (out of nowhere, like the vine), so too will he take it away (exile).

God Appoints the East Wind to Strike Jonah

No Shelter From the Sun

8 And it came about as the sun shone
and **God appointed an east wind**, a hot one,
and the sun **struck** the upon the head of Jonah.

Jonah 4:5-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

After Jonah made his own shelter “for shade,” God provided a superior shade, namely an Eden-like plant whose name recalls Jonah’s own rebellion and its consequences (“vomit”), which have continued to this moment. God continues to muster the forces of creation to bring Jonah to a similar posture of repentance as the king of Nineveh. So God takes the plant away so that Jonah is exposed to the hot wind and the heat of the sun.

Notice that the east wind and the sun are distinct elements in this scene, and while the function of the sun is clear (it strikes Jonah’s head), the purpose or result of the east wind is not mentioned.

Sasson (*Jonah*, 304) notes that the east wind does not kill the plant (the worm did that), nor is it associated with the heat (the sun is). Given all of the associations of the east wind with acts of divine judgment (see below), it makes most sense that the purpose of the east wind is to sweep away Jonah’s shelter, leaving him open to the bright heat of the sun in the following sentence.

The “east wind” has ominous associations of divine judgment that are drawn upon here.

- Famine is caused by the east wind (*Gen. 41:6*)
- The locusts are brought to Egypt by an east wind (*Exod. 10:13*)
- God sends an east wind to part the waters (salvation) and destroy the Egyptians (judgment) (*Exod. 14:21*)
- Israel’s scattering to Babylonian exile is metaphorically caused by the east wind (*Jer. 18:16*)
- The line of David is like a vine withered by the east wind and carried to Babylon (*Ezek. 17:10; 19:12*)
- The ships of Tarshish are broken by the east wind (*Ezek. 27:26; Psalm 48:7*)

“An East *Harishit* Wind”

The word חרישית occurs only here in ancient Hebrew. Its root ח.ר.ש could mean “silent” or “plow.” It is likely that the word was chosen on the basis of a network of wordplay with various intertexts.

- Elijah’s experience of God’s “silence” after the wind on Mount Sinai (*1 Kgs. 19:11-12*)
- God’s “wind” that appears “in the beginning” (בראשית // חרישית *Gen. 1:2*)
- The consonants ח/ר/ש are densely packed in *Jonah 4:6-8*

“The Sun Struck Jonah’s Head”

This phrase appears twice elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible, *Isaiah 49:10* and *Psalm 121:6*. Both are relevant to *Jonah 4*.

Psalm 121 is a poem where Yahweh’s role as deliverer is described with images rich with association with *Jonah*.

Psalm 121:5-7 NASB*

⁵ Yahweh is your keeper [unlike Cain!];

Yahweh is your shade on your right hand [contrast Jonah's self-made shade-shelter!].

⁶ The sun will not strike you by day [contrast Jonah's "beating" from the sun],
nor the moon by night.

⁷ Yahweh will keep you from all evil [unlike Jonah's "evil" that he can't escape!];
he will keep your soul.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 49:10, within the context of [Isaiah 49:8-13](#), details how the newly appointed servant will lead the exiles out of prison/darkness and into a restored Eden by way of the wilderness. On that journey, the sun will not strike them as God provides pools of water as they journey home.

Jonah's Second Death Wish and God's Second Question

This second dialogue has been designed on the model of the first dialogue in 4:3-4a, but this round intensifies the conflict between Jonah and God, especially after the loss of the shelter and the heat of the sun.

Round One: 4:3-4a

Jonah and God Dialogue

- B
- a ³ And now, Yahweh, please **take my life from** me,
 - b for **good is my** **dying** **more than my living** .
 - c ⁴ **And Yahweh said, "Is it good that there is heat-anger to you?"** "

Jonah 4:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Round Two: 4:8-9

Jonah and God Dialogue

- B'
- a And he fainted, and he **requested his life** , to **die** ,
 - b and he said, "**Good is my** **dying** **more than my living** ."
 - c ⁹ And God said to Jonah, "Is it good that there is heat-anger to you over this qiqayon?"
 - b' And he said, "**It is good** **that there is heat-anger to me** , **unto** **death** !"

Jonah 4:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Key Hyperlinks

Jonah's fate east of Nineveh is likened again to Israel in the wilderness.

Exodus 14:11-12 NASB

¹¹ Then they said to Moses, "Is it because there were no graves in Egypt that you have taken us away to die in the wilderness? Why have you dealt with us in this way, bringing us out of Egypt? ¹² Is this not the word that we spoke to you in Egypt, saying, 'Leave us alone that we may serve the Egyptians'? For it would have been better for us to serve the Egyptians than to die in the wilderness."

Exodus 16:3 NASB

The sons of Israel said to them, "If only we had died by the LORD's hand in the land of Egypt, when we sat by the pots of meat, when we ate bread to the full; for you have brought us out into this wilderness to kill this whole assembly with hunger."

Numbers 14:2-3 NASB*

² All the sons of Israel grumbled against Moses and Aaron; and the whole congregation said to them, "If only we had died in the land of Egypt! Or would that we had died in this wilderness! ³ Why is the LORD bringing us into this land, to fall by the sword? Our wives and our little ones will become plunder; would it not be better for us to return to Egypt?"

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In all of these narratives, the Israelites' desire for death appears irrational and the result of self-delusion. This response shows the ultimate lack of trust defiance of the creative power of Yahweh.

The second dialogue creates a more explicit analogy between Jonah and Elijah in [1 Kings 19](#), both of which activate hyperlinks to two stages of Moses' leadership of Israel.

Noble Moses on Mount Sinai

Exodus 32:30-32 NASB

³⁰ On the next day Moses said to the people, "You yourselves have committed a great sin; and now I am going up to the LORD, perhaps I can make atonement for your sin." ³¹ Then Moses returned to the LORD, and said, "Alas, this people has committed a great sin, and they have made a god of gold for themselves. ³² But now, if you will, forgive their sin— and if not, please blot me out from your book which you have written!"

Disillusioned Moses in the Wilderness

Numbers 11:11, 14-15 NASB

¹¹ So Moses said to the LORD, "Why have you done evil to your servant? And why have I not found favor in your sight, that you have laid the burden of all this people on me? ... ¹⁴ I alone am not able to carry all this people, because it is too burdensome for me. ¹⁵ So if you are going to deal thus with me, please kill me at once, if I have found favor in your sight, and do not let me see my wretchedness."

1 Kings 19: Elijah	Jonah 1-4
Elijah flees from Jezebel after defeating the prophets of Baal on Mt. Carmel	Jonah flees from God's call to go to Nineveh
Elijah walks one day into the wilderness (19:4a)	Jonah walks one day into Nineveh (3:4) Jonah goes east of Nineveh (4:5)
Elijah "asked for his life, to die (וישאל את־נפשו למות)" (19:4b)	"And now, Yahweh, please take my life (נפשי) from me, for good is my death more than my life" (4:3) "And he asked for his life, to die (וישאל את־נפשו למות)" (4:8)
"And he lay down and he slept (וישכב ויישן), and look, an angel touching him, and he said, 'Arise (קום), eat!'" (19:5)	"And [Jonah] lay down and he slept (וישכב וירדם) ... And the captain said ... 'Arise (קום) call on your God!'" (1:5-6)
Elijah journeys 40 days to Mt. Horeb (Mount Sinai) (19:8)	Jonah announces 40 days until Nineveh's destruction (3:4)
God asks Elijah two times why he has come to Mt. Horeb (19:9, 13)	God asks two times if it is good that Jonah is angry at his mercy (4:4, 9)
Elijah gives the same exaggerated, self-pitying answer two times (19:10, 14)	Jonah gives the same pathetic and selfish answer two times (4:2, 9)
God communicates with Elijah through symbolic natural phenomena (wind, earthquake, lightning) (19:11-12)	God communicates with Jonah through symbolic natural phenomena (plant, worm, wind) (4:6-8)
God counters Elijah's self-pity: You are not the only faithful Israelite, I have 7,000 others (19:18)	God counters Jonah's self-pity: You had pity on this plant, shouldn't I have pity on a great city? (4:10-11)
Narrative Analogy Between Elijah and Jonah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Reflections on the Jonah/Elijah Analogy

The large-scale comparison with Elijah is crucial to the portrayal of Jonah's character. Both prophets played their role in communicating the divine word. (Elijah did so willingly, Jonah not so willingly). However, both prophets fundamentally misunderstand the bigger picture of God's purpose, and they respond in a self-oriented way.

Neither prophet takes it upon themselves to intercede for Israel the way Abraham did for Sodom or as Moses did for Israel. Neither prophet can see beyond their own life circumstances, despite the fact that God patiently invites them into a conversation (two times!).

Both prophets invert the Moses model of the prophet who offers his own life in the place of God's enemies. They would rather die for their tiny narrative instead of giving their life for God's larger purposes in the world. Both prophets seek Eden-like shelters in order to evade their real responsibilities.

God's Final Question for Jonah: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 4:10-11

A	10 And Yahweh said, "You had pity
B	over this qiqayon ,
C	which you did not labor for it, nor did you make it great, which a son of the night it was, and a son of the night it perished.
A'	11 And shouldn't I have pity
B'	over Nineveh , the great city,
C'	which there is in it more than twelve ten-thousand humans, who don't know between their right and their left, and many animals?

Jonah 4:10-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

God's purpose in the vine is to create a parable-like experience for Jonah so that his pity for the plant is likened to God's pity on the nations, embodied in the iconic evil city of Nineveh.

- Jonah's pity = God's pity
- The plant = Nineveh the great city
- The plant's greatness = Nineveh's greatness

These comparisons between Nineveh and the plant provided by God are connected to a series of hyperlinked texts.

The Plant and the City

God's emphasis that Jonah did not labor (עמל) for the plant or make it great (גדול) recalls a key motif in the Torah and Prophets that the abundance of the promised land was not the result of Israel's power or labor.

Deuteronomy 6:10-11 NASB

¹⁰ "Then it shall come about when the LORD your God brings you into the land which he swore to your fathers, Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, to give you, great and good cities which you did not build, ¹¹ and houses full of all good things which you did not fill, and hewn cisterns which you did not dig, vineyards and olive trees which you did not plant, and you eat and are satisfied,

Joshua 24:13 NASB

I gave you a land on which you had not labored, and cities which you had not built, and you have lived in them; you are eating of vineyards and olive groves which you did not plant.

120,000 Humans

Verse 11 ("more than 120,000 humans") is worded in a strange way in Hebrew. The normal phrase would be "one hundred and twenty-thousand" (אלף ועשרים מאה) (see [Jdg. 8:10](#); [1 Kgs. 8:63](#)). But in Jonah 4:11, we find "twelve ten-thousands (רבו עשרה שטים). This is the only time 120,000 is phrased this way in the Hebrew Bible. This way of expressing the number highlights the number twelve.

In Genesis, when God chooses a certain lineage extending from Abraham (Isaac and then Jacob), God promises to also give his blessing to the non-chosen line of Ishmael.

Of Ishamel, God says "I will make him a great nation" ([Gen. 16:18](#)), "I will make him fruitful and multiply, and he will be the father of twelve rulers and a great nation." In Genesis 25:12-16, Ishmael's descendants have "twelve tribal rulers" ([Gen. 25:16](#)).

It's likely that in Jonah 4:11, the author is presenting Nineveh "the great city" as yet another divinely blessed nation consisting of "twelve ten-thousands" and therefore equally worthy of his attention and mercy.

Who Don't Know Right from Left

In Hebrew, the word "human" is singular (אדם *adam*), which evokes the *adam* / humanity figure from Genesis chapters 1-3. The depiction of *adam* not having access to true knowledge is a key motif in the role of the tree of knowing good and evil in [Genesis 2:9](#) and [Genesis 2:15-16](#).

To "go/turn right or left" is a turn of phrase in Hebrew that means to know the straight, or correct, way. It can be used literally as people go on a journey ([Gen. 24:49](#); [Num. 20:17](#)), or metaphorically where "right or left" is the opposite of the straight path that is morally good ([Deut. 5:32](#), [17:11](#)).

“To know between good and evil” is a key phrase used in divine wisdom texts built on the design pattern from Genesis 2-3. The phrase refers to moral discernment, the ability to discriminate between the morally good and beneficial and the morally bad and harmful. This is a trait connected with moral maturity.

Deuteronomy 1:39 NASB*

Your little ones ... and your sons, who today do not know good or evil, shall enter there, and I will give it to them and they shall possess it.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 7:15-16 NASB

¹⁵ [Immanuel] will eat curds and honey at the time he knows to refuse evil and choose good. ¹⁶ For before the boy will know to refuse evil and choose good, the land whose two kings you dread will be forsaken.

1 Kings 3:7, 9 NASB*

⁷ Now, O LORD my God, you have made your servant king in place of my father David, yet I am but a little child; I do not know how to go out or come in. ... ⁹ So give your servant a heart that listens, to judge your people, to discern between good and evil. For who is able to judge this great people of yours?

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This was the knowledge of good and evil that Adam and Eve took on their own terms instead of learning it from God (as Solomon did, see 1 Kgs. 3:9 above). This was the divine wisdom given to Israel in the Torah, which taught moral discernment about good and evil, which is also associated with the phrase “right and left.”

Torah Teaches “Right and Left”

Deuteronomy 5:32-33 NASB

³² So you shall observe to do just as the LORD your God has commanded you; you shall not turn aside to the right or to the left. ³³ You shall walk in all the way which the LORD your God has commanded you, that you may live and that it may be good with you, and that you may live long days in the land which you will possess.

Deuteronomy 17:11, 19-20 NASB*

¹¹ According to the terms of the Torah which [the priests] teach you, and according to the verdict which they tell you, you shall do; you shall not turn aside from the word which they declare to you, to the right or the left. ... ¹⁹ [the Torah] shall be with him and he shall read it all the days of his life, that he may learn to fear the LORD his God, by carefully observing all the words of this law and these statutes, ²⁰ that his heart may not be lifted up above his countrymen and that he may not turn aside from the commandment, to the right or the left, so that he and his sons may live long in his kingdom in the midst of Israel.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Deuteronomy 28:11-14 NASB*

¹¹ The LORD will make you abound in goodness ... in the land which the LORD swore to your fathers to give you. ¹² The LORD will open for you his storehouse of the good ... ¹³ if you listen to the commandments of the LORD your God, which I charge you today, to observe them carefully, ¹⁴ do not turn aside from any of the words which I command you today, to the right or to the left ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joshua 1:7 NASB*

be strong and very courageous; be careful to do according to all the Torah which Moses my servant commanded you; do not turn from it to the right or to the left

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Torah Teaches “Good and Evil”

Deuteronomy 30:9-10, 15-16 NASB*

⁹ Then the LORD your God will prosper you abundantly in all the work of your hand, in the offspring of your body and in the offspring of your cattle and in the produce of your ground, for the LORD will again rejoice over you for good, just as he rejoiced over your fathers. ¹⁰ If you obey the LORD your God to keep his commandments and his statutes which are written in this scroll of the Torah ... ¹⁵ “See, I have set before you today life and good, and death and evil; ¹⁶ in that I command you today to love the LORD your God, to walk in his ways and to keep his commandments and his statutes and his judgments, that you may live and multiply, and that the LORD your God may bless you in the land where you are entering to possess it.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In the theology of the Torah, the true way to wisdom and discernment between good and evil is found in the Torah, which teaches us how to go straight and not to the “right and left.” The Torah was Israel’s source of wisdom, which was not given to any other nation.

Conclusions About “Knowing Between Right and Left” in Jonah 4:11

Jonah 4:11 has merged the phrases “know between good and evil” with “no turning to the right or left” so that the pagan nations are characterized as those who haven’t been given the special revelation into God’s will that Israel has. And this is precisely what makes the nations the objects of God’s mercy.

Reflection Question

Based on [chapter 4](#) and the ending of Jonah, how do you think the author wants the audience to respond to the book? How can you help those in your context have this same response?

Session 45: Reflecting on the Ending of Jonah

Key Takeaways

- The mercy of God is remarkable. It is given to our enemies and also to us when we struggle with the fact that God loves our enemies.
- The meaning of Jonah is clear, and we can all agree on it no matter our different views about the historical reference of the events in the book.

The Sense of an Ending

“The narrative of Jonah’s story lacks closure, a sense of completion, and a sense that nothing necessary has been omitted from the work. The book ends without a resolution to the major conflict of the narrative’s plot. The reader experiences the greatest sense of closure at the end of the third chapter as Nineveh repents and God forgives. Even the fourth chapter begins by providing closure regarding Jonah’s flight, but the book’s final scene immediately reopens that closure just experienced by the reader. God’s question concludes the book, leaving Jonah’s response in the minds of the reader. This lack of closure at the end of the narrative is a literary device used to involve the reader in the ideological conflict that propels the real plot of the book: Jonah’s sense of justice versus God’s boundless mercy. The final scene blurs the narrative frame, so that the world of the text reaches out and envelops the world of the reader, forcing them to ask whose perspective they will adopt.”

Crouch, Walter B. (1994). “To Question and End, To End and Question: Opening and Closure in the Book of Jonah.” *Sage Journals*, vol. 19, 62. 112.

“[T]he final scene is so skillfully designed that when Jonah insists on Yahweh’s free pity, he cannot really avoid simultaneously conceding to his God the forgiving mercy he has extended to the pagans. But the narrator leaves the readers to draw this harmonizing conclusion themselves. Even the most morosely obstinate of them can hardly do other than—in Jonah’s place—respond with gratitude to their God’s final question.”

Wolff, Hans Walter (1986). [*Obadiah and Jonah: A Commentary*](#). Augsburg Fortress. 88.

“The ‘surprise’ gap at the beginning of the story, with regard to Jonah’s motive for running away, is filled in at the conclusion, when Jonah impeaches the Lord’s grace and compassion as the reason for his flight (4:2), and even more so in the last verse of the book, in which the Lord justifies His decision to show mercy for Nineveh. As Meir Sternberg argues, the impression conveyed by the start of the story is that God is wrathful and punitive. As for Jonah and his flight, we mistakenly believe that the recalcitrant prophet ‘is too tenderhearted to carry a message of doom to a great city. He obviously protests against a wrathful God not with words, like Abraham or Moses or Samuel, but with his feet.’ But the last verses of the book show that we had it backwards: Jonah does not flee because God is a wrathful God, but because He is a merciful God.

The Lord's reaction to the Ninevites' penance—"When God saw what they did, how they turned from their evil way, God repented of the evil which He had said he would do to them; and He did not do it" (3:10)—clearly echoes 'the Lord repented of the evil which he thought to do to his people' (Exod 32:14). Thus the book of Jonah teaches us that the Lord's mercy is not reserved exclusively for 'His people' but extends to all of His creation, including its animals, who (unlike Jonah) are not only obedient agents of his will in this story, but also, along with humans, objects of his mercy."

Shemesh, Yael (2010). "'And Many Beasts' (Jonah 4:11): The Function and Status of Animals in the Book of Jonah." *Journal of Hebrew Scriptures*, vol. 10. 22

You, Jonah,
how low
how deep
will you go
to secure
sleep?

You, Jonah,
how high
will you fare
hoping I
will ignore
you there?

You, Jonah,
how far
will you aim
your mariner
to protect your name
from my claim?

You! Jonah!

And Jonah stalked
to his shaded seat
and waited for God
to come around
to his way of thinking.
And God is still waiting
for a host of Jonahs
in their comfortable houses
to come around
to his way of loving.

Carlisle, Thomas John (1968). [*You! Jonah!*](#) Eerdmans.

Reflection Question

As you ponder the end of Jonah, why do you think the book ends with a question?